

WHILE
WE WERE APART

the early years

KENNY WRIGHT

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THE EARLY YEARS

WHILE WE WERE APART
BOOK 1

KENNY WRIGHT



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PREFACE

I've been writing in the hotwife genre for over a decade, and had the fantasy longer than that. I've written dozens of novels and stories on the subject, and if I may be so bold, am pretty good at spinning the tale.

One thing that I find so interesting is the build up to the act, the origin of the hotwife fantasy. In recent years, this has become its own genre, the “hotpast” story. I've read a few of them and really enjoyed them because it plays not just on the moment, or even the build up, but on what came before. I've touched on a few of these threads before, of course. You can't write a hotwife story and ignore the characters' backgrounds and motivations, what makes them tick and how they got there. Heather's backstory in *Bull's Eye*, of course, and more recently, *The Blonde in 3C* (check the back of this book for more about those), were examples of these.

Another genre that seems to be coming into the light more in the erotica world is the slow burn story—kind of the opposite of what *Penthouse Letters* used to do. We go deep into the characters even before the action happens. I enjoy these, but the problem is that many times, they meander a little too much. Backstory is good. Character exploration is great. But we're also all here for the action, right? Striking that balance is important.

That's where the book you now hold in your hands comes in.

While We Were Apart is a book that doesn't jump to the end. It's my take on a slow-burn origin story that follows Nathan and Morgan from their years in college on into their lives. I've written this one in vignettes, each focusing on a pivotable moment in their lives. Part hotwife, part hotpast, this book is a long exploration of a relationship that grows as much as the characters grow. It's not written as a quick hotwife story, but for those who stick with it—including the occasional frustration at what younger people sometimes do in their early 20s—you'll be thoroughly rewarded.

This one was written and posted over many months on my Patreon. This version, like all books I've written this way, takes into account many of the suggestions of my readers there. In fact, the entire shape of these three vignettes was changed from my original concept—and for the better.

It's also a living story. New vignettes are being written, and Morgan and Nathan continue to experience new things. What you're reading is just the beginning—quite literally.

If you've made it this far in the preface, thanks for reading, and what are you waiting for? Get on with the show!

PART I

SENIOR YEAR

“Hey, stranger.”

They say that absence makes the heart grow fonder.

“Morgan!”

Those same people say nothing about the effect it has on jealousy or insecurity or doubt.

“You’re here,” I said.

And they definitely didn’t say anything about how awkward the absence makes things.

“Hey, Nathan. You going to invite me in?” Morgan asked. She looked the same as ever—same lean body, same flowing, chocolate brown hair, same radiant smile. “Or do you have a new girlfriend in there?”

“New girlfriend?” But my brain couldn’t reconcile what was happening. I hadn’t seen Morgan in person in over a year. “No new girlfriend.”

She stared at me, shifting a little. This wasn’t how I’d imagined this reunion. In my head, there were fewer words, more kissing, and definitely clothes being torn off. She thrust a thumb over her shoulder. “This a bad time? Seriously, you have someone back there? I... won’t be upset.”

I heard the hesitation. “No, there’s no one else. I’m just... it feels like it’s been forever.”

“Too long.” Morgan seemed over the awkwardness and the waiting. Like the first time we kissed, she seized the initiative, stepping up to me, pulling me close, and pressing her lips to mine.

The kiss was clumsy for only a moment. It wobbled like a baby bird falling from the nest, and then it soared. She wrapped her arms around my neck and pressed her tongue into my mouth. I ran my hands down her back, and could feel the heat of her skin beneath her tank top. I grabbed her ass, encased in a pair of skintight jeans.

It was all so familiar, yet also, weirdly, excitingly, so new.

“Now that’s a better greeting,” Morgan said, breaking the kiss, but keeping her arms around me.

I nuzzled her nose. “Missed you,” I whispered.

“I missed you so much.” She pressed her hips against mine. “And it feels like someone else missed me. Which way to your bedroom?”

“Uh, it’s that one.” I pointed to the left door. Funny to think that I’d been living here a year and yet Morgan had never seen it. “Want a tour?”

“After.” She dragged me into my room. “I see you’re as tidy as ever.”

She was looking at my unmade bed, at the clothing strewn all over the floor and the empty water glasses beside my bed. “If you’d called to tell me that you were coming...”

“Oh, I hope I’ll be coming soon.” She laughed, pulling her tank top off and tossing it onto my unkempt bed. Her lacy black bra almost distracted me away from her belly piercing.

“That’s new.” I stared at the silver bar, studded on either end with white, glittering stones.

She ran her hand down her flat tummy and fingered the jewelry. “Thought I’d try it. You like it?”

“It’s very sexy.” I ran my eyes over her whole body. “Everything about you is sexy. Did England make you sexier?”

She laughed again—light as a caress. Familiar, too. “You’re so silly.”

“You still love me for it?” I pulled her close and kissed her.

“Always,” she said. “I’ll always love you.”

Finally, the last bits of that awkwardness were gone. We made it to the bed, kissing and exploring one another. I popped open her jeans, helping her wiggle out. My breath caught when our combined efforts revealed a black thong that matched her bra.

“I hope this isn’t reunion lingerie. I’m liking the new you.”

“Well, it *is* reunion lingerie,” she said. “But I’ve had a change of heart with things riding up my butt.”

I had a brief, but vivid image of some muscled stud driving his cock into Morgan’s ass. It came out of nowhere, driven by her unintentional innuendo. I couldn’t let it pass. “Is that so? Now this is going to be a *homecoming*.”

“What?” And then she got it, her face turning red. “Oh, I didn’t mean...” She demurred, but only slightly. “I didn’t know you wanted to try that.”

“I don’t,” I blurted, although it was only partially true. I’d just never considered it a real possibility.

“Okay,” she said. The awkwardness was creeping back.

I pulled her close and kissed her again. I ran my hands over her ass, confirming that her panties did plunge between her cheeks. “But I think it’s hot as hell seeing you in a thong.”

We made out some more, falling onto my bed, our urgency rising together. I pulled off my shirt, and she touched my chest as if trying to remember if I was this muscled before. I wasn’t. “Dan gave me a few pointers at the gym,” I said.

Those eyes lingered on my pecs before she glanced up at me with a bright smile. “I’ll have to thank him next time I see him.” She kissed my chest. “Very nice, Nathan.” Another kiss. “*Very* nice,” she purred.

Down she went, unzipping my jeans and fishing out my cock. Wrapping her fingers around the base, she studied my erection, like she was reminding herself what my dick looked like. Like she had to compare it with all the other dicks she'd seen while studying abroad.

The jealousy set in like claws along the insides of my gut, tearing my insides to pieces. I felt sick. I felt pathetic. And yet, when Morgan looked up at me, her dark eyes locking onto mine, and took me into her mouth, I felt so fucking good.

"Oh, fuck," I groaned. I wasn't going to last. It had been too long with only my hand to give me pleasure, and her wet mouth felt too good. I had to shut my eyes and try to will myself not to come as she bobbed along my dick.

But after about a minute I couldn't take any more. "Morgan..." I croaked. "I need you."

She popped off me, smiling. "Not going to argue with that." She worked my jeans off, but even the image of my dick bouncing obscenely before her was too hot.

I flipped her onto her back, pants around my knees, and pulled her thong to the side just enough to thrust home. I missed, naturally, drawing a giggle from Morgan. "Here, let me help."

She whipped off her panties in one fluid motion and took me into her hand, guiding me to her gash... which was shaved bare. Like, totally bare. Like, slippery-smooth-along-my-cock bare.

And then I was sinking into all that gloriously soft skin.

"Uh, God," she groaned. "Oh, Nathan... fuck me... fuck me..." She held me, raking her fingers through my hair, gasping with each thrust.

"Morgan, you're so sexy," I whispered. "I'm not... gonna... last..."

"Come, Baby. Don't hold back." Her hand tightened in my hair. I kissed her neck and breathed in her familiar scent. She was home. She was back. "Give me your come, Baby. I want to feel it."

I couldn't have denied her even if I'd tried. Her order seared through me. I slammed my cock to the root, my balls tight, my breath held. Time stood still—a microcosm of our year apart. It lost meaning. It was limbo.

And then she was back, and I was coming and everything felt whole again.

I BASKED in the glow of my orgasm, staring at the ceiling, Morgan's warm, lean body at my side. It had been six months of nothing but self-pleasure, a drought that I was beginning to think would last forever. And yet here she was, Morgan, my college girlfriend, back like nothing had changed.

When she got into the study abroad program in London for her third year of college, we kind of decided to break up. Or maybe I had mostly pushed it, because I was a dumb college kid who didn't know how good I had it until it was gone.

It was a friendly breakup. She told me that she'd be back in a year and asked if I'd have her when she came home. That was the type of person she was, and I only realized how deeply I'd fallen in love with her when we were separated by eight time zones.

We mostly emailed. The time difference was brutal, but it wasn't just that. At first, I was busy trying to be the single guy I thought I wanted to be around campus. When that got old and I got to missing her, phone calls were just so awkward.

I figured there were other guys. I worried about calling her some afternoon and another dude picking up. It was hypocritical, for sure, since I wasn't exactly celibate, but whatever.

But the reality was much harder to deal with than hypotheticals. Lying there next to a mostly naked Morgan, I realized that she'd definitely been sexually active over there. She didn't shave her bush or start wearing thongs

to give her an edge when writing papers. It was all going to take time to wrap my head around.

Or I should have given it time, anyway. My dumb self decided to dive right in at the time.

Rolling onto my side—after finally kicking off my boxers and jeans—I ran my hand along her body. Had her skin always been this soft and unblemished? I traced the small cluster of moles just beneath her ribcage. That was familiar. Lower, the navel piercing wasn't.

“So who do I have to thank for this?” I pinched the piercing, the metal warm and inviting.

Glancing up at Morgan, I found her staring at me, studying me with those dark eyes. “You can thank me, of course.”

“You did it for yourself?”

“Who else would I have done it for?”

Somewhere in the back of my head, an alarm bell began to bleat. “Some good looking Englishman with a fondness for piercings?”

Morgan's laugh was pure and genuine. “You're right. I did take out all my other piercings before flying back. I didn't think you'd like my triple brow rings.”

“Probably not my taste.” I laughed along with her, but it didn't feel great. I moved my hand lower. “And how about this?” I asked, running the back of my hand over her bald mound. Like the rest of her, her skin was so amazingly soft. “I definitely want to thank the guy responsible for this change of style.”

“We really doing this, Nathan?” She wasn't being defensive. I didn't feel her body stiffen, and she definitely wasn't pulling away. It was a real question, asked by someone who knew me better than I did. I took her point—I didn't really want to know.

But I also heard her answer—there was definitely a guy who got her to shave her box.

“I like it.” I fingered her clit. She shivered with pleasure. “I think you should keep it like this.”

Morgan smirked. “Of course you do.”

“You know, just in case you go back to visit and see...whoever. Wouldn’t want to disappoint.”

She was already shaking her head before I finished the sentence. “I’m not going back.” She scooped up to me until her breasts touched my chest. “I came home because I missed the fuck out of you, you idiot.”

“Sounds like you really missed me—”

She shut me up with a hard kiss. Because I was a dumbass, I almost kept on arguing, but Morgan and her kisses were a compelling reason to shut up. So I did.

When she went back down on me, though, even after I’d fucked her, the insecurities were back. She’d definitely never taken me back in her mouth after sex, and I’d never asked. She’d never tasted herself that way. Now, there was no hesitation.

She even brushed her hair out of her face so she could watch me as she bobbed up and down my length. I wondered if she’d been with guys bigger than me. The speculation hit me with a rush of adrenaline, jealousy so real it tasted like battery acid. My head spun. My cock swelled right along with it.

It was hard to watch Morgan swallow more and more of my dick and *not* think about her doing that with some Englishman issuing instructions in a boarding school accent.

‘That’s it. Keep your eyes on me and relax your throat. Take me deeper. You can do it, Morgan. That’s just perfect.’

And she did take me deeper than ever before. I felt my dick enter the back of her throat. She swallowed until her lips touched my pubes, then pulled back, gasping for breath.

“You have a nice dick, Nathan.”

“Thanks?” I did my best to *not* think she’d said it the way a wine connoisseur, who’d sampled many different wines, would talk about a surprisingly good table red. I didn’t do well at the “not thinking” part, though.

She straddled me, holding my dick steady as she impaled herself on it, and sighed, her eyes closed, basking in the feeling of me inside of her. I reached up, cupping her tits and thumbing her hard nipples.

“Yes,” she gasped. Languidly, she opened her eyes and looked down at me, seeing me. And that’s when it really hit me. There may have been other guys, but she’d come back to me.

Hands braced on my shoulders, she began to *fuck* me. Had it been like this before? Was this the thrill of a year of absence, or had she learned a few new tricks while we were apart?

She took my right hand from her tit and guided it down between her legs. I took the cue, happy to play with her shaved snatch. She moaned as I thumbed her clit, rising high over me and cupping her own tits together.

Her eyes were closed again, lost in the thoughts of other men? I didn’t wilt. I only thickened. I only rubbed her faster, thrusting up to meet her undulating hips.

“Oh... oh, yes... there... there!”

She folded forward as she came, her long, dark hair spilling around us. Her forehead was clammy and hot as she rested it against mine, her breath a high-pitched staccato. “Oh, fuck, Baby,” she groaned. “Come. Give me your... uhhh!”

I didn’t need to be asked twice. Grabbing her ass, I pulled her body down into me as I erupted for the second time. She shuddered, quaking each time I pulsed inside of her, even after I had nothing left to give.

She collapsed in my arms, sweaty and satisfied.

I wanted to ask her about the guys again, about her experiences. I wanted to know where she’d learned to fuck like that.

It just didn't seem like the right time.

Two weeks later, Morgan gave me a lingering kiss before sauntering away across the grassy quad, her ponytail bouncing, heading for the gym. I couldn't take my eyes off her body, encased in a skin tight pair of gym leggings and a racer back top that showed off her midriff.

"You are so fucking lucky, man." Beside me, my buddy Dan was just as mesmerized. "Love the belly ring."

"Since when were you keeping tabs on Morgan's piercings?"

"Oooh, she have more?"

"No, just... fuck you."

Dan chuckled. "Your girl's hot. I notice things about hot chicks. Like, for example, that ass. In fact, how have I never noticed how incredible it looked before?"

I said, "You were too busy looking at all the other sluts you're banging?"

Dan shrugged. We'd been friends since Freshman year, when we lived on the same hall.

Morgan disappeared around a building, and he glanced back at me, grinning. "It's college, man. Just making the most of it. So you two are back together, just like that?"

"Just like that," I said.

“Like I said, you’re so fucking lucky. She could have met some guy over there in that program with a bigger dick, and then it would have been all over.”

“Morgan’s not like that.”

Dan shook his head. “All chicks are like that, man. Trust me, as a guy with an abnormally large dick, I know.”

“Go fuck yourself, Dan.”

He chuckled at me. “I’d rather fuck your girlfriend.”

This was our way. The banter was normally harmless, but I’d already been struggling with jealousy and emotional insecurity. This shit wasn’t helping.

“I assume you didn’t tell her about Molly?” he asked.

“We were never serious. And I haven’t seen her in, like, months.” I heard the defensiveness even as it emerged from my mouth.

Dan seemed to get a kick out of that. “I take it that’s a ‘no’. Eh, she probably wasn’t totally innocent over there, either.”

It was one thing to speculate in my head. To hear it uttered aloud, however, made me feel ill. “You’re not helping.”

“Oh, come on, Nate. Don’t be a fuckin’ hypocrite. If you can sleep around while Morgan’s a million miles away and you two are on ‘pause’, or whatever, she can, too. No judgment on either of you, and frankly, it’s a good thing. You two work great for each other, so maybe the year apart got all your craziness out.”

“Thanks?” I rose and stretched, checking my watch like I had some place to be. “You’re a really special friend, you know that, Dan?”

He grinned. “I do, in fact, know I’m very special.”

I SHOULD HAVE TALKED to Morgan about all of this. In hindsight, that's the healthiest thing to have done. But I was a 20-year-old college idiot surrounded by other 20-year-old college idiots. So instead, I bottled up all of my insecurities and let them fester inside of me.

After my chat with Dan, I should have gone to class. It's what Morgan, a hard-working student, would have done. On my walk across campus, though, all I could think about was my girlfriend in all her spandex being ogled by guys at the gym, so instead of my plan to head to class, I swung by my place, grabbed my gym bag, and decided to do some recon.

The campus gym was a state-of-the-art affair, built recently on funds generated by our sports program. I spent a lot of hours here, lifting and running and keeping in shape, and knew the place pretty well.

Morgan would be up in the cardio area, where she spent most of the time running and biking, but I still made my careful way through the gym. She knew my schedule and would definitely wonder why I wasn't in class.

I nodded at a few of the guys that I knew there, but didn't stop to chit chat. Walking with determination, I hit the locker rooms to change and then made my careful way up to the cardio machines. I'm not sure what I was expecting to find—I trusted her, of course, and yet here I was, on a spy mission.

Morgan wasn't on any of the treadmills or ellipticals. She wasn't on any of the bikes. She wasn't anywhere in the cardio room. I went from furtively scouting along the edges of the room to boldly walking through. Got a few looks as I did, but Morgan was definitely not there.

I checked the weight machines, where she also did some reps. She wasn't there, either. "Hey, you seen Morgan?" I asked a buddy of mine at last, trying my hardest not to sound like a paranoid boyfriend.

"She's back? Nice! I'll let her know you're looking for her if I see her—"

“No, it’s cool. I just wanted to, um, say hi.” I winced. “Not a big deal. See ya around.”

I turned away, my face burning, my guts twisting into knots. It was like someone had taken a baseball bat to my head. Everything rang and swam and I just couldn’t deal with it. I walked out of there without changing or grabbing my stuff from the locker room, and only realized I’d left it all behind when I got back to my apartment building and realized I didn’t have my keys or phone or anything.

“Fuck,” I groaned. My walk back to the gym was less clouded. I let myself cool off. I probably just missed her. She definitely wasn’t at some guy’s place, her legs spread wide as he drilled her. “Don’t go there.”

The more I thought about it, though, the faster I walked and the more convinced that she was cheating on me. It was totally irrational, and yet by the time I arrived back at the gym, I was as pressurized as an over-pumped keg.

Back at the gym, I did one last sweep of the various rooms—not even bothering to be sneaky anymore. She hadn’t shown up, which wasn’t comforting. I hit the locker room, grabbed my bag, and headed back out...

...when I spotted her. Talking with some guy.

The gut punch felt so real that for a second I thought I’d run into something. I stopped, and someone *did* run into me. “Watch it, asshole,” that someone muttered as they passed by. It barely registered.

Morgan was sitting on the top of one of the picnic benches outside of the gym, and this guy was standing next to her. They were sipping bottles of Gatorade and laughing, and it flipped my whole world upside down.

The guy was exactly the type of guy that I didn’t want talking to my girlfriend. Clean cut and good looking, the dark-haired guy had the confidence and tone to wear a tank top and a pair of gym shorts without feeling self-conscious. I didn’t recognize him, but that was no surprise. The

school population was huge. Whoever he was, Morgan seemed to enjoy his company, which made it so much worse for me.

Now, I'm not some knuckle-dragging, chest-thumping thug. I didn't walk up to them and headbutt him or anything—although I had a few vivid fantasies of doing just that. But I did approach.

Morgan saw me first. I watched for a reaction *very* closely—watched for guilt or nervousness, Did she flinch? Did she look quickly at Mr. Tanktop?

I didn't see any of that. If anything, she had the nerve to look happy to see me. "Oh, hey, Nathan!" And then, processing my presence, added, "Thought you had class?"

"It was just a review," I mumbled. "Who's this?"

Smooth, I thought. *Not paranoid there at all, buddy.*

"Oh, this is Jeremy. Jeremy, this is Nathan."

There was definitely a sizing up that happened when he heard my name. I saw it in the way he looked me over, as if thinking, *So this is the boyfriend*. "Nice to meet you, Nathan."

His handshake also spoke volumes, overgripped and over-firm.

Or maybe that was me doing the overgripping.

"Hey, Jeremy. Sorry to interrupt..."

"Oh, hey, no worries at all," Jeremy said. "We were just catching up on England."

"Jeremy was in the same study abroad program," Morgan explained.

"Ah."

"Morgan talked a lot about you," Jeremy said. "Good to finally put a face to a name."

Oh, she did? I glanced at Morgan, who was beaming at me. I was suddenly very confused by it all. "Cool," I said, hoping that saying it would make me feel it. "Anyway, I'm going to go..." I jerked my thumb towards the gym, like I was just headed there now.

“Right. And I better get home,” Jeremy said. “Need to shower before class. It was good catching up, Morgan. Hope to see you Saturday.”

I waited until he was gone before looking at Morgan. “Saturday?”

“Oh, he’s having a few people over from the program. Like a mini reunion. Want to go?”

No. “Sure, sounds fun.”

“Sweet.” She gave me a hug, squeezing my biceps. “Keep doing what you’re doing. Me likey.”

“Maybe one day, I’ll even have the confidence to pull off a tank top.”

“Oh, please.” Now her laugh was definitely on the hysterical end. “You have nothing to be jealous of.”

“I know.”

But did I?

I always hated the kind of guys who felt like they had some kind of ownership of their girlfriends. They'd drape their arm around her when introducing themselves as if to say, 'This one's mine.' They got jealous for no reason, and angry at her when she talked to some other male.

No, I was the cool boyfriend, the chill boyfriend. She had friends who were guys, that's great. I believed in platonic relationships. Morgan wanted to go study abroad for a year? That's great! No problem. We'll work it out.

Yet now, after Tank Top Jeremy, I was feeling all those Neanderthal man things. I wanted to get my club. I wanted to remind him that she... was... mine.

"Oh, fuck me!"

I wanted to remind Morgan as well.

"You feel so... you feel so... good!"

I had her legs over my shoulders, our fingers entwined above her head as I rolled my hips into her. This wasn't just rabbit fucking. This wasn't just me pounding away. I'd picked up a few tricks of my own and was determined to show off.

"Oh, Nathan, Baby, you feel so... oh!"

My roommate was out at a party, and Morgan and I decided to stay in and watch some TV. It was like old times, before she left—even before we

officially got together. Only this time I could lean over and kiss her. Kissing led to hands roaming to clothes coming off.

I went down on her, worshiping the body I'd missed for so long. I kissed and licked her smooth thighs. I traced the edges of her thong, teasing both of us before pulling the flimsy material to the side and feasting on her bare gash. That was never going to get old, seeing her smooth shaven mound. It was a reminder of our lost year, and a motivator not to lose her.

We moved to the bedroom after I made her scream loud enough that our neighbors definitely heard. I didn't care. Let them hear and be envious.

"Yes, Nate! Fuck me!" Her voice cracked, a whispered-shout that I would never grow tired of. It was all the motivation I would ever need.

"I love you, Morgan." I squeezed her hand as I sank balls deep into her.

"God, I love you too, baby."

When I opened my eyes, she was staring right back up at me, her lashes long, her dark irises hypnotic. Her pussy rippled around my cock as she squeezed me. I'd never felt something like that before.

"I missed this," she said. "I missed you."

It should have been reassuring. Those should have been exactly the right words to ease an agitated ego. But at the time, all I heard was, "*All the guys I fucked in London made me forget all about you!*"

So I folded her legs until they were up around her ears and fucked her in a way that she wouldn't ever forget.

My abs screamed. My arms burned. I pushed. I didn't stop. Morgan didn't want me to stop. She begged me to keep fucking. She gnashed her teeth and rolled from one thrilling orgasm to the next.

"Baby," she gasped. "Are you close? I need you. I... need that come."

I groaned.

"Give me your come!"

My balls tightened.

"Fuck your come into me!"

That was so unlike Morgan. That must have been learned elsewhere.

But holy hell, was it hot. I obeyed, slamming my hips forward and fucking all my come deep inside of her. She writhed beneath me as she came, again, our slick bodies slapping and sliding.

Morgan sighed when I finally released her legs. I flopped beside her, watching her stare at the ceiling with a big, goofy grin. “That was...” She turned to me and finished, “amazing.”

“I missed you, too,” I said lamely.

She giggled. “Well, hold on to that angst, stud. A girl could get used to that.”

If she only knew.

I’D FORGOTTEN ALL about Tank Top Jeremy’s party until Morgan reminded me Saturday afternoon. Or maybe it was more like I was actively pretending it wasn’t going to happen on the off-chance that she’d forget.

“I was thinking we could get dinner up near the Crossing,” Morgan suggested. “Jeremy’s place isn’t far from there. We could walk over after.”

“Right, the party.” And she knew where Jeremy’s house was? Definitely an irrational thought—of course she had to know if she was invited—but disconcerting anyway. “Yeah, that seems like a good plan. Like a date.”

She beamed at me. “A date. Love it.”

“That mean you’ll wear a slinky dress for me?”

“I think I could manage something...”

And that’s how we ended up at a party of strangers with Morgan wearing the kind of little, black dress that she almost never wears. I was loving it while we were in the restaurant. Less so as we walked up to Jeremy’s house, the party already in full swing.

I didn't recognize anyone. Seemed that Jeremy, and the small contingent from our school who'd studied abroad, traveled in different social circles than I did. Many recognized Morgan, though, and it was so hard to resist being that guy who puts his arm around her as I walked up.

Because I *wasn't* that guy.

"Cute dress, Mo," said a bleached blonde with a smoky voice. She wore a powder blue dress even tighter and shorter than Morgan's, showing off a fit, curvy body and a pair of tits that drew my eyes.

Thankfully, Morgan didn't seem to notice my stare. She beamed at the blonde. "Thanks! Love yours, too."

"Let's catch up later," the other woman said as we entered the house.

"Mo?" I asked when we were out of earshot.

"Oh, that's Cassidy," she answered, as if that were explanation enough for the nickname. I let it go. I was determined to let all of this go. I was the cool boyfriend.

We were enveloped into the house party. Morgan waved hi to seemingly everyone, sometimes introducing me, sometimes not, but always as "this is Nathan," not "this is my boyfriend Nathan." Not that she had to do that. Not that I was so fragile that I needed that.

Beer helped convince me that the above was true. At first, anyway, and then, as alcohol goes, it started to convince me otherwise—why *didn't* she introduce me as her boyfriend? Was she embarrassed? Did she want to keep her options open?

We found Jeremy on the back deck, next to the keg, chatting with a small group of people. He'd exchanged his tank top for a plain, black t-shirt that still managed to show off his arms and broad shoulders.

"Morgan! You made it!" he greeted, spotting my girlfriend. His eyes skipped over her body, albeit briefly, checking her out before turning the charm on. "And Nathan. Good to see you again, buddy."

Again, the hard handshake. Again, my probably misplaced dislike for this man. “Hey, Jeremy.” I looked around. Some people were playing beer pong in the backyard. The deck alone was packed with people. “Quite the gathering.”

“You know how it goes. One guy invites some friends, who invite other friends. I probably know, like, half the people here.” He spotted someone else and nodded a greeting. To me, it appeared that he knew everyone.

At some point, I got separated from Morgan. I went inside to use the restroom, and when I came out, she wasn’t on the back deck any longer. The paranoia was real, but I wasn’t going to be the clingy boyfriend. I was going to give her space and be cool about it.

I pumped myself some more beer and pretended that everything was cool, even as I freaked out inside.

“I think you may have over-pumped there,” someone said, pointing at my Solo cup of foam. “Here, let me...”

A cute blonde with nerd-girl glasses took over the keg pump as I dumped the contents over the side of the deck. “Ah, thanks.”

As she pumped, despite her innocent look, my mind went straight to a handjob. The girl’s smile broadened, like she knew what I was thinking. I needed to refocus. “So what’s your connection here?”

“Oh, I know Jeremy. We did this study abroad thing. You?”

“I came with Morgan. She’s my girlfriend.” That felt desperate and awkward. “I’m Nathan.”

“Oh, so you’re Morgan’s boyfriend.” I wasn’t sure, but it sounded like there was something loaded in that statement, although she didn’t seem like the judgmental type.

“Yeah, although we sort of took a break last year.” I felt like I was just digging my hole deeper and couldn’t figure out how to stop. “For obvious reasons.”

“Right.” She took my cup from me and filled it, managing the foam better than I had. “I’m Reagan.” She pushed her glasses up the bridge of her nose before adding, somewhat embarrassed, “Yes, after the president.”

“Nice to meet you, Reagan.” I took the cup of beer, and she began refilling her own. “So you knew Morgan? In London?”

“Sort of. She hung out with a different crowd.”

“Got it.” My blood pressure rose. My palms grew clammy. I knew what I wanted to ask and the beer—that was already half empty and definitely not my first—tore my inhibitions away. “So what kind of crowd?”

Reagan’s smile put me more off-balance. “Checking up on your girl?”

“What? No, I...” I scratched the back of my neck, surprised that it wasn’t actually on fire. “Fine, yes. I’m curious.”

“Heh. I don’t blame you. I’d be curious too if I had a girlfriend who looked like her and had spent the last year away.” We drifted away from the keg and back into the house. “So before I get into that, were you really on a break?”

There was a lot to unpack in that question, but I was too amped up to unpack any of it. “Yeah. I know she saw a guy or two.”

Conceptually, thinking that was one thing. Saying it to another person was much heavier.

Reagan didn’t immediately correct me. In fact, her introspective nod was like being pushed off the side of a building. Flailing, stomach heaving, I said, “I just am curious if she, like, dated a bunch of guys or... you know...”

Reagen seemed to see more in me than I wanted to share. “No, nothing like that. Don’t worry, your girlfriend didn’t turn into some raging slut out there.”

“But there were guys?”

She hesitated before answering, and the hesitation dropped like a sack of rocks in my stomach. “I don’t know. Like I said, different circles. She

knew a bunch of the Europeans, and they went out a lot. When we were in class, Morgan was always heads down.”

“Yeah, that sounds like her,” I said.

“Honestly, it was hot. Beauty and brains. I have kind of a girl-crush on your girlfriend.”

Another young woman interrupted us. “Is Reggie going on about Morgan again?”

“Beth, this is Nathan, Morgan’s *boyfriend*.” Reagan elbowed her friend, Beth, who was tall, lean, and alluring. She had a bob of dark hair that just reached her chin, large, blue eyes, and a crooked smile that made it seem like she got a kick out of everything around her.

“And I’m Beth, Reagan’s *girlfriend*,” Beth said. She did the thing that I’d resisted so much with Morgan—she put her arm possessively around the much more petite blonde. “I kind of wish those two did hook up. Would have gotten it out of Reagan’s system.” Beth looked at me. “He knows what I mean.”

“Beth...” Reagan warned.

“Have you seen Morgan?” I asked.

“Nope,” Beth said. When she stared at me, I felt naked. “Maybe check Jeremy’s bedroom?”

My chest tightened up. Bile caught in the back of my throat. “Beth!” Reagan objected. “Not cool.”

Beth shrugged. “I saw them head that way. Don’t shoot the messenger.” She looked right at me. “Better hurry.”

Reagan hooked her arm into her girlfriend’s. “You’ve had too much to drink. Come on, let’s go home.” To me, with more sincerity than her girlfriend, she said, “I’m sorry. Ignore her, she just gets jealous.”

Over her shoulder, Beth added, “And horny! I always get so horny when I’m jealous.” With a wink to me, she let herself be guided away.

I refilled my beer before deciding to ascend the stairs. I wore my fatalism like a lead jacket. Each step felt like a workout, and the stairs seemed to stretch on into infinity. “Hey, which one’s Jeremy’s?” I asked a couple flirting at the top of the stairs.

The guy shrugged, annoyed, but the girl pointed to the door at the end of the hall—the *closed* door. I nearly vomited. Instead, I floated to it, my senses dulled, my heart in my throat. I heard a giggle through the door, followed by a man’s laugh. My face burned. I didn’t knock, but I sure as hell hesitated outside of that door.

I almost left. I almost went home. This was the end of it. It was one thing to fuck around when she’s a million miles away. Entirely a different thing to do it while we were at the same fucking party!

The lance of anger gave me all the courage I needed. I opened the door, swinging it open so hard that it crashed against a dresser, rattling some drinks. The people inside jumped. “The fuck!?” Jeremy shouted, jumping to his feet.

He wasn’t naked. His dick didn’t swing out, wet from fucking my girlfriend. The scene before me caught me off-guard.

Morgan was there. So was that blonde, Cassidy, and a couple other people that I didn’t know. They were all seated on the floor, a hookah in between them, putting out some sweet smell.

“Close the door, man!” someone said.

Morgan looked up at me, her eyes dilated. She smiled warmly and held out her hand. “There you are, Nathan. Come on, join us.”

Jeremy looked a little less pleased with my arrival, but didn’t say anything. I also wasn’t in the mood for this. Any of it. I looked around at the bunch like I’d walked in on some cult, and shook my head at Morgan. “I’m ready to go.”

“You sure?” Jeremy said. “This is some good hash.”

I never looked away from Morgan, doing everything I could to communicate that I really, really didn't want to stay. "I'm good."

She got it. Rising, she didn't offer me drugs again. She pressed herself close and said huskily, "Take me home, Nathan."

I didn't look back into the room. I didn't look back the whole way out of the house. I was an adventurer escaping the crumbling temple. I had my prize. I had my treasure.

I had completely forgotten that I wasn't the kind of guy who treated their girlfriends like things that could be owned. Guess I wasn't the cool boyfriend, after all.

"DID YOU FUCK JEREMY LAST YEAR?"

That was the question I should have asked. It certainly rode me the whole way back to my place, a fat devil on my shoulder, jealousy and curiosity in my ear. But I didn't ask. I chickened out. This was the moment, and I couldn't.

Instead, Morgan pressed us into that territory. "You're not a fan of Jeremy," she stated.

"Nah, he's okay." I had no idea why I said it. Ego or pride or something equally stupid, I didn't want to admit the guy got under my skin, maybe?

Morgan wasn't buying it. Even in her stoned and drunk state, she saw through me. "I get it. I thought that he was an asshole when I first met him, too."

"I didn't say he was an asshole."

She giggled, leaning on me, squeezing my arm. "I know. *I did*, goof! He's definitely the guy who likes to be the center of attention, but like all of us, there's more to him than just that."

"Well, that's good." Sarcasm snuck into my tone. Morgan snorted.

“I’m not asking you to be his friend.” We’d arrived at my place. She stopped in front of it, turning to me and taking my hands in hers. “Thanks for coming to the party with me. It was good to catch up with my friends there.”

“Of course. It was pretty fun.”

Morgan stepped closer. She was so beautiful. Her dark eyes wide and earnest, her hair falling in soft waves around her face, casting it in enough shadow to be mysterious, I wondered how the hell I ended up with her.

“I’m sorry we got split up,” she whispered. “I hope you’re not too upset.”

I shook my head. “It’s fine. I can take care of myself.”

“Yes, I know.” Closer still, I felt her breasts on my chest. “But tonight, I get to take care of you.”

“Oh... kay.” Even after all the time together, she still could take my breath away.

The spell broke with her giggle. She pushed a strand of hair over her ear, smiled, and turned away. She was sweet Morgan again, the girl who’d left for London. “Come on, take me to bed.”

“Ah! Ah! Fuck me! Ah!”

The cries drew me deeper into the house. Everyone I passed gave me a pitying look, whispering to one another and shaking their heads sadly. I floated past them, down the hall with all the doors.

The man’s grunts were now audible through the door at the end of the hall, the unmistakable sounds of sex assaulting my ears. My gut churned. My skin crawled. “Ah! Ah!”

“Harder! Fuck me... harder!” Morgan was moaning for it. Begging for it. “Fuck it into me!”

“That’s my girl,” Jeremy said. And I was inside the room all of a sudden. Morgan was on her back, naked, as Jeremy plowed in bare snatch. He looked at me, not surprised at all to see me there. “She loves it rough, man. Fuckin’ can’t get enough.”

“Told you they were in Jeremy’s bedroom,” someone said beside me—Beth, from the party, the lesbian dating Reagan. Tall and willowy, she squeezed my arm and added, “Reagan tells me they spent most of their time last year in Jeremy’s bedroom. Didn’t they, Reggie?”

Beth looked down. I followed my eyes, and there was her girlfriend, the cute blonde on her knees, still wearing her glasses, sucking my cock. It felt

incredible, wet and firm, her tongue slithering back and forth. I pushed my hips forward, and Reagan choked, but didn't stop blowing me.

"Watch them," Beth prompted. "Watch how they love to fuck."

I glanced back at the bed. Morgan was riding Jeremy now, facing me, her naked breasts bouncing. She had one hand in her hair, the other dancing between her legs, fingering her bare shaven twat.

"She did that for me," Jeremy taunted. "She shaved for me."

"Oh, fuck," I groaned.

Beth leaned close. "She did so many things for him," she whispered. "But hey, you were on a break, right?"

"Oh—AH!" And I was coming, hips forward, cock slamming into the back of—

—Morgan's throat.

The dream melted away. It was early morning. Morgan had cast the sheets away so I could see her waking me with a morning blowjob. The dream still haunted me, but I was already forgetting the details. Only the sensations of extreme jealousy and extreme arousal remained as I spewed into Morgan's mouth.

She swallowed, her eyes on me as she drank down my come. Pulling up, she beamed at me. "Happy birthday." Her voice was so sexy, husky and raw from the blowjob. "You must have been having some dream. I swear, you were moaning before I even went down there."

"I... don't remember." *Hey, you were on a break, right?* Who'd said it? Had that been part of the dream?

"Think you can get it back up?" Morgan crawled over me. She was naked, her skin warm from being in bed all night. She was an inspiration, her runner's body taut and smooth, pale, unblemished.

"I think I can manage," I said, never going fully soft.

She slid my cock along her sex, which she continued to keep bare. She was wet, and it took only a few humps and I was once again thick and ready

for her.

With a shift, she sank over me with a sigh. “Mmm, that’s nice...”

Since the start of school, over the last month, we just fell back into our relationship without really officially declaring it, picking up where we left off before she studied abroad. I tried to play it cool, to pretend that it was all the same. But it wasn’t.

Thing was, Morgan had never felt out of my league before. She was always attractive, but acted like she didn’t realize it. She was a jeans-and-t-shirt girl, both before and after—the kind of girl who got away with putting on as little makeup as she could. Morgan put study first, play second.

She still did all that. Other than the one party at Jeremy’s, she spent her Saturday nights in the library. When we hung out, it was with me and Dan and a few of our other friends. But now that she was back, there was something about her that was... intimidating.

Like she was cooler than me now. Like maybe she was settling for me. We’d go out with friends and she was more at ease. When I saw her talking to another guy, she didn’t seem like the shy girl I’d sat down next to in History of Jazz.

And definitely like when she rode my cock, her body rippling over me, more into the sex than I swear she had been before.

My insecurity grew. Our relationship was doomed, I told myself. That’s probably why, for my 21st birthday gathering in early October, I invited—

“Molly? Why did you invite her, man?” We were in the backroom of Murphy’s Pub, where Dan knew the manager. The gathering was small, unlike Jeremy’s big house party earlier in the year, but also more my speed, which also made Molly’s appearance even more flagrant.

Which is why Dan was looking at me like I’d gotten my face tattooed. “Are you a fucking idiot?”

Molly was one of the girls that I’d hooked up with, on and off, when Morgan was traipsing around the UK with Jeremy. Molly was my main

hookup, if I was honest, aside from a few random drunken one-offs that I barely remembered. She was hot, fun, slightly crazy, and would have made a great girlfriend. Yet the more I was with her, the more I pined for Morgan, until I finally had to break it off with her.

That was about half a year ago. Half a year of being good and resisting temptation. Of waiting for Morgan to return. And now, because I'm a dumbass and couldn't get Jeremy's party out of my head, I'd invited Molly to my own, and she'd come, looking just as hot in her dress and all that red hair.

I shrugged. "Ran into her at The Caf. She remembered that my birthday was coming up..."

"And you thought that remembering your birthday was such a kindness that you fucking invited her here?"

"Sure, why not?"

Dan squinted at me. "If you don't know why not, then you really are a fucking idiot." He glanced at Molly again. "At least she brought a hot friend."

He wasn't wrong. I didn't know the blonde at Molly's side, but she was cute going on sexy—especially in the short skirt and tight blouse she wore. In fact, both of them were dressed for a night out, threads designed to show skin and entice—a far cry than the casual clothes most of us wore.

Dan wasn't going to let it go so easily, though. "But dude, this is a bad idea..."

"It's fine." I glanced nervously at Morgan, chatting away with a few of our friends. "It'll all be fine."

"I'D LIKE TO PROPOSE A TOAST." The small gathering turned to Molly, who was holding a shot glass up. We were well into the night, and things

were starting to get sloppy. “To the birthday boy, such a good guy—kind and sweet and thoughtful, not to mention pretty fucking hot—”

“Okay, Molly,” Dan put an arm around her. “I think you’ve had too—”

“Don’t touch me!” Molly shrieked. She raised the shot glass, its contents sloshing out over her wrist. “Nate, I just want to say, I hope she gave you as good a birthday BJ as I did—”

“Okay, show’s over,” Dan said, now forcefully removing Molly. The blonde who’d come in with her, Denise, helped usher her out as the room tried to move on.

“Well, that was awkward,” I said. Some laughed nervously. I didn’t want to look at Morgan, but like someone passing a car wreck on the highway, I couldn’t stop myself.

When I saw her standing there, her arms crossed beneath her breasts and her eyes flat, forcing a smile, I realized that the car wreck was me.

I went to her, and everyone around us seemed to give us distance. Before I could come up with something to say, Morgan spoke first. “So that was Molly.”

“Uh... yeah.” Morgan had heard of Molly?

“She’s pretty.”

“Pretty drunk.” My joke fell flat.

“Why did you invite her?”

Of course there was no good answer to that question. Why did she invite me to Jeremy’s party just after coming home? Why didn’t we just hash this whole thing out?

“I don’t know,” I said lamely. “I didn’t think it would be like that.”

“Nathan, you...” Morgan didn’t look sad, exactly. It was worse. She looked disappointed. “You shouldn’t have done that.”

She was right, of course. Not that I said that. I was too busy sizing up my foot for my mouth. “Jeremy didn’t seem to have a problem inviting you to his party.”

“What?” Morgan blinked. “What are you implying?”

“Look, I’m not upset. Just seems a little hypocritical is all.”

“Oh, right, because you invited a girl you fucked last year to a small gathering of friends for your birthday party, just like Jeremy invited a girl he fucked to a giant house party?”

All I heard in that statement, mostly, was ‘girl he fucked.’

“So you did fuck him?”

“Ugh! You don’t even understand why I’m upset, do you?”

“You’re jealous?”

“You...” She took a deep breath. “Forget it. You’re drunk, and I’m leaving. Happy birthday, Nathan. Call me when you’ve sobered up.”

I watched her walk out of my life, too drunk to see the tears shimmering in her eyes, too riled up to know that I needed to follow. Dan wasn’t there, either, to set me straight, still off somewhere dealing with my other mess. So instead, I turned back to my friends. “Who wants to buy me another drink?”

GIRL HE FUCKED... giant house party... check Jeremy’s room...

I was still buzzing when I woke the next morning, alone in my own bed, with almost no recollection of the night before. Other than that I’d had way too much to drink, and now I had to—

Vomit! I raced to the toilet and hurled into the basin just in time, bile pouring out my mouth and nostrils. I felt better after that, but still had a splitting headache.

“I will never drink again,” I croaked to myself, forcing myself to drink a glass of water.

It was around this point that some of last night returned. I’d had an argument with Morgan over... Molly? Because I’d invited Molly to my

party. Fuck me.

I checked my phone, disappointed that Morgan hadn't texted. I put on some clothes, brushed my teeth, and headed out to her place. This was an apology that needed to be done in person.

On the way there, of course, in the cool morning air, another possibility occurred to me—that I'd walk in on Morgan in bed with someone else. It was the gym paranoia all over again—or that feeling of walking down the hall in Jeremy's house. I knew it was silly, but the closer I got to her place, the more convinced that I became.

I didn't barge in. I couldn't. I didn't have a key. But I did knock hard, like I was serving a warrant, and when no one immediately answered, I knocked even harder.

"Okay, okay, fuck!" someone shouted from the other side.

Morgan's roommate, Nitika, answered, looking grumpy and disheveled from sleep. "What the fuck, man, you know what time it is?"

"10:30? Doesn't seem that early."

Nitika rolled her eyes. "You're looking for Morgan. She's not here."

My gut bottomed out. "What?"

Nitika shrugged.

"Did she come home last night?"

"Uh oh. Trouble in paradise."

"Just tell me, Nitika. Did she even come back here?"

Nitika's smile was malice. She didn't like me all that much. I'd later learn that she was casual friends with Molly, but at the time I had no clue. "You know? I can't remember. You should ask her?"

And with that, she shut the door in my face.

I wandered outside, untethered—like a piece of trash blown loose from an overstuffed garbage can. I definitely felt like trash.

I'd felt like this one other time—last Valentine's Day. I was out with Molly, and she was doing everything right, and it should have been great.

But it wasn't, because she wasn't Morgan, and maybe I'd never be with Morgan again. I had the absurd urge to buy a plane ticket and fly to her, only to realize that it was also Valentine's Day over there, and she was probably with some stud, and I'd just make a fool of myself. Also, I couldn't come close to affording a plane ticket to England.

Wouldn't take a big purchase now, though, and if she'd gone somewhere, I had a pretty good idea where.

"WELL, THIS IS A SURPRISE." Jeremy opened the door as wide as his wide smile. "Nathan, to what do I owe the honor?"

He had a polo shirt stretched tight over his broad chest and a pair of jeans designed to look worn, but probably cost more than my whole wardrobe.

"I'm looking for Morgan," I said.

"And you think she's here?" I couldn't tell if that was a smirk, or just the way his face always looked.

"Let's cut the bullshit," I said. Adrenaline surged. It was all I could do to keep my voice even. "I know all about you two."

"Do you now? What is it, exactly, that you know?"

I wanted to punch him. I didn't. I'm not a total barbarian. "Look, it's fine. Whatever. We were apart last year. But not anymore. She's mine, and you need to stay away from her."

"This is my house," he said, spreading his hands wide, palms towards me. "Sounds like this is a conversation you need to have with her?"

"So she is here." I advanced.

"No," he said, and there was command in his voice. He shook his head, forcing a smile all over again. "Man, you've got this all wrong, Nathan." The disdain for me as he said my name was as clear as spit in the eye. "I

have no clue what she's doing with you. A girl like that could have anyone. Believe me, watching her this last year, I know." He let that revelation sink in like a knife in the back. "Nothing I've seen here makes me think that you're the one."

"You can go to hell," I spat, knowing how childish it sounded.

Jeremy just chuckled. His focus shifted past me, over my shoulder. "Told you he was here," he said—not to me. I knew who, and my body sank. There, over my shoulder, Morgan was walking up the sidewalk.

"Nathan, why did you come here?" Morgan asked, although I could tell that she knew the reason.

"Just... looking for you." I turned, even though I didn't want to. There she stood, beautiful and tired and disappointed all at once.

"I'm here. Jeremy texted."

"Ah." Fuck, this wasn't good.

"Come on, let's go for a walk. I think we need to talk through some things," she said.

It was all so reasonable. This was the best that I could have hoped for, considering the reasons, and yet all I could think about was how humiliating that this was happening in front of Jeremy. I didn't need to look at him to see his smug smile.

I raked my fingers through my hair. "You know what?" My voice shook. "Forget it. He's right." The battery acid taste was back. I felt like vomiting all over again. "I don't deserve you."

"Nathan—" she started.

But I was on a roll, determined to destroy everything I could. "I'll see you around, Morgan."

And then I did the dumbest thing in my life. I walked away.

I'm not sure what I was expecting. For Morgan to chase after me? For Jeremy to stop me and tell me that I was being an idiot? For me to come to my senses and turn and say I was all wrong?

Instead, I kept walking... walking... walking until it was too late. When I did turn to look back, the door was closed, neither Jeremy nor Morgan standing there waiting. Probably already in the house, Jeremy taking advantage of his vulnerable "friend."

I felt loss and regret. I felt my whole world blowing away, like I'd torn my life into little pieces and tossed them into the wind. Maybe I should have turned around and marched back up to Jeremy's. I don't know. The prospect of dealing with his smug smile was too much.

I found Dan at last. He was eating at the Caf, far less hung over than me. "You look like shit, my friend," he said over a bowl of Lucky Charms. "How late did you stay out last night?"

I shrugged. "Where did you go?"

"Well, after Denise and I finished dealing with the trainwreck you and Molly caused, we kind of didn't see much of a reason to go back to the party." He stared at me, and I caught his meaning.

"She was a cute blonde."

“Not natural,” he confessed. “Although who cares when she can suck a dick like that?”

“Sounds like you’re in love.” I fell into the seat across from him. “I broke up with Morgan.”

The spoon of cereal actually fell out of his hand, splashing across the table. “You... what?”

I groaned. “Just now. I went to Jeremy’s—”

“Who’s Jeremy?”

“Guy from the study abroad program. Pretty sure they hooked up.”

“And she was there with him?” Dan pressed.

“No, but I thought she was. Guess he texted her. She showed up later.”

“Okay,” he said slowly. “Still not getting why you broke up.”

“Because she was going to hook up with him eventually,” I said. “Because she deserves a guy like that.”

Dan blinked. “Like what?”

“I don’t know. Like... someone good looking who’s going to graduate and make a lot of money and throw fancy parties and shit.”

Dan rubbed his eyes. “You think Morgan wants to marry a... a fuckin’ future lobbyist? Because I don’t think we’re talking about the same girl.”

He did make sense. Where was he when I needed him this morning? “No, that’s not what I meant.”

“Then what do you mean? And why the hell did you break up with the best thing to ever happen to you?”

“Because it was inevitable.” I said it with enough rage that Dan finally backed off. “Maybe she won’t end up with Jeremy, but I don’t think she’ll end up with me.”

“That’s horseshit, man.” Dan looked frustrated, but also softened his tone when he saw my jaw set. “You two were great—*are* great. I only joke that she’s out of your league. She’s not. She’s hot, yes, but she’s not hot in the way that... like Rachel is.” Rachel was a girl Dan hooked up with, on

and off, until he got tired of how high maintenance she was. “She’s grounded, and better, she makes you grounded.”

“But... but England—”

“You fucked other girls, too!” Dan quieted down when he started to draw looks our way. “Stop pushing that double standard. Do you want to run off with Molly?”

“No, of course not.”

“So why do you think she wants to run off with this... Jerry guy?”

“Jeremy.”

“Whatever. It’s a phase. It was fun. And she came back to you. She didn’t need to. She could have kept things broken off.”

“I... suppose that’s all true.”

Dan picked up his spoon again and scooped some of the soggy cereal up. “Of course it’s true. So, are you going to fix this?”

“No. What’s done is done.” I thought of Jeremy and cringed inside. “I’m thinking of transferring.”

“No you’re not,” he said, incredulous.

“No, I’m not, but I kind of want to crawl into a hole for the rest of this year, just get through graduation and get the hell out of here.”

“Try the library, I hear it’s pretty secluded.”

I shook my head. “That wouldn’t work. I’d definitely run into Morgan there.”

THE DAYS immediately after the breakup felt like a terrible nightmare, and all I needed to do was will myself to wake from it. Only, “waking up” from this dream would require me to confront what a boneheaded thing that I’d just done, and I was still very much boneheaded about it.

Morgan called. I ignored the calls. I wanted to wallow a little longer. I'd answer her the next time, I told myself. Or the time after that. But the calls didn't keep coming. After a few days, they just stopped.

"If she really cared, she'd actually come visit," I told Dan.

"You are a fucking idiot. *You* broke up with *her*."

"Exactly," I said emphatically, even though it didn't make any sense.

"So you're what? Just going to ghost her?"

I nodded. "That is my current plan, yes."

"You are a fucking idiot," he repeated. But he left it alone.

I didn't transfer, of course, but I did keep to myself a lot more. Many of my friends were Morgan's friends, and I just didn't want to deal with that. I studied more than I ever had. I worked out everyday—at the older gym on the opposite side of campus. I wallowed in my own misery.

Not that I didn't see Morgan around. The first time I saw her was over a month since the breakup—amazing how quickly time passed. Dan had talked me into going to a Halloween party at some frat house. She'd come, too, along with Cassidy, from the London program. From the minute I saw Morgan, I realized what a mistake it was to come... and yet I couldn't make myself leave.

They were quite the pair—Morgan in red as sexy devil, Cassidy in white as sexy angel. Morgan's costume was nothing more than a midriff baring tube top, a pair of red booty shorts, and red horns in her dark hair.

It was clear from her expression that Cassidy had dragged her here, just as Dan had me. She scanned the crowd with a weariness that I felt all the time now. When her eyes passed me, my heart jumped. I wanted to run before realizing that my identity was hidden behind my *Scream* mask.

She didn't even linger on me, though, one moment she was there, the next she was being pulled into the next room by Cassidy, where people were dancing

I skulked around the edges of the party like a total creep, pretending to ignore Morgan while checking her out every chance that I got. Had she always been so sexy? Had her hair always been that long, flowing in light brown waves about her bare shoulders. Had she always been so thin?

I couldn't help thinking about the *last* Halloween that we spent together. This was before her trip to London, during our freshmen year. We'd spent it watching a horror movie under a blanket rather than going out. I specifically remember her saying, "I'm not going to dress up as a sexy version of whatever just to get some booze."

Yet there she was at this party, wearing so little, and looking so... comfortable. It didn't feel good to watch, yet I couldn't stop watching.

Morgan wasn't put off by the attention. If anything she seemed to revel in it now. Her navel piercing flashed red to match her skintight shorts, and her initial reluctance was soon replaced by that easy, casual smile of hers.

She danced with Cassidy, slinky and sexy, angel and devil putting on one hell of a suggestive show. It was the kind of act that I'd seen a few times before at parties like this—girls trying to catch the attention of guys. I just never thought that I'd see Morgan doing it.

I had to admit, it was pretty effective. It also kept me away. I briefly entertained this fantasy of going up to her, dancing with her, then pulling my mask off and apologizing. In my head, it would be so easy. In my fantasy, all was forgiven.

Then two frat guys moved up behind Cassidy and Morgan, tall, muscular, good looking. The girls separated, dancing with the guys rather than one another. Mission accomplished. My heart sank.

It had been a little over a month since we'd broken up. She'd already moved on. She'd already become someone else—or maybe that transformation had happened in London and I was just now seeing it.

"Hey, let's get out of here." It was Dan, suddenly at my side, seeing where my eyes were fixated.

“I’m good,” I said stubbornly.

“Uh, no. You’re really not.”

The frat guy whispered something into Morgan’s ear, glancing towards the stairs as he did so. My stomach dropped. Dan tugged on my arm, but I didn’t move. I couldn’t. I just stared, like a doomed deer stares at oncoming headlights.

To my great relief, Morgan ended up shaking her head. Cassidy seemed to notice the exchange, too, swooping in to rescue her friend. The guys were forgotten. The girls moved on to another part of the room.

“Come on, dude,” Dan said. “I didn’t know she’d be here.”

“It’s cool. She’s not... we’re not...”

“Right.” He led me out. I followed.

So did dreams of that party, of Morgan as the devil, of Morgan as *single*. I knew that I’d made a mistake, but every time I thought about finding her and apologizing, I thought about how it would get back to Jeremy, about his proclamation that “*Nothing I’ve seen here makes me think that you’re the one.*” He was right, she could have anyone, and definitely didn’t need a buffoon like me.

Dan was a good friend. He didn’t push me to reconcile. He knew that I’d only dig in deeper. He gave me space, which I appreciated, but that space was lonely.

I saw her a few other times before we left for winter break. She’d be walking across the quad, or down on the Crossing going into a restaurant with friends. She looked the same. She looked happy. I know it was wrong, but that only helped keep me away.

In early December. I was done with my finals. Winter break was just a few days away. I was feeling relieved to get away from it all—from school, from the exams, from the constant fear that I’d run into Morgan and things would get awkward.

Of course that was exactly when I ran into Morgan.

And it was awkward.

For me, anyway. It wasn't so much as me running into her, but me overhearing her. I was leaving my advisor's office when a huge group of people were let out of one of the lecture halls, chattering and relieved to be finished with whatever final they were taking. Of course, Morgan was amongst them all, looking as amazing as ever in a pair of black leggings and a big, puffy winter coat.

My heart skipped. It would have been so natural to slip in beside her, give her a sheepish "hello," and move past the last few months of separation. Even in my head, I knew it couldn't possibly go down like that. I almost did it anyway, swept up in the exuberance that came at the end of a hard semester.

Only she wasn't alone. I blinked and realized that Jeremy was beside her. Worse, they seemed chummy and chatting. I couldn't hear what they were saying. I couldn't even really see their faces from where I was, lost in the crowd behind them. But my motivation was dead and buried in the cold, winter ground. Were they together now? Had I done that? My gut churned regardless.

I lagged behind, letting the crowd flow around me, taking Morgan in its wake. I watched her go, seeing her turn to Jeremy and smile at something that he said. My chest tightened. I felt awful. Just awful. I let her go.

I DID a lot of navel-gazing over winter break, reflecting on my actions and my attitudes. I was a profoundly jealous person, and I'd let that jealousy turn small things into epic events. Would I have done things differently? Absolutely. But what was done was done. All it took was the thought of Morgan and that smile that she shared with Jeremy, and I was done.

“No Morg?” my older brother, Alexander, asked when he swung by our parents’ house. “See, Justin, I told you he should have gone to England with her last year.”

Justin, my younger brother, was only half-paying attention. He was glued to his phone, sending texts to his own girlfriend. “Right, like it’s that easy.”

“For a girl like Morgan, I would have done everything I could to get into that study program.”

“Like get good grades?” Justin needled. “Now that’s some crazy talk.”

“Go fuck yourself.”

I excused myself from my brothers, and they seemed more than content to mess with each other without me there. At least the break wasn’t going to be a quiet one. Meant that I wouldn’t spend the majority of it thinking about Morgan and what she was up to.

But I didn’t need to imagine. I found that out during my first week back at school.

“SO HOW WAS YOUR BREAK?”

“Kind if slow. Hard to find much pussy in my sleepy little home town.”

“That’s why you bring the pussy along with you.”

That was Jeremy talking.

“Easier to do when you spend your winter break in Aspen.”

That was some guy I didn’t know. And me? I was frozen in the stall of the gym’s locker room as these two had this painfully stereotypical, locker room chat.

The guy I didn’t know pressed on. “So who did you bring this time? Bianca? Cassidy? Morgan?”

Hearing Morgan's name in the mix was like getting struck by a bolt of lightning. I nearly choked. The fear of being discovered, hiding in a bathroom stall, sent a second, teeth-clenching bolt through me.

"Yes?" Jeremy said with a chuckle. "My parents' chalet is big enough for a nice group of us."

"Your parents chalet," the guy chuckled. "Where was my invitation?"

"Corey, I *did* invite you. You told me that you hated skiing."

The guy—Corey, apparently—said, "If I'd known it was just an excuse to party, I would have been happy hanging out in your hot tub."

"Everything is an excuse to party, Cor. And there was plenty of hanging out in the hot tub."

"Damn, man. Bummed I missed that."

"You should be," bragged Jeremy. "Here, check it out."

I heard the *swick* of a phone being unlocked. The desire to see what Corey was seeing was very strong. Especially as he gasped and said, "Wow. Mo's got some great tits."

Zap.

"Right? It's like the more you take off, the bigger they get."

Double zap.

"They keep those tops on?" Corey pressed.

"Fuck no, but they wouldn't let me take any more pics. You're just going to have to believe me when I tell you that Morgan may have the most perfect pair I've ever seen. Don't get me wrong, Cassidy's got some nice, big tits, but I like Morgan's more—like the perfect, perky rack."

"So fucking jealous." Corey said it, but I was feeling it—feeling it like bile rising up my gullet.

"I still can't believe her boyfriend broke up with her," Corey said.

"It definitely made senior year more exciting," Jeremy agreed. "It's fucking hot to see the fun girl we knew in London again. You should have seen her eyes light up when I told her I invited Lo to Aspen."

“Lorenzo was there? Now I’m really bummed I didn’t go.”

“Next time. We’re thinking of flying out to Ibiza for Spring Break. His parents have a place there...”

They were getting quieter now, heading for the exit at last.

“Count me in. Not going to miss another...”

And they were gone. The door shut.

I wanted to throw up the whole way back to my place. When I got there, I jerked off instead. It was... confusing.

After overhearing Jeremy brag about partying with my ex-girlfriend, I was finally starting to think of her that way: as my ex. And I stopped hiding and avoiding. I saw my friends again. I tried to stop worrying about seeing Morgan again.

As it happened, all the drama and insecurity that I felt wasn't shared by any of our mutual friends. I mostly got a "where have you been, man?" greeting, or people chided me that senior year was supposed to be chill, not full of grueling study.

Most of them had jobs lined up after graduation, or were headed back home to live with their parents as they transitioned into the real world. I had two years of graduate school ahead of me, a Masters in Education, and saw the final semester of undergrad as a way to get ahead.

Now that I wasn't actively avoiding her, of course I didn't actually run into Morgan at all through the rest of January and the first part of February. Funny how that works. I thought about her, though, probably too much. I thought about how much she'd changed—how much *we'd* changed. She was now the type of girl who partied with guys like Jeremy and girls like Cassidy. She was the kind of girl who hung out naked in a hot tub.

Thing was, as much as I wanted to be upset at how much she'd changed, it was hot as hell, thinking about this new side of my girlfriend—

ex-girlfriend.

On Valentine's Day, I did hole myself away in the library, half-working on my capstone paper, but mostly staying away from all the romance around me. I was slowly coming to terms with the breakup, but V-Day was just too much. I didn't want to see her in the window of some restaurant, staring across a candlelit table at some other guy. I didn't want to think about her crawling into bed with that same guy wearing the kind of red lingerie that I would never see—

Stop. I needed to stop.

Not that I was without regret. My dumbass self hadn't just pushed her away, but I'd pushed her into Jeremy's arms. Talk about a self-fulfilling prophecy. I'd done that, and now I needed to live with it.

The library stacks were quiet. I'd learned that they were big enough that I could usually find a cubby somewhere and not see another person until I emerged. That was my intention on that February 14th.

Fate had other ideas.

"Nathan?" For a moment, I figured that I'd drifted off, that I was imaging her voice. But then I looked up and there she was.

"Morgan," I said with a rush.

There she stood, holding a set of books to her chest. She wore an oversized sweatshirt and leggings, her hair pulled back in a ponytail, her glasses on. It was a far cry from the Valentine's Day fantasy I'd conjured up, and yet she was even more beautiful to me like this.

"I didn't think I'd run into you here," she said. "Figured you'd be out on a... you know."

She actually looked as nervous as I felt.

"Same." I considered adding something biting about her and Jeremy, but caught myself. Not going to fall back into old mistakes. "But I've always known that no man could compete against the stacks."

She humored me with a giggle. “Hard to compete with the greatest minds in history.”

She looked cute as she pushed her glasses up the bridge of her nose. “Are those new?” I asked, noticing the clear plastic frames.

“Yeah. Needed a new prescription. Guess I’ve been spending too much time down here, in the dark.”

Bet that’s not all you’ve been doing in the dark. The taunt didn’t feel bitter. It no longer tasted like acid or bile. It was just a statement, buzzing in the back of my brain.

“I like them,” I said instead. I really did. “You have a good break?”

It was the masochist in me asking that. That was the bit of me that sought the drama.

Morgan’s face darkened, just a touch. She released an almost imperceptibly small breath. “It was interesting.”

“Yeah?”

“I went skiing. With some friends.” Now she was looking really guilty.

“Sounds much more fun than Christmas in Florida with my family,” I said. “Only took three days with my brothers for me to wish I’d just stayed at school.”

“Oh, that’s just family love. So Alexander was back from... Cambodia, was it?”

“Yeah. Home for the holidays.” That she remembered that my older brother was in the Peace Corps was so Morgan. “And Justin’s doing well in school. He spent most of his time chatting with some girl on his phone.”

Morgan smiled at that, as if remembering a time when we used to do that. This felt like old times. Like back when we were a casual couple. Back before I decided to take a dump over everything.

But I wasn’t going to wallow. Not anymore.

“So why no date?” I asked.

Morgan's eyes flickered for a moment. She took a quiet breath, as if to say to herself, *So we're going to do this?* She said, "There was no one who caught my interest." She paused a beat, adding, "You?"

"I actually came to the stacks looking for one. I've heard it's a great place to pick up girls."

Morgan's laugh felt more genuine now, despite the lame joke. "I'm afraid that you've been deceived."

"I don't know," I said, meeting her eyes. "It's not all that bad."

She blushed, glancing away for a moment, then shyly back.

"I'm sorry, Morgan. I was a jealous idiot." I'd been so afraid of saying that, yet it felt so good to say. "I know it's not much, but... I'm so sorry."

Morgan grimaced. She floated over towards me and my little desk, covered in books. She smelled the same as she always did, a familiar blend of her shampoo, her body wash, and just... her. For one brief and hopeful moment, I imagined her throwing her books down, grabbing me, and kissing me.

Instead, she set her books on the table and pulled up a chair beside me. She looked tired, but she didn't look away.

"I'm sorry, too," she said at last. She took a steadying breath. Before I could even ask her why, she went on. "Sorry for taking you to Jeremy's party. I hadn't considered how that might make you feel." She looked at me with a bit of wince. "But he... he really was just a friend."

I heard the past tense in that statement, and for a split second, I thought about asking her about it. I also thought about how quickly that could unravel, how quickly I could fall back into my irrational, jealousy-fueled mistakes. So I kept my mouth shut.

"I get why you may have had the wrong impression, though," she finished. "And I shouldn't have disappeared the way I did. I was just kind of caught up in the moment..."

"I'm sorry I jumped to, like, the worst conclusions."

“You know that I’d never, ever do... *that* to you, right? And... and it’s been eating away at me that you think that I could.”

I could see it, now that I was looking for it. I’d been so wrapped up in my own insecurities that I didn’t see that she had some of her own. “I know,” I said. “It’s just... I don’t like that guy. And I don’t understand what you see in him.”

“I won’t defend him, but Jeremy... he’s also more than what you think. We all are, right?”

I could no longer resist asking the thing that I needed to ask. “So you didn’t really hook up with him in London?”

“No.” She looked bashful and flushed. “He tried. At first, in the beginning, he tried. But no.”

“I’m sorry I didn’t trust you,” I said. I pushed out this next apology before I could stop myself. “And I really am sorry I invited Molly to my birthday. That was totally stupid.”

“You were trying to get back at me? For inviting you to Jeremy’s party and disappearing?”

“I guess. I... I wasn’t really thinking straight at all. And I know that I hurt you.”

“Not just me,” she said. “It wasn’t fair for you to do that for Molly, either.”

I sighed. “I know. It was shitty of me.”

Morgan propped her elbow on the table and rested her head on it. “Yeah, it’s possible. We should have talked more. Like this.”

“I wish that we had.” I heard the finality in my words. I *felt* them. I didn’t like it, but I couldn’t stop talking once I did. It was like tripping as I ran down a hill, and now I was tumbling end-over-end and I couldn’t stop. “We launched right back into our relationship like nothing had changed. But we had. A year apart will do that, for better or worse.”

Morgan looked like she wanted to argue, but I didn't give her the chance.

"We graduate in a few months," I said. "You're going to med school to be a top notch, kickass surgeon or whatever."

"And you're going to do the harder job of teaching kids." There were tears in her eyes. She knew what this was now—this was the breakup speech, the one that we'd put on hold for these last few months.

Morgan reached out to me and took my hands in hers. I was surprised to find them just as clammy as mine were. "I love you, Nathan," she said, her voice breaking. "I'll always love you."

"Just because I'd bring you coffee and PB&Js when you were cramming for an exam?"

Her laugh bordered on the desperate, someone clinging to a ledge that they couldn't hold forever. Morgan would get so stressed out when it came to school work and her academics. She never believed she was prepared enough, despite always killing it. It was all I could do to calm her down.

"Because you were there for me," Morgan said. "Because you helped me get out of my own head. And yeah, the sandwiches were a nice touch."

"You're going to do great things, Morg, and you're going to make some guy really fucking happy."

A tear slipped down her cheek. "So this really is it?"

"Tell me it isn't," I said, hoping that she would and knowing that she wouldn't.

Morgan furrowed her brow. "You've definitely changed, Nathan. Twenty-one is suiting you well."

"I can now legally get wasted."

Morgan snorted, her laugh wet and sloppy. "I think we're both still figuring out who we are as... as individuals," she said. "Isn't that what this time in our lives is all about?"

She wasn't wrong, although a part of me wished that she was. I just always imagined that we'd be figuring it out together.

Morgan squeezed my hand one last time and started to rise. "Well, I'll let you get back to... picking up chicks in the stacks." There was that smile, peeking out from her flushed cheeks and large, wet eyes.

I didn't want to let her go. I wanted to reach out, to pull her down to me, to kiss her. She hesitated a moment, as if waiting for me to take it all back.

"Fuck it," I said to myself.

She turned at the sound of my voice. "What?"

I cleared my throat and opened my mouth with absolutely no idea what was going to come out of it next. "Look," I ran my hand through my hair. "I can... I can still bring you coffee when you need it. We don't need to be, like, *together* for that."

Morgan started to smile, and it was nice to see a little bit of light return to her eyes. "Are you really using the 'let's be friends' line?"

It wasn't an accusation. She was really smiling by the time she said it.

"Totally your fault," I said. "But you're right, we're both still figuring out who we want to be. I just don't think we need to do that *totally* apart."

She gripped her books tighter against her chest and cocked her head to the side, peering at me as if I were a stranger she couldn't quite make out in the darkness. "I'm confused, Nathan. What's happening here?"

It would have been so easy to say that we were getting back together. So easy. But also, I knew now that we couldn't just go back to the way things were. "I think we need a reset."

"Reset to when? To the beginning of Senior Year?"

"To the *beginning* beginning. To being friends again."

Morgan nodded slowly. "I... I can get behind that."

For the first time in months, it felt like stepping into the sun. I'd been missing that feeling, to be around her, to be at her side.

"Graduation's three months away," Morgan said.

“Still can’t believe that.”

“And I am *so* stressed right now.” She squeezed the books in her hands. “I could use...”

“More coffee?”

“A friend,” she said at the same time. She tossed her books on the floor and came in for a hug. No move to kiss, just a solid embrace. And it was still better than any kiss I had ever shared with anyone else. She felt so familiar. She felt so right. I didn’t want to ever let her go, but knew that I had to.

“Okay, I’ve got one condition,” she said before releasing me.

“We’re doing conditions, huh?”

She laughed, stepping back. “Can we go get something to eat? I’ve been avoiding any place that sells food today because, well, Valentine’s Day...”

“Sure.” I couldn’t stop grinning. “Probably too late to get a table at Le Jardin de Luxe.”

Morgan looked down at herself in her oversized sweatshirt and leggings. “Not that they’d let us in even if we could.”

“How about Chipotle? I’ll even spring for it... this time.”

She giggled and bent to pick up her books. Rather than offer to help, I visually reacquainted myself with the contours of her ass—a stunning reminder that leggings are a privilege, not a right.

She smiled as she straightened up, obviously aware of what I’d been doing. “Look at you, Mr. Big Spender!”

“Nah,” I said as I began to throw my things into my own backpack. “I have a coupon.”

Morgan threw her head back and laughed. “Best. Valentines. Day. EVER.”

The rest of senior year was much more chill, just like my friends had urged. Morgan and I were friends, and I forced myself to embrace the platonic nature of our re-forged relationship.

It was a good decision for both of us. I told myself that it was a good way to heal and move forward, but mostly, it just felt nice to have Morgan back in my orbit again. Not that it was totally easy. I could still feel the jealousy clawing at my insides whenever I saw Morgan with another guy, but as far as I could tell, she didn't date any of them. She spent most of her time studying.

She didn't even go to Ibiza with Jeremy and his cadre, either. I knew because I ran into her lounging on the quad, reading a book, over the long break.

"You stayed on campus," I said, squatting down and saying hello.

"I did. Figured this place was big enough for the both of us," she teased back. "Also, I'd like to point out that you *also* stayed."

It occurred to me that the only reason I knew about this trip was because I'd been hiding in a bathroom stall listening to Jeremy. "My plans to hang out in St. Martin's with a bunch of wild coeds fell through."

"Dan forget to invite you?" she said with a giggle.

“Dan’s actually shacked up with Denise, who came to my birthday thing with Molly. Guess some good came out of that night.”

“Wow. Dan’s been dating someone for...” She did quick math. “Almost half a year? That is some kind of record.”

“I know, right? I even heard him use the L word.”

“No shit.” Morgan chewed on that. “I guess miracles do happen.”

“No plans for you?” I asked. I wanted to be more specific, but wasn’t sure how I could explain why I knew that Jeremy had invited her to the European party island.

“Nah. I’ve got too much to do. I’m working on my dissertation, and wanted to get a head start on finals.”

“You know most people relax in their final semester of senior year?”

Morgan shrugged. “I guess this is my way of relaxing.”

GRADUATION DAY WAS FILLED with all the feels, the bitter and the sweet. As I watched Morgan walk across the stage in her black gown, her hair flowing out of her cap, and her smile lighting up everyone around her, I realized how things didn’t go the way that I’d dreamed.

“You made it,” Dan said, wrapping his arm around my shoulders and pulling me close. “And you didn’t hang yourself.”

“You know, you have a true way with words, Dan?”

“Sorry it didn’t work out for you two, but who knows? You’re still young. Maybe you’ll run into her in a few years and it’ll be different.”

I liked that idea. It was also a dangerous one. “It’s time to let go.” I held up my graduation cap. “We’re not kids anymore.”

“Meh. Today’s all about looking both forward and back, right? Last hurrahs and all that shit?” He glanced past me, where Morgan was huddled

with some of her friends. She looked up at me, our eyes locking through the crowd, and I felt the same jolt as the first time we'd met.

Dan clapped me on the back. "Don't crawl back into your head, Nathan. Live in the moment."

And he was gone. And Morgan was there, peeling away from her friends. "Hey," she said when she was close. "Congratulations on the diploma."

"Congrats on *summa cum laude*."

"Thanks." She looked so beautiful. "Ready for what comes next?"

"I barely know what that is," I said. "I'm trying to be more chill about things. You?"

"Chill sounds good," she said. "I've already gotten a bunch of pre-work for med school. It's... a lot."

"You'll be fine."

She grinned at me. "So I heard some of the gang is going down to the Crossing."

"I heard that too."

"You're not going?" she asked.

I shrugged. "I'm kind of all tapped out."

"Yeah, same."

Our eyes locked once more. I loved those eyes, deep and brown and filled with warmth. I loved this woman. And I knew I needed to let her go.

But I also wanted to live in the moment.

"I've got a bottle of champagne back at my place. Was saving it for a special occasion, but now don't want to pack it to move."

"That does sound like a problem," Morgan said with a knowing smile.

"It's already chilled, you know? So maybe unchilling it would make it go bad?"

"Maybe. You asking me to come back to your place for a drink, Nathan?"

Live in the moment.

“I suppose I am.”

“I’d love to.”

WE KNEW what this was as we crashed into my apartment. We weren’t getting back together. We weren’t committing to a future. This was us throwing our graduation hats into the air. This was a goodbye.

But fuck, it felt good to say goodbye.

We were all over each other before the door even closed. Unlike our first reunion at the beginning of senior year, there was nothing shy or tentative about this one.

We were still in our graduation gowns, our fingers shaking and fumbling to unzip the black, baggy material. “Aww, you’re wearing clothes under there,” I said as I opened Morgan’s. She wore a cute, black wrap dress—perfectly acceptable clothing to wear under graduation robes.

“Hoping I was naked?”

“It *would* make this easier.”

Morgan just laughed, kissing me as she opened up my own gown. “Hey, at least I’m in a dress. You’ve got all...” Her hands went to the front of my chinos. “...these...” She deftly unbuckled my belt and started working on the front clasp. “...layers.”

We left the robes on as I lifted her onto my dresser. She laughed, hugging me by the shoulders. I lost my balance, tipping into her, our lips finding one another as we laughed.

“We’re out of practice,” she said as she tugged open her wrap dress.

As I focused on her lacy black bra and matching thong, I said, “Okay, this is better than being naked.”

Her stomach was flat, her navel still pierced with a simple, silver bar. “Glad you approve,” she said, hooking her thumbs into her thong and lifting her hips long enough to whisk it off.

She was still bare shaven. I wondered if she’d gotten any action lately. If she had, it wasn’t with anyone serious enough to mention. My jealousy only fueled my excitement. That this woman, who I still loved, was capable of casual sex had my cock stiff and ready.

“Now get those pants off, Nathan!”

I worked open my chinos, pushing them off to a surprised Morgan. “You’re not wearing underwear!”

I chuckled. “I forgot to do laundry. Nothing’s clean.”

“Well, at least you didn’t wear dirty boxers *for your graduation*,” she said, smiling the whole time.

“You’ve got a winner in me.”

“Not the word I’d use, but...” Her fingers wrapped around my cock and pulled it between her legs. “It’s definitely convenient right now.”

I pushed into her velvety opening, shuddering as I nearly came. “That feels so good,” I groaned.

Morgan swung her arms behind her, bracing herself on the dresser, and looked up at me through her dark lashes. I put a hand on her hip and another on the wall behind her, and started thrusting hard.

“Oh, fuck!” She lifted her legs around my waist, driving her heels into my butt.

“Uhhnn, Morgan...”

With our graduation gowns hanging loosely around us, we fucked for one last time. The dresser shook and rattled as it hit the wall. Morgan fucked back, driving with her heels and off of her palms.

“Yes... Yes, yes!” she gasped. “This feels... so good. I... ohhh... I missed this... so much...”

My heart swelled. My hips drove. I bent over her, kissing her neck. I could feel her lust quivering along the graceful column, and the quick pulse along her jugular.

“I’m close,” she moaned. “Are... are you?”

“Mmm...” I grunted. I was close. So close.

I fell into her, thrusting deep, encouraged by Morgan’s athletic embrace. I ached for her. “Oh, Nate, Nate!”

It felt good to hear her moan my name. It felt so good.

Time seemed to slow down in that split second before release. I thought about all that came before—the first time I’d said “hi” to Morgan, our first kiss, and now, our last. I thought about what could have been if I hadn’t let my insecurities get the better of me—the two of us tackling grad school together, building a life away from school and finding our way in the real world.

Shoulda. Woulda. Coulda.

Didn’t.

Morgan was no longer out of my league. She never had been. She was just another person, a college kid, trying to navigate the world and prone to dumb mistakes. If I’d only realized that sooner. Didn’t mean I could reverse time. Didn’t mean much. My jealousy and insecurity were still there, all the complex emotions that I’d been struggling with ever since she’d left during our junior year together were not gone.

Didn’t matter. Not as I buried my face in her damp hair and emptied my swollen balls. In that moment, we were together, we were one.

And it didn’t end there. We spent the whole night together, one last, glorious night. One last hurrah. We didn’t sleep much, both knowing that this was it, while neither of us wanting to say it aloud.

“You’ll stay in touch?” she asked.

“Of course.”

I vowed to be better this time. I vowed to not let time and distance draw us apart, the way they had when she went off to London. But this also wasn't London. There was nothing time-bound about this next phase in our lives.

“You're going to make an amazing doctor, Morgan. Who knows, one day I may need a surgeon for open heart surgery or something”

She put a hand on my chest. “Your heart's just fine, Nathan. Just don't let your head keep getting in its way.”

I nodded. “Very poetic, Doctor.”

She kissed my forehead and stepped away.

“I'll... I'll see you around.”

It was an odd goodbye, but neither of us wanted to use those words.

“See you around, Morg.”

It would be another year before that was true, and by that time, everything had changed. But of course, that's a story for another time.

PART II

REUNION

“Pssst! Nathan!”

I nearly jumped at her voice. I was strolling along a path at the edge of the vineyard at dusk, the sun having just fallen behind the rolling Californian hills. It was my favorite time of day. The grounds were peaceful, the sky’s dazzling display fading like a memory, and my body was pleasantly exhausted from a day’s hard work.

“Over here,” she said again.

“June?” I looked in the direction that I thought her voice was coming from—a copse of bushes that sat up a steep incline above me.

“Shh, keep it down.” June’s head popped out of those shrubs, and she gestured for me to scramble up there.

This was going to lead to trouble. If there was one thing that I’d learned over the past month-and-a-half working at Suncrest Valley Vineyards, it was that June Lee was trouble. She was also very fun, and very good looking.

I climbed up the embankment, getting help from her as she pulled me into a small copse. June always smelled good, like lavender on a summer day, even after a long day of work.

Before I could ask what was going on, she put a finger to her lips.

“What?” I whispered anyway.

June rolled her large, almond shaped eyes, and shook her finger against her lips. “What don’t you understand about this gesture?”

She apparently wasn’t exasperated enough not to reach out and kiss me on the mouth. I returned it, feeling my body heat up at the prospect of what came next, when she backed off.

“Come on, follow me. *Quietly.*”

We’d been casually hooking up for the past few weeks. It wasn’t serious. We both knew that it was nothing more than a summer fling. She’d go back to her final year at UC Berkeley, and I’d return to my Education Masters at UCI. We’d say that we’d keep in touch, but I was pretty sure we both knew how that went.

I followed June as she ducked low, keeping just below the line of bushes. She wore a pair of tight, capri-length khakis and her Suncrest Valley polo shirt, just like me, although June managed to make it look a lot sexier. I couldn’t keep my eyes off of her tight little butt as she led me along the curve of the terraced vineyard.

I was about to ask where we were going again when she stopped, turned back to me one more time, and once again put her index finger to her pursed lips. This time, I didn’t say anything. Turning back in the direction that we were headed, she moved to the side so that I could see what she was looking at.

I realized where we were. She’d taken us on a circuitous route to the Overlook at the Edge, a scenic hilltop gazebo that usually offered private wine tastings and sunset views, located about as far away as you could get from the estate and winery. We were actually above the gazebo, further up the slope, and completely out of view. I didn’t even know this spot existed.

I also realized why she was so insistent on being quiet. With the sun set, they were merely silhouettes at first, two people standing close, the scene almost romantic.

“Ohhh...” A female moan drifted along a warm evening breeze, and those shadows started to take shape. The woman was actually turned away, facing the darkening foothills of Napa Valley, and the man was standing behind her, his pants down around his ankles.

“Oh,” I said, my eyes growing used to the dark.

“That’s what she said.” June’s breath tickled my ear as she pressed close. That fresh lavender scent and the public sex taking place before us had my heart racing.

June reached down between my legs, finding my cock hard, and before I could say anything, she started to unzip me.

“June...” I whispered in warning.

“There’s a reason I brought you up here,” she whispered back. “And it wasn’t to watch the sunset. Now look closely, Nathan. You recognize them?”

I looked, although June was distracting me as she fished out my cock. As my eyes got acclimated to the low light, though, I did recognize the woman. She was one of the guests who’d checked in that morning—an attractive MILF in her late forties or early fifties, with dark blonde hair and a tight gym body. June had teased me about checking her out earlier, when she’d taken the tour wearing a pink dress that hugged her slim figure in all the best ways.

Now here she was, with that pink dress pushed up around her hips and a man thrusting his hips into her.

Only her lover wasn’t her husband, a portly older gentleman with white hair and a clipped goatee. No, the guy driving into her, his shirt completely off, was younger, fitter, his muscles catching in the light of the rising moon. He was also a guest up at the estate, but part of a different group who were checking out tomorrow.

The realization hit me harder than I was expecting, a swift gut punch. Another woman’s face flashed before my eyes, someone who I’d been

trying to forget about for the last year but never could—Morgan at my doorstep after London, Morgan behind a closed bedroom door, Morgan with other men.

Like all other times these thoughts invaded my mind, rationally I understood that she'd never cheated, that she'd never done a thing behind my back. But the punch landed just as hard as ever.

"Mmm, I knew you'd like watching." June felt my dick thicken in her hand as I watched the blonde MILF get railed. "Figured you were a voyeur."

The man in the gazebo clapped his hand over the older woman's mouth to keep her quiet. She was shuddering, clearly coming, her hands gripping the railing, her heels splayed wide.

"He is, too."

At first, I didn't know what she was talking about. Then I followed her eyes. A third person was also there, standing just beyond the gazebo, his hands between his legs, one arm braced on an unlit lamppost. It was the blond woman's husband.

"What the fuck?" I hissed.

"Kinky, huh?"

The woman came down from her high, but the man fucking her wasn't ready for the fun to end. He pulled out of her and directed her down to her knees. She obeyed without hesitation, grasping for the man's large dick and swallowing it enthusiastically.

"Lucky lady," June whispered as she stroked my dick with one hand and rubbed herself with the other.

I wasn't sure if June thought she was lucky because the man had a big cock, or that her husband just stood there playing with himself too. I didn't get that, yet felt a confusing empathy for the man. I thought of Morgan in our last year in college before I dispelled those unsettling thoughts.

The shirtless man with the muscles stood tall, feet planted, one hand on his hip, the other a fist in the woman's short, blond hair. She knew how to suck cock, taking him until her lips wrapped around the base. We could hear her gags and slurps from up on the hill.

"Fuck, I need a dick," June whispered. She dipped down and took my cock into her mouth. I just stood, too stunned to react, watching the display in the gazebo. My gaze drifted over to the man watching, the husband, his thinning white hair disheveled in the moonlight. He was so focused, his eyes intense, unblinking, his chest rapidly rising and falling like he was the one getting the blowjob.

The man actually getting sucked didn't last long, and the woman was ready for it. She pulled back until just the tip was in her mouth, as he began to pump into her. She jerked his shaft as she received it all, swallowing dutifully.

I tried to hold back. I was almost successful, until I glanced over at the woman's voyeur husband. Again, unbidden, my past ambushed me. This time it was only feelings, emotions, impressions—insecurity, jealousy, arousal, lust.

"Uhhnn." I bit back my grunt. June managed to pull back, dodging the arc of my come as it disappeared into the bushes.

My knees wobbled. June giggled as she guided me away by the hand.

"You better not be one and done," she said once we were out of earshot. "Because I'm horny AF."

LATER THAT NIGHT, we hung out with the other summer workers at the vineyard, drinking anything but wine. June regaled everyone with what we'd witnessed, although she left out the part about how she blew me.

"So the husband didn't stop them?" Kirin asked.

“Definitely not.” June chuckled, glancing at me. “He liked to watch.”

“So kinky,” Vicky said, her Australian accent thick. “I once dated a guy who liked that.”

“That chick is hot. Adelaide Marx. I checked her and her husband in today.” That was Carlos, from Mexico, who worked primarily in the bed and breakfast side of the vineyard. He ran one of his hands through his curly, dark hair.

“Oh, they’re the ones organizing the big reunion tomorrow,” Vicky said. “Interesting.”

Carlos nodded solemnly. “I do wonder if she’d be interested in tasting something spicy and Latin.”

Everyone laughed.

“What?” Carlos asked, hands up.

Later that night, tucked away in our small room in the attics of the estate, as June rode my cock, she said, “Maybe if you play your cards right, you can fuck Mrs. Adelaide Marx, too.”

I reached up, running my hand up June’s neck and into her sleek, black hair. In the low light of the room, her pale skin almost glowed. “You wouldn’t be jealous?”

June giggled, leaning down to kiss me playfully. “You’re not getting sweet on me are you?”

I kissed her back, pushing my tongue into her mouth. I swept my hands over her skinny body, down her back to cup the ass I’d been admiring in those tight khakis.

“No. I just like the idea of making you jealous.” I didn’t think that was even true. Maybe I *was* starting to feel for her. But I also knew that she had someone back in school, someone she rarely talked about. They had an arrangement, much like the one that I had with Morgan when she went off to London, back when Morgan and I were a couple. With June, I was just the fun.

I rolled June over, lifting her dancer's legs against my chest. I started to fuck her in earnest, driving my hips until my abs screamed, and June had to bite back her own screams. "You sure you want to share this with someone else?"

"Uh! Uh! Uh!"

As I increased the speed and strength of my strokes in my fevered determination to fuck her brains out, the sexy Asian American was replaced by Morgan in London in the bed of some strange man.

I grunted, feeling myself start to lose my edge. Things blurred. I saw June again, yet Morgan remained overlaid, like a sunspot, like a regret.

"Fuck... me..." June gasped. She pulled me down to her, raking her nails across my shoulders. The pain only made me fuck her harder.

We exploded together like a crash landing, fiery and abrupt. I rammed into her one last time and pumped my condom full of come. June was coming hard, doing her best to keep quiet. Everyone knew we were fucking, though, and tonight wasn't going to scandalize anyone. We'd be teased in the morning, but nothing more.

I collapsed onto her prone body. She was June again, smelling like lavender and sweat. Smelling new. A new beginning.

“Excuse me, but we need an extra table brought out.”

I turned towards the requester, realizing only a moment later that it was Adelaide Marx, the woman I’d watched get fucked the night before.

She was dressed in a long white summer dress with blue flowers printed all over it. Up close, I realized just how beautiful she was—and not in that faded flower kind of way. She may not be in her twenties or thirties anymore, but as Carlos so articulately stated last night, she was hot.

And right now, she was lifting her brows in my direction like I was deaf.

“A table. Erm, yes. Let me go back inside and... um, make that happen.” As I stammered, all I could think about was this same woman getting fucked last night against the gazebo railing. “I’ll just...”

I scurried away, back inside. More guests were already arriving. A sign had been set up on an easel proclaiming: “Welcome to the Marx Reunion.” Apparently this was an annual thing that this affluent family did every year. I wondered if extramarital sex was also an annual thing.

The guests bridged the generations, from grandparents to couples with little babies. People greeted each other with hugs and excitement, with an exuberance that I couldn’t imagine in my own family. It was hard to picture

our much smaller bunch doing anything close to this, even if we did have the money to support it.

“Nice setup, huh?” June said, carrying an ornate flower arrangement on her way outside. “I’ve never been to a family reunion that has a dedicated planner.”

I just nodded. It wasn’t like we weren’t used to some amount of opulence. We worked at a vineyard in Napa, after all, but this did seem to be particularly luxurious.

I grabbed one of the round folding tables from storage, tucked a set of linens under my arm, and lugged it all outside. One of the things we learned early on here was that everyone pitched in. We were a team, and I liked that.

I set the table up as Vicky came over and helped with the table cloth. Chairs were next, and when it was all set up, I went in search of Mrs. Marx. More guests had arrived. The mingling had begun. There were probably close to 50 family members and their plus ones by that point, most staying on the grounds of the estate.

I found Adelaide Marx holding court by the back of the terrace, a glass of Suncrest Valley Merlot in her hand. She was chatting with a younger couple—a strapping young man and a slender brunette at his side.

As I approached to let her know that the table was set up, the brunette turned and I caught her profile. My stomach plummeted. It was Morgan.

I’D SPENT the last year trying to move on. Despite telling one another that we would stay in touch, we didn’t. Not really. What was there really to say? Phone calls were awkward. Emails were stilted. We weren’t a couple, and I was bad at keeping up with any of my friends. My only text to my best

friend, Dan, in the last six months was a “happy birthday!” My world became my Masters program—my professors, my colleagues, my papers.

Morgan had made more of an effort. She’d initiated most of the emails. She’d called a few times. We’d talked about our classes—sounded like med school was harder than she’d expected. We nibbled around the edges of our social lives, talking about Baltimore, where she was enrolled at Johns Hopkins, and Irvine, where I was in my much more modest program at UCI.

I dated a few girls. Nothing serious. I made a few friends, but nothing deep. I was in limbo. I just didn’t know what I was in limbo for until I saw Morgan on the patio at Suncrest Valley.

She had bangs, cut high across her forehead, and her hair looked lighter. I wondered if she’d done that for her new man, then forced myself to stop thinking like that. That was the old me. That was the man I didn’t want to be.

She looked nervous as she spoke with Adelaide Marx, who was joined by her husband. She hid it well, but I knew what to look for—the way she played with the ends of her hair, the way she nodded too much as she listened. She was the plus one, and this may have been her first contact with the rest of the Marx clan.

The man at her side was good looking, with the same sandy blond hair as Mrs. Marx. He wore a baby blue golf shirt that stretched over his muscular upper body. Even from across the patio, I could see how toned the man was, his back and shoulders huge, his arms thick. He had an easy smile, and when he looked at Morgan, I saw adoration.

My stomach squirmed, and my instinct was to turn and run from the room. Even after a year apart, the jealousy came on thick and strong. But I was better than that. I was beyond it. I buried those feelings down, and when I did, I realized that I was happy for her.

Or, more accurately, I *could* be happy for her, once I got past the thing where I wanted her to be happy *with me*.

I ended up moving away from them before Morgan saw me. It would be impossible to avoid her through the whole weekend, but I wasn't ready to confront the past just yet.

June found me as I got ready to take a small group out on a tour. "What's up? You look like you saw a ghost."

"Maybe, yeah." I laughed it off. "Just recognized someone out there."

She stepped up to me, straightening the green t-shirt with the vineyard's logo printed on it—the one we all wore. "Either they're someone you hate and despise, or they're an ex. Or both."

Not someone I hate. "Just a girl I used to see back in undergrad."

"Ooo, juicy. Which one?"

"Time for me to start my tour," I said, avoiding her questioning and turning to the group ready see see how a vineyard functions.

Of course I couldn't avoid it altogether. Morgan was on my second tour of the afternoon, right there along with her new man and a collection of cousins about their age. When I saw her waiting amidst them, wearing a loose, flowy blouse over a pair of tight jeans, I almost turned around again. Instead, I forced a smile on, took a deep breath, and faced this head on.

Her eyes widened as she saw me approach, giving me a once over that I thought was flattering before realizing that she was probably just taking in my vineyard uniform.

I felt hot all over, slightly ill, definitely squeamish.

"Nathan?" Her shock fell away to a wide smile. She broke away from the group she was with and gave me a hard squeeze. Pulling away, she studied my face. "What are you doing here?"

"Summer job. I wanted something more hands-on." This close, my heart ached for her. It had only been a year, but she seemed different, older, more

worn down. Maybe it was the hair, the new bangs, the new shampoo scent, something citrusy, like grapefruit. I liked it.

I remembered myself and where we were, stepping back. “And you’re with the Marx reunion?”

“She’s with me.”

Morgan’s new guy stepped up beside her, and for a second I thought he was going to drape his arm over his shoulder and add, “*And she’s mine.*”

I thought of Neanderthals, of senior year, and couldn’t help but crack a smile.

Turning to him, Morgan said, “This is Nathan. A... friend from college.”

Friend, I mouthed, trying it out. I could get behind that.

“And Nathan, this is Will. His parents organized this reunion.”

His parents... the ones from last night. I nodded solemnly. “Organizing a family reunion. Very brave of them.” I held out my hand. “Nice to meet you, Will.”

We shook like it was a contest of who could break the others’ hand fastest, and do it with a smile. The meeting had Jeremy vibes, only I was now Jeremy. “Nice to meet you, too, Nathan. She doesn’t talk much about undergrad.”

“Yeah, Morg tends to bottle things up, doesn’t she?” I glanced over at her before returning a smile with her boyfriend. “We were friends for, like, three years, and there’s still so much I don’t know about her.”

Will seemed to relax, now that I was teasing Morgan. “Yes!” he said. “You should see how she gets with school work. Doesn’t ever ask for help and—“

“Alright, gentlemen,” Morgan said. “Don’t you have a tour to conduct for us, Nathan?”

“Right, yes. Let the agrotourism commence!”

Of all the varying jobs we had to do at Suncrest, leading these tours was my favorite. I took this job because I didn't want to be inside all summer, and I loved educating people—even affluent tourists like these.

We walked through the vineyard as I talked about the different grape varieties, how we cultivated them, how we pruned the vines. I went over Suncrest's rich history and its sustainable farming practices, which was always a hit with these folks. They loved feeling like they were supporting something responsible.

The tour wrapped back around to how we processed the grapes, fermenting, barreling, aging. Everyone was always interested in Margot Pauline, our resident vintner, and how she designed our wine profiles, and since she was currently working, she took some time to answer questions.

Morgan and I hung back. "So how's med school?"

She brushed some hair over her ear, a gesture I knew so well, although it looked different now that she had bangs. "It's fine. Good. How's your program?"

"Just one more year to go. It's fine."

Morgan nodded. This conversation was forced, but I loved being at her side anyway. "Will seems like a good guy."

Morgan nodded. There was more to this story, but I wasn't going to get any of it now, so I turned to humor. "The family seems to do pretty well."

"A family of doctors," Morgan said. "His dad's one of the most renowned surgeons on the West Coast, and his mom is the director at Mercy General."

In a way, hearing Will's pedigree was freeing. I couldn't compete with that, so there was no sense in trying. "Good family to have if you want to be a doctor."

"It's pretty privileged," Morgan agreed in a whisper.

"What are you two whispering about?" Another member of the tour group had come over. She was tall, blonde, and put together.

“How everyone in your family is an MD.” Morgan’s forwardness surprised me. She obviously knew this woman. “This is Callie, Will’s cousin.”

“Nice to meet you, Nathan,” Callie said, reading my nametag. “And yes, they’re all doctors. That’s why I’m considered the black sheep of the family for going into finance.”

“Callie also lives in Baltimore,” Morgan explained.

The sharp blonde looked between the two of us. “So I overheard a bit earlier. You two were ‘friends’ in college?” She didn’t use air quotes, but both of us heard them.

Morgan and I shared a glance that was as guilty as it could get. “Yup. Friends,” I said as Morgan responded, “Just friends.”

Callie looked between us and laughed. “Okay,” she said, clearly not convinced, but also not willing to get into it. “Well, Morgan rocks, and it’s always nice to meet one of her friends. Especially cute guys who know a shit ton about wine.”

I tried to read Morgan’s expression, to see if she was jealous, but she just laughed at Callie and said, “He certainly does know quite a bit about wine. That’s new.”

We finished the tour back in the tasting room. I passed the expertise on to the staff who spent all day there, pouring small glasses for our guests. Normally I leave the group at this point, but I honestly didn’t want to say goodbye to her.

At the end, Will and Morgan came back over. Morgan’s cheeks were rosy from the wine tasting, and Will had been enjoying some generous pours from Vicky.

“This guy...” he said, clapping me on the back. I braced myself, thinking of what I may have done were I in his position a few years back. “...knows his shit.”

“Thanks—” I began before he kept going.

“It tracks.” He put an arm around Morgan and pulled her close. “Morgan is so awesome even her friends are awesome.”

Morgan looked at me apologetically. I was just so happy to be forced into close proximity to her.

“So you’re going to be a vintner?” He added too many syllables to the word. Also, I didn’t want to be one. I was going to be a teacher. But before I could say more, he went on, turning to Morgan. “What do you think? Should I swap career paths too? Sounds badass.”

It’s funny how many people actually have asked me that at the end of a tour, like I was a career counselor—how do you get into it, what do you study, how much does it pay?

I caught Callie smirking at us, but ignored her.

“I think you should do whatever makes you happy,” I said.

“Thanks man. You should be happy, too.”

“Alright,” Callie said, stepping in. “I think we’ve got a big group dinner and we don’t want to piss off your mom.”

“Definitely not,” Will said. “Thanks for the tour, Nathan.”

“Just doing my job,” I said, waving goodbye. Morgan glanced back at me and waved, and I was sad to see her go.

The next time I saw her, I saw a *lot* more of her.

Seeing Morgan again after all that time messed with my head. This was different than the last time we'd been apart because I honestly didn't think I'd ever see her again. Not really. I'd closed that chapter in my life, unlike her year abroad when I knew that she'd be coming home.

In a way, this was easier. I knew where I stood. I wasn't her boyfriend. I was her ex. She had a boyfriend. I could either wallow like I had much of my final year in college, or I could accept it and be happy for her.

"Let's go for a walk, Will."

It was late. I'd decided to get dinner by myself in Santa Rosa, wanting to escape all the people. I knew that June would have questions, and while I wasn't going to lie to her, I just didn't want to deal with it. The 45-minute drive there and back helped me clear my head, if only a little.

I'd parked the car in the employee lot and was making my way along the service path back up to the estate when I heard Morgan's voice filter through the darkness. I froze.

"A walk on a moonlit night. I like it." Will hadn't sobered up much since the tour. When Morgan spoke, though, she sounded more serious.

"Honey, we need to talk."

My ears perked up. That didn't sound good. Not that Will picked up on it. "Or maybe we could do something other than talk?" he said playfully.

Morgan laughed softly. Nervously? “Come on.”

So I knew that I should leave it alone. None of this was my business. She was in the past, and I’d already caused her a whole mess of trouble for her.

Then Will said, “Let’s go to that overlook... I bet it’s nice and quiet now.”

How could I resist that? There was just no chance. I didn’t even bother trying to justify this. I just hustled through the night, head low, taking the service paths to the hidden spot where June and I had spied on Will’s mom the night before.

I made it there well ahead of Will and Morgan, giving me plenty of time to talk myself out of being there in the first place. I was still confused as to why I was there. I was never great with the jealousy thing. I spent more time senior year broken up with her and self-flagellating myself thinking of her with others than actually *with* her. Crouching in the shrubbery in the dark reminded me a little of those times—wearing the Scream costume at that Halloween party, or overhearing Jeremy talk about his winter break with Morgan. In a twisted way, it was nostalgic.

“...you’re just under a lot of pressure at school, babe. I get it.” Will had arrived on the scene. I peeked out, catching the sight of Morgan leading him along, their feet crunching in the gravel path.

“Yeah, maybe...” she said. I recognized that tone. She was circling around a hard conversation, trying to figure out how best to approach it. She’d used it when she told me that she’d gotten into the London program.

They must have come straight from the dinner we’d set up on the estate’s terrace. She wore a dark navy blue halter dress—almost black—with delicate sequin embellishments that sparkled in the moonlight. It ended just above her knees, showing off legs, and had a cutout in the back that exposed her creamy skin, skin that Will ran his fingers along as he guided her into the gazebo.

“Thank you for coming here with me,” Will said, stepping close.

“Will, I—”

“I don’t mean *here* here, at the overlook, although walking in heels like that on a gravel path isn’t the easiest.” He brushed her hair from her face. “I mean coming along with me to this reunion. I know it can be a lot.”

“Your family’s like all families,” Morgan said. “Yours is just much bigger.”

“You always know exactly what to say.”

I could barely hear them, my ears straining as I leaned in, as if a few more inches would be enough. I didn’t need to hear to read body language, though. Morgan was tense. She had a lot riding on her—a lot that Will didn’t seem to pick up on. He leaned in, wrapping her up in his thick arms. Morgan seemed to flinch, if only for a moment. But then Will leaned down and whispered something into Morgan’s ear.

She giggled, pulling back to look up at him, tossing her hair. They exchanged a few more whispered words, but I knew where this was going. I knew that I should definitely leave, but also, wasn’t this the reason I’d followed them out here in the first place?

Will started kissing her neck as his hands traveled along Morgan’s body. I sighed to myself, remembering when I could do that, and how I’d taken her for granted. She tipped her head to one side, baring more of her neck to him.

He said something, and the two of them turned away from me, out towards the rolling hills of northern California. Wine country at night, there was almost no more romantic place.

Then, he unzipped her dress. I saw her tense again, start to turn in protest. He stopped her with a firm hand on her back, and she... stopped for him. She let him strip her dress off in the warm evening air, exposed. She wasn’t wearing a bra, but she did have on a lacy black thong that plunged between her sculpted ass cheeks.

Another memory stirred: our first time together after London, when she'd surprised me by wearing a thong. *'I've had a change of heart with things riding up my butt,'* she'd said back then. For the first time, it made me wonder who had changed her mind about that.

I could just hear his voice in the breeze. "I can make you feel better."

He collected her against him, cupping her tits from behind as she reached back for his head, pulling his lips to hers over her shoulder. Seeing her want him, want this other man, sizzled through me. I don't know why, but I was getting excited *for* her.

My stomach also filled with acidic jealousy, but I knew my place in things now, and I knew I wasn't entitled to feel that way. Maybe that's why I kept watching, my cock hardening in my pants, as Will worked her body.

He turned her, pressing her right up against the railing of the overlook. I caught sight of her bare breasts, perky and as perfectly formed as I remembered, her small nipples hard. They kissed passionately, any previous hesitation gone. She tugged at his shirt and together they whipped it off. He was certainly a specimen, his cut upper body carved from muscle.

He drifted to his knees, kissing her body on his way down. He sucked on her tits as she ruffled his hair, and when he dropped lower, his spit was shiny where the starlight played across her nipples.

She still had the belly piercing, the silver bar glittering in the center of her flat stomach. He nipped at that, too, as he grasped her thong and dragged it over her hips.

"Ah!" Morgan moaned, tipping her head back as she leaned into the side of the gazebo, her hands grasping railing. From my vantage point, I could see her responding to his mouth, ripples of pleasure rocking her body. Her chest rose and fell in short gasps, and she bit her lip as she tried to quiet herself.

I remembered that body, her soft skin, her taste. A wave of longing crashed over me as I watched another man do what I'd taken for granted.

There was no doubt that she was into the sex. I could read her. I knew her. When she moved a hand from the railing into Will's dark blond hair and held him against her, I knew she was close.

Will didn't let her come, though, pulling back as she got closer and closer to the edge. "No," she whimpered.

He stood, still in his trousers, his muscular upper body eclipsing Morgan. He grabbed her face, dragging her in close to whisper something that I couldn't hear. But I could see her nod quickly, eager to do as she was told. Then they were kissing again, and her hands went to work on his pants, opening them, tugging at them, pushing them down over his pale ass.

It was hard to watch, and it made *me* hard as I watched. I couldn't look away. I didn't even want to blink.

Will put his hands on her hips, turning her, bending her over the railing. It was the same position that I'd watched Will's mom get fucked last night.

Morgan looked over her shoulder, meeting Will's eyes as she set her long legs shoulder width apart, her ass waving before him. She said something that I couldn't quite hear. A plea maybe. *Fuck me.*

Her imagined words seared a hole through me.

Fuck me.

"Ah!" That, I could hear—her moan echoing over the hills before he covered her mouth with a hand. He was inside of her. He was fucking her.

We'd had a rocky run. We'd taken a break and taken on lovers. We'd gotten back together only to break up again. I knew that she'd been with other men. I'd heard Jeremy talk about it in the locker room. I knew there had been someone named Lorenzo in London. But I'd never *seen* her with another man.

Now, I don't think I will ever shake the image of Will's muscular ass flexing each time he thrust into her. He was rougher than I ever was, too, reaching out and grabbing her hair as he drove into her. She seemed to love it, arching her back and throwing her hips back against him. Her cries

bounced off the roof of the gazebo and out over the vast darkness. She couldn't contain her pleasure—pleasure on another man's dick.

“Take it, baby,” Will grunted.

“Uh, yes...”

“You're not holding back on me, are you?”

“Uhh uhh...”

“Come on me.” He actually slapped her ass. I tensed at that, but Morgan only cried out more. “Come all over my dick.”

“Nngh!” She squeezed down on the railing, rolling her shoulders back as her head hung down between them. She lifted her ass against him, grinding backwards as she groaned and moaned an orgasm that I hadn't heard in over a year. I missed that sound. I missed her.

“Oh, yes,” Will barked. “You ready for me?”

Morgan only moaned in response. Moments later, Will was thrusting deep, chest puffed out, head rocked back as he emptied himself into my ex-girlfriend.

I swear to God, I almost came with them. It was embarrassing. I didn't get it. At the time, I didn't know anything about cuckold angst. I just knew angst, pure and confusing and painful.

Still, I couldn't creep away. I was suddenly aware of the world around me. Insects hummed. The gentle breeze rustled the grape vines. But otherwise, the world was so quiet. They'd hear me rustling. They'd hear me retreat.

Will pulled out of Morgan and stumbled back, his pants still around his ankles. Even softening, his dick swung full and large between his thighs. He chuckled as he caught himself and pulled his trousers back up. He threw himself onto the bench of the gazebo and retrieved a bottle of wine that I hadn't noticed that he'd carried out and took a swig directly from it, smacking his lips loudly. He was still drunk. “So was that the kind of conversation you had in mind?”

“Not exactly.” Morgan picked up her dress, but didn’t put it on immediately. Instead, she floated to the back of the gazebo, facing my direction. I froze, thinking that she saw me. She seemed to search the terraced hillside, like she had some preternatural hunch that I was there.

I held my breath. I didn’t move. My heart thudded in my ears. Seeing Morgan standing there completely naked didn’t help with my blood pressure. She was a little skinnier than I remembered, her hair lighter, with bangs, her skin pale in the evening light, covered in just the hint of sweat. Her tits were just as I remembered though—firm, soft, a generous handful. Her pussy was still smooth. Is that the way Will liked it?

“So what *did* you want to talk about, babe?”

Morgan shook her head and turned away from the hillside, back to her boyfriend. At last, she stepped into her dress, and when her head emerged from the top, she was smiling again. “It’s nothing. It can wait.”

Will hopped up off the bench and stuffed himself back into his shirt. “How about we head back to the room and enjoy that nice, big bed of ours again.”

“Someone’s frisky.”

They started heading back up the gravel path. “You know how I get with good Merlot. I think it’s the tannins...” His voice faded away. I was once again alone.

I took the long way back to the building, wandering along the service paths like a dandelion seed caught in the wind. The full weight of Morgan being here finally hit home. This wasn't just some random meeting. She was here with another man's family. That was a serious step.

I'd brought Morgan home over the winter break of our sophomore year because her home situation was complicated and she was going to stay on campus instead. It just made sense, but it wasn't until my brothers teased me about settling down so quickly that I realized how big a deal it was to introduce your significant other to the family. But that had just been my brothers and my parents. The Marx Reunion was so much bigger.

The significance of Morgan meeting Adelaide Marx now struck me in the gut. To bring her here, into what felt like a familial gauntlet, meant that he knew how amazing she was, and unlike me, he wasn't going to take her for granted.

I slowed as I made my way up to the estate house, admiring the locale with fresh eyes. The vineyard was a beautiful and historic Napa Valley establishment with a rich history dating back to the early 20th century. The estate was originally built in 1902 by a wealthy San Francisco businessman who'd wanted a country retreat for his family.

I knew all this from countless tours of the grounds, but I'd never really processed it.

Over the years, it had changed hands, getting converted into a vineyard and winery, the surrounding hills covered in Cabernet Sauvignon, Merlot, and Chardonnay vines. A tasting room had been built onto the home, several guest bungalows erected around the hill crest, and the back lawn cleared to attract special events, like the one currently set up now.

The estate remained stunning throughout its history, the grand, three-story mansion renovated in a Spanish Mission-style style—stucco walls, red tile roofs, and arched windows.

Inside, the main house was equally impressive. There was a large, airy entryway with marble floors and a grand staircase leading up to the second floor. The walls were adorned with beautiful artwork and antique furnishings, giving the place a timeless, elegant feel. We got to stay on the top floor, but even up there felt like we were characters in a Jane Austen novel.

"I'm happy for her." I said it aloud before entering the house just to hear how it sounded. I could almost believe myself.

"Who are you happy for? The ex?"

June's question came out of the dark. I jumped. "Jesus fuck!"

"Such blasphemy." She had a vape pen most likely loaded with cannabis, offering it to me. "Want some?"

"No thanks."

"You're such a Boy Scout."

I shrugged. After spying on my ex-girlfriend having sex, the Scouts of America probably wouldn't agree. I didn't love getting high. I didn't love how it made me feel, and besides, I was already feeling pretty weird.

"So you trying to convince yourself that you're over your college girl?" June pressed. She stuffed the vaporizer into the back pocket of her tight jeans and approached me. "Also, where were you tonight?"

“I needed some space. Just... I have a lot on my mind.”

June wrapped her arms around me and pulled me close. She felt good—warm and soft and familiar. I was still on edge from the sex I’d just watched, and stiffened quickly with June against me.

“Want to talk about it?” She looked up at me with empathetic eyes. Tonight, she’d done her eyeliner with little curls at the corners, highlighting her Asian features.

Did I want to talk about it? I did. But not tonight. “Later,” I said, pulling her close. “Right now, I don’t want to talk.”

“That works too.”

I didn’t know what reclamation sex was. Even if I did, this certainly wasn’t that by any stretch. June wasn’t Morgan, and I also wasn’t currently *with* Morgan. But when we went up to my room, I fucked June like I had something to prove, and when I closed my eyes, I saw Will’s bare ass driving into my ex.

June kept up. She had a lithe and flexible body and loved to fuck. Rolling me onto my back, and straddled me, her black hair falling around her pale, slender shoulders as she rocked her hips over my cock. Her naked body was a dream, shimmering and beautiful—high, hard, pale nipples, slim hips, a tight little landing strip of dark hair leading down to her smooth, wet, snug pussy.

“Ah, fuck!”

Her fingers were a blur between her legs. I grabbed her, yanked her down to me, kissed her hard as my other hand grabbed her ass and urged her to ride me faster. She responded immediately, driving into me faster, her hips rolling as she slid up and down my shaft. I dug my fingers into her ass, squeezing her hard. June cried out, but not in pain, in excitement. “Fuck!”

We were manic, heaving and crashing against one another. I threw myself up into her until June was arching back and coming hard. I was right

there with her, eyes shut, seeing Morgan, not June, remembering Morgan and how it used to be, how it could be, how I wished it still was.

“Whatever got into you, I like it,” June said. We were lying in the dark, only the flat sheet covering our sweaty bodies. “Been a while since I was fucked like that.”

“Your boyfriend back home doesn’t do it for you like that?” I’m not sure why I said it like that. We didn’t talk about him, and when I brought it up, I felt June tense.

“It’s different with him. We have a connection.”

But the sex isn’t as good. This time, at least I only thought it. Hard not to project my own lived experiences onto this. Like, did Morgan ever have this conversation with her London lovers? She must have compared them to me. Did she compare me to Will now?

“So what’s your deal?” She caressed my chest, running her fingers through the sparse copse of dark curls. “Where did you go?”

“To Santa Rosa.”

“But where did you *go*?”

I understood her real question. I just wasn’t sure that I wanted to answer it. Then again, who else could I talk to? In a month, I may never see June again. There was comfort in the fleeting nature of what we had.

“Just dealing with stuff from my past. Seeing my ex again dredged it all up. Apparently her new boyfriend is the son of the blonde from last night.”

“No shit, really?”

“Really.”

“What a wild coincidence.”

Or was it fate? I shook it away, focusing on real and tangible things. She was with someone else—like *really* with someone else. I ran my hand down June’s naked body, tracing her spine with my fingertips.

“We dated from our second year through our last in college.”

“Who broke up with who?”

“I broke up. I was a jealous idiot.”

June was quiet, giving me space to work through it all. She shifted, draping a leg over mine. She kissed my shoulder.

“We actually had an arrangement like you and your guy. Only instead of a summer, it was for all of our third year at school. She studied abroad.”

June’s eyes went wide. “A whole year?”

“Yeah.”

“Did you at least visit?”

“No.”

“But she came home during breaks?”

I shook my head. “Nope. It was too expensive for her.”

June processed it all. “No offense, but that doesn’t seem healthy. You were functionally completely broken up. For a year. You know how much can happen in a *year*?”

“You’re not really helping,” I muttered.

“But how am I hurting? You’re not together anymore.” And then she put it together. “And now you’re talking yourself into being happy for her.”

Might as well own it now. “Yeah.”

“You know the best way to help her stay happy?”

“What’s that?”

“To stay away. To not complicate her life. If you’re suffering here, she’s probably feeling that, too, and in a moment when she’s meeting her new man’s whole fucking family.”

Morgan was missing me? I liked the idea of that.

“You make a good point.”

“Tomorrow is Saturday. This reunion is scheduled through Sunday. You can call in sick tomorrow and be scarce after. And then she’ll be gone and that will be that.”

Easy as that. “So just stay away?”

“Just stay away.”

“Right.”

No way could I actually do that.

Okay, it's not like I went seeking her out the next day. But I also didn't hide in my room and let the storm of the Marx reunion blow over. There was just too much to do, and I still was working a job.

I saw her reading at the far end of the manicured lawn in an Adirondack chair pointed away from the estate. June would have told me to stay back, but June wasn't around.

The walk across that lawn felt endless. My blood pressure rose. Sweat built up beneath my polo. I tried to focus on the crispness of the morning air and the sounds of the birds, but all I could really think about was her and all the moments that we'd shared—meeting in class, sitting on the quad in the sunshine, holding one another in bed.

"Hey, anyone sitting here?" I asked.

Morgan startled slightly at my voice. She turned, looked up at me, seemed to hesitate before nodding. She said, "You are, I hope."

"Thanks." Hope. That's not what I needed right now, but it felt good to have some anyway. "Trying to get some peace and quiet?"

"It's easy out here," she said. She closed her book—a medical textbook, I noticed, not something read for pleasure. "So peaceful."

I glanced out over the hills around us. "Yeah, for sure. Easy to take for granted when you're so bogged down in the day-to-day."

“I hear that,” Morgan said. Her fingers tightened on her text book. “You look good, Nathan.”

“So do you. I like the hair.”

She touched her bangs. “Do you? I actually kind of hate it. Like, I’m actually growing it back out. Not sure why I cut them.”

“You were trying something new. That feels on brand.”

She lifted a brow. “What are you saying, mister?”

“Just that you like to try new things. I always admired your adventurous spirit.”

Morgan snorted. “Not much adventuring now, unless you count barely passing biochemistry.”

“I somehow doubt that.”

“Maybe I’m being dramatic, but, like, it’s been *hard*.” I could see the stress on her face just from thinking about it. Morgan was always a good student, smart, hard working, but undergrad was easy for her. Didn’t seem like that was true in medical school. “How about you? How’s your program going?”

“Sounds easier than yours. I like it, but can’t wait to be in my own classroom.”

“You’re going to be great at that. You’re good at explaining things in a captivating way. Like on the tour yesterday.”

“You’re just hot for the teacher.” It was a casual joke, one that came so easily when we were a couple. I regretted it as soon as she blushed and looked away.

Without making eye-contact again, staring into the grass, she smiled and said, “Well, you do know how hearing about grape vine cultivation gets me going.”

I cleared my throat before launching into one of my scripts. “Did you know that Suncrest Valley practices rigorous canopy management to enhance the brightness of the grapes. This involves carefully pruning and

training the vines to ensure optimal sun exposure and airflow—think of it like getting a haircut, if a haircut could make you smarter.”

“I wish,” Morgan laughed.

““The vineyard cultivation practices at Suncrest Valley are a testament to the winery's commitment to quality and sustainability,”” I continued.

Morgan clapped her hands together in delight, laughing harder.

““The attention to detail and dedication to the land is evident in every bottle of wine they produce, and it's no wonder that Suncrest Valley has become one of the most respected and sought-after vineyards in Napa Valley.”” I stopped and grinned at her. “Think I should use it next time I’m out at a bar.”

“It would definitely work on me.”

My turn to laugh. “Yeah, but you’re a total nerd.”

“Fair.”

“What am I missing out here, kids?” Will had found us. I spotted him just before he took a seat on the arm of Morgan’s Adirondack chair. “Morning, babe.” He leaned down and kissed her. I was surprised when he pushed his tongue past her lips, forcing myself to look out over the hills as my face heated up.

“Nathan was just telling me about the history of the vineyard.”

“Didn’t he do that yesterday?”

She rested a hand on his knee. “Oh, you know I can never get enough history.”

Will didn’t look convinced, but let it go. “I just came out to tell you that we’re about to head out. You sure you don’t want to come?”

“You need a caddy?” Morgan joked. “You know golf isn’t my thing. You go, have fun with your dad and uncle. Catch up on things. I’m good.”

Will hesitated, looking over at me before returning to her. It was almost irritating to watch, except that I had spent most of senior year—when we were together—treating her this way.

“Of course,” he said, kissing her goodbye. Again, the kiss lingered a moment too long. *Mine*.

When he was out of earshot, I said, “You know you have a type, right?”

“And what’s that?”

“Good looking but insecure men who are prone to jealousy.”

Morgan’s laugh was quick and spontaneous. She covered her mouth, her warm eyes smiling. God, I missed that look. “He’s not that bad. He’s just stressed out being around all this family. I mean, look how you get when it’s just your two brothers.”

I thought about the time when I was in his situation just after London, when I thought that she was fooling around with Jeremy. And the party that we should not have gone to. “I’ll make sure not to invite you into the back room to smoke from a hookah.”

She winced. “Not my finest moment.”

“I had a few rough ones myself.” The nostalgia felt like a warm blanket on a cold winter morning. “He makes you happy?”

“He... does.” I heard the hesitation, but she was smiling, doing all the appropriate things. I almost called it out, but that wasn’t my place. I’d already introduced enough drama for a lifetime with her.

“Then I’m happy.”

“Thanks.” She blushed.

I had the sudden and nearly uncontrollable urge to kiss her, but even in my nostalgically romantic state, I knew how wildly inappropriate that would have been. Even if she didn’t have Will. Which she did. We had moved on.

“You’re here until Sunday?”

“Yeah. Then back to school to study. These labs are kicking my ass.”

Morgan stood. Our time together was coming to a close. I stood as well.

“Studying over summer break. You’re just the same.”

She looked at me—like really looked. “You’re... not. I like this new you.”

My turn to thank her for the unexpected compliment. We started to move back towards the house. Some of the staff were erecting large tents on the lawn for this evening's dinner. Our pace got slower and slower as we approached the house.

"You know..." Morgan seemed hesitant. She had a confession. I gave her space to talk. "I... I was going to break up with him before this trip."

I was expecting this—hoping for it even. It still took me by surprise. Morgan didn't share like this. That she was sharing it now, with me, was... confusing.

Softly, gently, like someone afraid to spook a wild animal, I asked, "Why are you telling me?"

"Because I don't want to be accused of keeping things 'bottled up.'" She was smiling. That was a good thing.

"Who ever accused you of that?" Humor was my defense mechanism. But I also couldn't resist probing for more. "And is that still the plan?"

We'd finally stopped walking completely. She looked at me meaningfully, searching my face as she took a deep breath.

"It's still the plan. But I don't want to make a scene, you know?"

"Makes sense."

"And I do care about him," she was quick to add. "I just don't think that he's the one."

We stared at one another for what felt like an eternity, and in that moment I saw a whole lifetime pass between us. I saw her the way I had the first time that we met—quietly beautiful, friendly, inviting. I saw her after London, more confident, yet more conflicted, too. But it went beyond that. I saw her future. Our future? The ups and downs were written across her face, she would change—we would change. But maybe we could change together.

Then the moment passed and we were just two people standing on the back lawn of a vineyard in Napa Valley.

“I’m sorry that he’s not,” I said at last. “And I’m really sorry that you came to this thing.”

She smiled. I smiled, too. “Are you? I’m not so sure that I am.”

My heart skipped. She turned and wandered back to the house, and I watched her go the whole way. When I finally snapped out of it, I noticed Adelaide Marx standing over by the erected tent. She was chatting with Vicky, who held a clipboard, but her eyes were on me.

I looked away and got out of there, headed in the opposite direction of Morgan.

I was hauling some equipment into one of the sheds along the grounds when she found me. Not Morgan, but Adelaide Marx, the matron of the Marx family, standing in the entrance, the sun silhouetting her curves. The contrast was hard enough that I couldn't see her face, just her blonde hair haloed in the doorframe.

“You’re Nathan, right?”

“Uh, yeah. Can I help you?”

“That’s what I’m here to find out.” She stepped into the shed, pulling the door closed behind her. “I saw you chatting with my son’s girlfriend. You two know each other?”

Shit, so she had noticed. “Yeah, we went to college together.”

“I see.”

The shed was made of loose clapboard, and sunlight poured in through the cracks. Even the door barely closed. It was designed to keep weather off of the equipment more than anything else.

But the space wasn’t huge, and I was suddenly very aware of how close Adelaide Marx was. And how attractive she was. I tried to guess her age, but there was a timelessness to her beauty. She had a few wrinkles on her brow and around her mouth, and she carried years in her green eyes, but I

couldn't put an age to her. The sunlight pouring through the cracks of the old clapboard walls made her blonde hair shine like a halo.

"So you were friends," Adelaide said.

"Correct." I had a pretty good idea why she was here, and as much as I wished that this was a porno setup, I was calculating how much trouble I was going to get in from management. Women like this could get a summer worker fired without a second thought.

Even still, her green eyes never wavering from mine, her expensive perfume filling the small space, my cock stirred.

"So you can maybe tell me about her," Adelaide said. "What kind of girl is she?"

My heart raced as Adelaide stepped closer. I took a step back, knocking into some shovels. I turned, grabbing them before they clattered to the ground, then realized that I'd turned my back on her and twisted back. She hadn't moved except to put her purse up on the utility shelf, and was smiling at my nervousness.

"Don't be nervous, dear." This time when she advanced, I didn't flinch away. I couldn't. There was nowhere else to go. "I just want to know who this girl is. Tell me about her."

"Morgan's... great," I said honestly. "She's kind, passionate, intelligent. She can be both bookish and adventurous, getting as lost in the library as a new city or experience..."

Adelaide listened intently, hearing so much more than just the words I was rambling off. She was sharp. She knew that I was a threat to her son. I thought about the conversation earlier that morning, about how Morgan was going to break up with him. As crazy as it was, it made me sad for *Will*. He went from rival to underdog.

I looked at this stunning woman in front of me, struggling to find words that will make this situation better for everyone involved. Including her son.

“Mrs. Marx,” I began, seeing her smirk at the formal name. I pressed on without overthinking my words. “I understand why you're here. And I want you to know that I would never try to sabotage your son's relationship with Morgan.” I ran my fingers through my hair, buying myself a moment to think. “I’ve caused enough grief for Morgan already.”

I wasn’t sure if she believed me. Her face remained smooth and unreadable, but she was listening.

“My mistake was that I didn’t trust her, and I let that take over everything. So you need to trust... both of them, I guess. Give them space. Let this weekend be a special moment for them to reconnect. So just let things unfold naturally.”

I gave Adelaide a reassuring smile, trying to project sincerity and calm confidence I didn’t totally feel in this situation.

“You want me to give up control?” She issued a hearty laugh. “You sound like my husband.”

My pulse quickened and my mouth went dry as I tried to process what was happening. I could practically feel the heat radiating off Adelaide's body as she closed the final gap between us.

“Nathan... you're quite an interesting young man,” she purred. “I wasn’t expecting this kind of advice when I followed you out here...”

I swallowed hard, feeling simultaneously aroused and conflicted. There was no doubt that this gorgeous older woman was hot, that I wanted her, and that I wanted to see where this went. I thought about her in the gazebo, getting fucked, going to her knees so easily to suck off some other guy. I groaned as Adelaide’s fingers traced down my chest.

But there was Morgan to think about. I still had feelings for her, boyfriend or not. This felt like a betrayal.

“Mrs. Marx...” I managed to say, my voice hoarse.

“Call me Adelaide,” she said. Her perfume enveloped me, the scent of her body intoxicating in the confined space. My resolve began to crumble

long before she said, “And I need to thank you, Nathan. I don’t want my son marrying some cheating whore.”

“Marry?” The word hit me like a punch to the gut.

I stared at Adelaide in shock, the world seeming to tilt on its axis. “They’re going to get married?”

Adelaide nodded. “If she says yes,” she said. “I’ll be honest, when Will told us his plan earlier, I wasn’t so sure. But you’re right, Morgan seems like a great girl.” She noted my shock with a nod. “And judging from your reaction, I’d say that she seems like the kind of girl worth holding on to.”

“She... is.”

“I can see that this is difficult for you,” she said, her voice a whisper.

“I’m... I’m just not sure that... they’re ready for marriage,” I stammered. Her eyes dance before me. “They’re so young.”

“Maybe,” Adelaide agreed. “But that’s their decision, right? Not yours.” She leaned in and kissed my neck ever so gently. I groaned, shutting my eyes as her hand cupped my hardness through my pants. “And no offense, honey, but you already had your chance with her, didn’t you?”

I was speechless. Especially as she sank to her knees before me.

“Adelaide...” I managed to choke out, my heart pounding wildly. I definitely needed to push her away, tell her I can’t do this... But Morgan and I aren’t together, right? We’re over and... and maybe she’ll be wearing another man’s ring by the end of the weekend.

I couldn’t find the will to stop Adelaide as she gazed up at me with those striking green eyes, her hand undoing my belt with practiced ease.

“What about your husband?” I tried in weak protest.

“Oh, he’s off golfing.” She unzipped my fly and tugged my jeans and boxers down just enough to free my throbbing erection. “And a little secret between the two of us? He’s the one who actually told me to follow you.”

“What?”

She wrapped her hand around my shaft, stroking it as she gave me a seductive smile. “He knows me and what I like. And what I like are strange, hard cocks.”

With that, she leaned forward and flicked her tongue over the tip, lapping up the bead of pre-cum gathered there. “This qualifies.”

She swirled her tongue around the head of it, sending waves of pleasure through me. I reached out and grabbed a shelf for support as my knees threatened to give out. *Oh my god. This is really happening.*

All thoughts of right and wrong flew out through the cracks in the shed as she took me deeper into her hot, wet mouth. The suction was incredible. I groaned and my hips jerked involuntarily. She was good at this. She had a lot of experience pleasing men, and the idea of that, of this sophisticated woman on her knees before countless strangers, only drove me closer to the edge.

“Adelaide... you... ungh...” I couldn’t find the words. I wasn’t even sure what the hell I wanted to say. “That feels... ohhh god...”

She moaned around my cock, the vibrations nearly making me come on the spot. One hand squeezed my balls while the other gripped my shaft, stroking in time with the bobbing of her head. I was overwhelmed by the dual sensations, and it took every ounce of self control to hold back.

Adelaide pulled back, releasing me from her lips with a loud pop. I groaned, disappointed and relieved as the cool shed air hit my slick shaft. I shouldn’t be here. I definitely shouldn’t be doing this. “I should... I can’t...”

“Oh, I think you can,” Adelaide said, rising before me, her hands still on my shaft. “Come on, don’t you want to fuck the mother of the man who’s going to marry your ex-girlfriend?”

I was being manipulated. I knew it. I even knew it in that moment, in that shed. Didn’t help. Didn’t stop what came next. When Adelaide slipped

out of her dress, letting it pool down around her feet, I knew there was no escaping this next mistake.

I stared at her, drinking in the sight of her toned, golden tanned body displayed so invitingly for me. Beneath, she wore black lingerie that did incredible things to her curves. "Did I strike a nerve?" she asked, reaching back to unclasp her bra, freeing her large, full breasts. "I think I did."

I could only stare in awe as she shimmied out of her thong too, baring her naked body to me. Her skin was smooth and golden, and between her thighs, her pussy lips glistened with moisture, the skin completely hairless and tempting.

"You're a bitch, you know that?" I said hoarsely.

She only laughed.

And then we were kissing again, clashing, throwing our bodies against one another. As I spun her around, pressing her against the slats of the shed, and thrust into her from behind, I thought of Will doing this to Morgan last night.

"Oh, fuck, yes!" she cried out, arching her back to take me even deeper. It was like someone else possessed me. I gripped Adelaide's hips tighter, slamming into her as I thought about what I'd watched last night.

"Oooh yes! Harder!" The walls of the shed creaked with each forceful thrust. The tools rattled. Anyone walking by would know exactly what was happening. It made it all crazier, wilder. "Come, baby! Fill me up! Come in my slitty, MILF slit!"

This was so fucked up. So wrong. Who talked like that, and yet... and yet, with a guttural roar, I buried myself to the hilt inside Adelaide and exploded. My cock jerked as I pumped load after load of come deep into her willing cunt. The forbidden pleasure crashed over me in relentless waves as we both rode out our intense orgasms together.

Adelaide sighed contentedly as I stumbled back. She picked her dress up and wiggled back into it without bothering with her underwear. Those

scraps, she stuck into her purse.

“Thanks for that. I *really* needed that,” she said.

I just stared at her, uncertain what the hell just happened. She grabbed something that had been set on the shelf—something that I hadn’t noticed until now. Her phone. She turned it around and pressed something.

“Don’t be nervous, dear. I just want to know who this girl is. Tell me about her.”

“Morgan’s... great.”

Our voices sounded tinny and small through the speakers of her phone. “You recorded us?” I asked.

“For my husband’s entertainment,” she said. “He made me, and I don’t say no to him.”

“I... I don’t consent to that.”

Adelaide just laughed, ignoring my protest. “You know, I can see a lot of me in Morgan, don’t you? I bet she doesn’t say ‘no’ to much, either.”

I just stood there, mouth opening and closing like a fish on land, as she spun and left the shed.

I didn’t know what to do with any of that. I didn’t know whether Adelaide had recorded us as a threat, or if it really was a kinky game between her and her husband. I wasn’t sure what to do at all. I should have taken June’s advice and laid low.

I tried doing that the rest of the day. I did my jobs. I made sure I always had another employee with me. I avoided the party that was set up, the dinner that was served, the tours that were being done. Tomorrow was Sunday. The Marxes would be gone and I could get back to my life. Call this one of the most fucked up “learning moments” of my life.

“Hey, where have you been hiding?” June found me as the party in the back lawn was winding down. The tables were being cleared. The music turned off. Some of the reunion guests were still scattered around, out by

the Adironnacks or mingling on the flagstone patio. I didn't even scan them for Morgan or Will or Adelaide. I didn't want to risk even eye contact.

"I'm taking your advice," I said lamely.

"Wise man."

I wasn't so sure about that.

She sidled up to me, getting as close as we dared to get in public. Everyone knew we were hooking up anyway. "You want some other advice?"

"Please." She leaned into me like she was going to kiss me. I was pretty sure she was going to suggest something sexual when she looked at me with those warm brown eyes.

"Come out tonight. We're headed to The Alley. There's a show that a bunch of us are going to check out."

I pulled back and wrinkled my nose.

The Alley was an outdoor bar in Santa Rosa that was definitely on the divey side. I'd gone there on our first weekend and realized that it really wasn't my scene. The music was crazy loud and tended towards the shouting, angry kind of metal that grated on me.

"Oh, don't be like that. You could use a break from all the polos and khakis."

And the drama of this family, I thought.

"Fair enough. Fine, I'm in." I pulled her close. "As long as you wear that black top without the back."

"You've got a deal."

"I'm in."

"You're easy," she laughed.

I thought of the shed incident. "I am, yes."

"Hey, sorry for eavesdropping, but can I come, too?" Of all people, when I looked up, Will Marx was standing there, wearing a button-down

shirt that was designed to be worn untucked and with several buttons undone, his hands stuffed into the pockets of his pressed trousers.

He glanced between us. He recognized me, of course, but apparently my close proximity with June removed me as a threat.

I could almost hear June snicker without actually snickering. What a hilarious idea, to invite the man who was going to propose to Morgan tomorrow. But before I could come up with a polite way to turn him down, June said, “Sure, man, all are welcome. The more the merrier.”

And that’s when I realized that June had no idea who this guy was—and in fact, all that *she* saw was a hot looking guy with wind-blown sandy blond hair and a body built like a fucking Olympian.

She was also easy, apparently, and tonight was going to be trouble.

“This isn’t a good idea,” I said to June on our way up to the rooms to get changed. “You know who that guy is, right?”

“Some hot guy who wanted to get away from his relatives?”

“He’s Morg’s...” She didn’t even know Morgan’s name. “He’s my ex’s boyfriend.”

“Your *ex-girlfriend’s* boyfriend?” She paused and glanced over at me, grimacing. “Well, that’s awkward.”

“No shit.” And I wasn’t about to tell her how I just had sex with his *mom*. Who also happened to fucking record it.

“But there’s an upside here,” she went on, resuming her march towards our rooms.

“Let’s hear it.”

“And you will.” She kissed me in front of her door. “As soon as I can figure out what it is.”

I considered skipping out on the night. Morgan would probably be there. Morgan and Will. That was complicated for so many reasons, but what I kept coming back to, and what finally made me actually change into my black hoodie and jeans, was the fact that *Morgan would be there*. And maybe tonight would be the night that Will got down on one knee? I needed to give her the heads up. She needed to know first.

Morgan was indeed out front by the time June and I made our way down, looking good in her boho sundress, her hair falling in shaggy waves about her shoulders. She scanned the two of us, processing our body language and how close we were standing. Prickles rode up my spine as I subconsciously took a half step away from June, and while we weren't holding hands, our hands suddenly felt way too close.

Will and Morgan were joined by the cousin, Callie, along with Carlos, Vicky, and a few of the other summer workers. Carlos had already fired up the van we used for these outings and we all piled into the back. There were enough of us that June had to sit in my lap, and Morgan in Will's.

"Tonight's gonna be fun," Will said enthusiastically.

I was less sure.

I WINCED as the wall of sound crashed over us, distorted guitars shrieking and blast beats pounding. The small club, crammed into an alley between two bars, was packed with a sea of black t-shirts, faded denim and heavy boots. Most of the crowd was about our age or younger—some teens, but mostly rowdy twenty-somethings getting worked up by the screaming music.

"Drink?!" I yelled to Will and Morgan. When they didn't understand what I was saying, I made the universal hand gesture for drinks—holding my hand and tipping it back. Morgan, wide-eyed at the locale, nodded eagerly.

Will, despite looking completely out of place in his golf shirt and boat shoes, seemed to dig the vibe. He seemed like a good guy, although one used to being catered to. For him, this was like another tour, an outing that came with the resort package.

The bars on either side of the alley served drinks to the club, and both were packed. We pushed our way over to Grillo's and shouted out our orders. Will ordered a round of shots, and the summer workers were more than happy to take advantage.

"I feel so out of place." Morgan yelled to me. Even standing in the far back of the crowd, away from the stage, I could barely hear her. But I got what she was saying, and nodded.

"Not my normally chosen venue."

The lead singer, a stringy chick with short blue hair and a bunch of facial piercings, was leading the crowd in a screaming chant that I swear was, "FUCK YOU, NATE!"

Morgan and I looked at each other, wide-eyed, as others around us picked up on it. "Another ex-girlfriend?"

"God, I hope not!" Will was in the midst of the mosh pit, pumping his fist and chanting right along. "He seems happy to shout that."

"What?" Morgan shouted.

"Never mind."

She followed my eyes and put it together. "Oh, Will is..." The rest was lost in the noise. I shook my head, tapping my ear, and Morgan seemed to move on.

It was only on the second refrain that we figured out that the singer was shouting, "FUCK YOU, MATE!" Morgan and I joined in this time, although I swear Morg was still saying my name when she winked at me and laughed.

I need to tell her about Will and the proposal. If she really isn't happy with her relationship, then she should know. "Hey, Morg?"

"What?!"

"You should know—"

"Hey you two!" It was Callie coming between us, her arms around our shoulders. "Stop flirting back here and come dance!"

“We’re not flirting,” Morgan said lamely. Callie either didn’t buy it, or didn’t care. Next thing we knew, we were into the thick of it, thrashing and hopping around with the rest of the locals. Definitely not my scene, but when the crowd pressed me close to Morgan, her warm soft body molding against my side for a brief moment, I knew that I wasn’t going anywhere.

Of course we weren’t alone. June and Will joined us, along with Vicky, Carlos, Cassie. More alcohol was consumed. More shouted conversations over the buzz of the metal guitars.

“You still like her,” June said at one point, her arms around me.

“Who?”

“Uh huh.”

“Want me to seduce her boyfriend? Give her a reason to break up with him?”

I wasn’t sure if she was joking or not. “No, don’t do that please.”

It made me think of my twenty-first birthday and the drama that had ensued with Molly. I didn’t want a repeat of that night, or anything close to it.

I glanced over at Morgan, who was in the crowd with Will now, doing her best to dance. The two looked so out of place in the sea of angst and black clothing.

June pulled me closer, pressing her lithe body to mine. “If you’re not going to let me fuck the blond stud, I suppose you’ll have to do.”

Even that statement was confusing. Made me think of Adelaide and her husband. “You can fuck whoever you want.”

“Oh, I know,” she said with a wide smile.

“I just don’t want any drama.”

“You’re no fun.”

My ear drums were splitting. There was only so much of this that I could take. I thought about Ubering back to the vineyard, but ended up

ducking into Grillos and the muted silence that it afforded. Only a few other patrons were in here, rather than in the alley, and I appreciated the solitude.

Eventually, Morgan found me, settling into the stool beside me at the bar. She was alone. “Hey, we thought that you’d left.”

“Nope. Still here.”

“You okay?” She asked it in a tentative way, like someone holding out her hand as she approached a growling dog. That was fair. I didn’t have a great track record when I was drinking.

“Honestly? I’ve been better.”

“I shouldn’t have come out. I’m sorry, this is your whole thing, and you’ve got June—who seems cool, by the way, and—”

“Will’s going to propose to you.”

Morgan stopped babbling, her mouth open. That was exactly the best way to deliver the news, but I was drunk and unfiltered. She said, “I’m sorry, what?”

“That’s the plan. His parents know. I... I heard it from them.”

“There’s a story there,” Morgan said.

My neck burned. “Yeah. And I’ll tell you all about it someday.” If we had any more days. “But anyway, I thought you should know. Just so it doesn’t catch you by surprise.”

She put a hand on mine on the bar. “Thank you.”

I looked at her hand, then did my best to ignore it. I said, “Can I buy you a drink?”

“I’ve switched to water.”

“Smart girl. I should do the same.” I flagged the bartender down and asked for a couple glasses of water.

“Morgan?”

“Yeah?”

She had such big eyes, large and soft brown, so full of feeling. I missed staring into those eyes now. “I wish things had gone differently with us.”

“Same,” she said, squeezing her hand over mine. “You know, at first, I kept hoping that maybe we could make it work?”

“You did?”

“The distance though, it’s hard.”

I nodded. “I stopped writing.”

“Well, you kind of did. But it’s not all you. I’m not so great at it either. Out of sight, out of mind, and all that.”

“We don’t do well apart, do we?” I offered. “But also, we don’t always do well together.”

“I don’t know. We had our fun.” There was color in her cheeks.

“So what are you going to do about Will?”

Morgan sighed. “I guess I need to have a talk with him before he makes a big spectacle in front of everyone.”

“You think that’s how he’d do it?”

“Yeah. Will is all about big and flashy things. He takes after his parents, and look how they throw their family reunions.”

“I see your point.”

“This is going to be hard, though.” Morgan sighed. “Despite, you know... not wanting to be with him anymore, I still like him. He’s a good guy, with a good heart, who helped me out when I was feeling pretty low.”

I heard the affection in her voice for him. “Maybe don’t break up then?”

Morgan looked at me, surprised. “You really have changed.”

“I just want you to be happy, Morg.”

“Then talk me out of medical school,” she said with a laugh. “I’m not sure it’s worth it anymore.”

It was a little startling to hear her struggle with something academic. “Oh, please. You’ve got this. There’s nothing you can’t do when you put that brilliant mind to work.” She smiled, thinking of midterm finals in our second year. “Want me to send you some peanut butter and jelly sandwiches”

“Oh, my god,” Morgan laughed, recalling the same memory.

She’d been cramming all night and hadn’t eaten in a day. I knew she couldn’t go into that exam on an empty stomach, but the only thing I had in my apartment to make was peanut butter and jelly sandwiches. So I made her about four, and she wolfed them all down. Ended up scoring an A.

“You know, I still eat them before my exams?” she said. “It’s like a good luck charm now.”

“Really?”

“Yeah. Will thinks it’s weird, but goes with it. I don’t even need to ask him to make them for me any more.”

The implication was that Will lived with her now. Or at least spent enough time with her that he was there when she was studying all night.

“You could always say ‘yes’ to him. Good looking guy, wealthy family, easy to house train. You could do worse. Case in point...” I tipped two thumbs towards me.

“You’re not worse, Nathan,” she said ever so softly. Her hands had found mine again, and suddenly I was looking at her lips instead of her eyes, wondering if they were still as soft as I remembered.

That’s when we heard the commotion outside. Looking out through the garage door windows, we watched as the mosh pit out there devolved into an all out brawl. And in the middle of it was Will.

“Oh, shit!”

Morgan and I were outside, pushing into the fray before either of us could decide whether that was a good idea. People were pushing and shoving everywhere, throwing punches, shouting. The band stopped playing. The lead singer was yelling, “Calm the fuck down you fucking wankers!” Which wasn’t very calming.

By the time we found Will, the fight was a chaotic melee of people settling grudges, or just excited for the opportunity for violence.

Morgan led the way through the scrum like a combat medic on a battlefield. Together, we extracted Will before any more damage could be done.

By the time we were back out on the street, Vicky had pulled the van up. “That was fucking awesome!” Will said, amped up.

“I’m sorry, did you forget about getting punched in the face?” Callie asked. Morgan had a napkin that she was dabbing at Will’s split lip.

“Exactly!”

“I like men who like getting smacked around,” June said as she climbed into Will’s lap. I met her eyes and shook my head subtly. She pouted.

Morgan took a seat in my lap for the ride back to the vineyard, and despite our heart-to-heart in the bar, and the way Will went on and on about feeling so alive—and clearly very drunk—the ride was awkward. I didn’t dare look at Callie, and June kept flashing me knowing smirks.

“Well, that was an interesting night,” Carlos said.

“Want to make it even more interesting?” Will announced to the van.

Oh no, I groaned. He was fishing something out of his pants. June laughed, joking, “I’m all for a good time, but I don’t think your girlfriend is looking for *this* kind of ‘interesting.’”

“Oh, ha. No, that’s not...” He finally pulled free the thing that I was worried about: a black velvet ring case. “Morgan? Want to be my wife?”

The whole van sat in stunned silence. I subconsciously tightened my arms around Morgan's waist, for support, for intimacy.

"Will, let's talk about this after we get back," she said.

He opened the box, and June's eyes went wide. "Holy shit, that's a big diamond."

"What do you say? I have never met anyone more brilliant, more beautiful, more... sexy than you. I know that we've only been dating for, like, six months, but I know a good thing when I see it."

I listened to this Richie Rich boy be this right and wished I had been so perceptive.

"Will, could we please talk about this later?"

Callie picked up on Morgan's hesitancy and tried to intervene. "Will, maybe that guy hit you harder than you thought—"

"Nah. I've given it a lot of thought. I know what I want, and what I want is you at my side." For a guy who seemed to understand what a catch Morgan was, he certainly had a problem reading the room.

Morgan shot me the briefest of glances. I held my breath and hoped that maybe Will didn't pick up on it.

"I'm sorry, Will," she said at last. "But this is all... a lot. At once."

His face darkened at last, cutting through his happy-drunkenness. “Just say yes. It’s easy. Mom and Dad blessed it.”

“You already talked to them?” Morgan asked.

Everyone else seemed to pick up on the tension in the van. Vicky seemed to pick up speed, trying to get us home before another brawl broke out.

“Of course. This is a big decision.”

“It is,” Morgan said, her voice shaking with emotion. “For us. For me and you. You... you should have talked to me first.”

“Then it wouldn’t have been a big surprise. Baby, why are you being weird about this. I thought you’d be happy.”

“I...” Morgan looked from face to face in her unintended audience. She wasn’t a fan of being the center of attention, yet here she was, with all eyes unfairly on her.

“We’re almost home,” I said. “Maybe you two should wait—”

“Is it him?” Will asked, cutting me off. “Everything was fine until you saw him.”

“That’s not true,” Morgan said. “I guess if we’re doing this, we might as well do it.”

“You don’t have to—” I muttered.

“Will, you’re a great guy. Like, super great. But I’m sorry, I can’t marry you. And I know that sucks, and you’re hurt and pissed, and I wanted to have this conversation in private, but, again, I’m sorry...” She reached out and closed the ring box. I swear I heard June whimper. “My answer is no.”

On cue, we pulled up to the front door of Suncrest Valley’s main estate. “Final stop,” Vicky announced in her plucky Australian accent. “Time to get the fuck out, kiddos.”

I have never seen a group so eager to get out of a car. I swear Carlos jumped out before it had come to a complete stop. June was definitely out of Will’s lap as soon as the doors opened. Will sat stunned.

“Come on, walk with me,” Morgan said to Will from outside the van. “We should talk more.”

I didn’t think that was a good idea. Apparently Will didn’t, either. “I don’t think so,” he mumbled, deflated. He finally climbed from the van, shoulders slumped. He still held the closed ring box in his hands. “I’m going to...”

I exchanged grimaces with the others as he wandered inside. Callie had an arm over Morgan, who was looking just as shocked as the rest of us at what just happened.

“Come on,” she said. “You can crash in my room.”

“I should follow,” Morgan began.

“No, you shouldn’t,” Callie said firmly, leading Morgan around the side of the house, taking the longer route there. Morgan didn’t protest anymore. I couldn’t let things end on this note, though, trotting up to them before they were gone.

“Hey, Morgan, you okay?”

They paused. Callie looked back at me. I expected daggers. I expected the equivalent to Will’s *‘is it him’*; accusation. But she was more thoughtful, and I got why Morgan liked her. “Pretty sure that’s a no,” she said softly.

Morgan sniffled. “At least I had a heads up?” Morgan said weakly. “Thanks for that.”

“About fifteen minutes of a heads up,” I said. “I should have given you more.”

“Don’t put this on you,” Morgan said.

“And don’t put it on *you*,” Callie said to Morgan. “This is my boneheaded cousin. This is this whole fucking family. Now come on, let’s get you some water and some sleep.”

“Night, Morgan,” I said.

“Goodnight,” Morgan responded. “And thanks again. Despite everything... tonight was fun.”

By the time the two were gone, everyone else had gone their separate ways. Everyone else, that is, except June. She was standing apart from us, giving us space. I wondered what this must have been like for her. We were never serious, but I still cared for her.

“Hey,” she said, approaching. “I thought of an upside.”

“Yeah? Let’s hear it.”

“That scene in the van didn’t play out in front of his whole family.” She giggled, stepping up right against me.

“I suppose... that’s an upside?”

“You should go to her. She needs someone.”

“She’s got Callie.”

June rolled her eyes, “She needs *you*, idiot.”

“You sure? What about...” I gestured between the two of us.

June laughed. “You’re not going to pull out a ring, too, are you?”

“Well, I *did* talk to your parents...”

June laughed. “Now I know you’re messing with me. There’s no way they would have agreed to let me marry a white guy.” She pushed me playfully. “Now go. We’re good, you and me. And if things don’t work out and she lets you, I’m still around for the rest of the summer.”

Felt like I was trespassing as I ascended the grand staircase from the main entrance, heading up to the wide, airy hallway of the guest suites. The ceilings were high, the floors lined with plush, patterned carpets that muffled my footsteps. Along the walls were paintings of the estate over the years, from when it was just a rich man's vacation home to its transformation into a vineyard.

The doors were heavy wood, adorned with an antique brass handle that took an actual key. I found Callie's room number—thanks to Vicky—room 12 etched into a discreet plaque.

My heart wanted to keep running down the hall and out through the window at the end. I was surprised that my hand wasn't shaking as I lifted it to the door and docked quietly.

It felt like I waited forever. I had so much time to talk myself out of this and flee. I was about to turn away when I heard the lock turn and the door open. Callie's face appeared at the crack.

"I was hoping it was you, and not the other one."

"Thanks?"

She swung the door open. There, sitting in the midst of the specious and beautifully appointed room on the king-sized bed, was Morgan. She still wore her summer dress, long and loose yet still somehow very sexy. She'd

pulled her hair back into a ponytail, those short bangs cutting across her forehead.

“You have a gentleman visitor,” Callie said in the contrived accent of an aristocrat.

“Hey,” I said lamely from the door.

“Hey, there,” she responded.

“I’ll give you two some space,” Callie began.

“I don’t want to kick you out of your own room,” I said. “I just want to talk.”

“Uh huh.” The blonde wasn’t buying it.

Morgan rose. “How about a walk?”

“Yes. A walk sounds nice.”

Morgan seemed to avoid both of our gazes as she left the room. I was on edge, too, taking the back stairs to avoid running into any of the Marxes along the way.

Once back under the stars, I felt like I could finally breathe. Insects chirped. The night smelled of freshly turned soil and foliage and cut grass.

“You okay?” I asked.

“I’m still trying to decide,” she said with a sardonic chuckle. She sighed and looked up at the night sky. “I should have broken up with him months ago.”

“Why didn’t you?” In my head, I answered for her: “*Because I liked the sex.*” The thought was the old Nathan. I silenced it before it could take hold.

Morgan shrugged. “Because it was just easier that way. He was fine, you know? He’s a good guy, he makes me laugh, he...” I heard a lot in her brief hesitation. “...he helped distract me from school, which is fucking hard as hell.”

I nodded, wanting to say something, to crack a joke or tell her how smart she was, but knew it was better to remain quiet. A warm breeze

picked up as we wandered the rows of the vineyard. It rustled in Morgan's hair.

"Honestly, if circumstances had been different—if I hadn't come here and he hadn't proposed—I probably would have stayed with him. Maybe settled. Maybe I would have been too caught up in keeping my head above water in school that the next thing I knew, I'd be Mrs. Marx with two kids and a big house and I guess a dog and—"

"Hey, hey. You're spiraling." We'd stopped. I took her hands in mine. It was nice to see this kind of vulnerability in Morgan. Even when we were together all those years, she hadn't shown it. "Give yourself more credit. You'd be *Dr.* Marx with two kids, a nice house, and probably a dog."

Morgan laughed. "I don't even like dogs."

"You don't? No wonder we broke up."

Now we were both laughing. She squeezed my hands. "Thank you, Nathan."

"Why?"

She shrugged again and turned to continue our walk. "For just being you. It's nice to have a... a friend, I guess."

A friend. Yeah. I suppose that could work.

We walked in comfortable silence for a bit before Morgan said, "You know, when Will laid the blame on you, he wasn't entirely wrong. I mean, he *was* wrong about things turning bad when we got here. Will just never saw it. He's a bit clueless that way." She was nervous. I heard it in the way she spoke, her cadence rushed. "But seeing you here *did* open my eyes. It reminded me of what... *this* could feel like."

"I think that's a bit of rose-colored glasses," I said. "We weren't great, either, and things did kind of end spectacularly badly."

"Is there an opposite of rose-colored glasses?" she mused. "Green is the opposite color, right, so... puke-green-colored glasses? Whatever, point is, you wear those."

“I work at a vineyard. I’m very familiar with puke.”

She laughed politely at the lame joke. “You only remember the bad stuff. But when I think of us, in college, you know what I remember?”

What I *didn’t* say was: *Probably me bringing another girl to my birthday party and then getting angry at you.* I kept my mouth shut and let her answer her own question.

“I think of sitting outside with you and Dan, studying on the quad. Or that movie theater we used to go to, where the tickets were like three bucks and you complained *every time* about the ripped vinyl seats.”

“To be fair, they were pretty awful.”

She smiled. “I think about meeting for lunch at the Caf and how you’d tease me for getting a Dr. Pepper. Something about being pre-med. But you know what I think about most?”

We were suddenly standing very close to one another. I wasn’t sure how that had happened, but I was happy that it had.

“How different you were from everyone else. All the other guys who hit on me. You were a little neurotic, definitely melodramatic, but underneath all of that, I saw... I saw...” Her eyes wavered. She looked past me, searching for the right words. “I saw a kind soul. And I miss him.”

I leaned into her before I could talk myself out of it, pressing my lips to hers. She responded, her lips parting, a gasp passing from her to me. I poured everything I had into the kiss, everything that had been bottled up inside of me over the last year. I could feel her doing the same, her fingers clutching at the sides of my hoodie.

“I need you,” Morgan murmured, staring up at me with those big, beautiful eyes. They reflected the moonlight, so full of need and open for anything.

“God, you’re beautiful.”

We were at the gazebo, I realized, like our subconscious minds had brought us back here. I laughed quietly to myself. “What?” she probed.

“Just... this place, it’s called the Overlook at the Edge, and it’s kind of a known hookup spot.”

Morgan looked around, realizing where they were. “Oh, I know.” She pulled me into the gazebo and lifted her brows.

This was happening. This was really happening. I responded by kissing her again and my hands ran down her body, mapping out the curves that I still dreamt about.

Her body responded eagerly to mine, her breath hitching as my lips moved on to her neck. “Oh, Nathan...”

My pulse quickened and my cock tightened inside of my jeans when I felt her hands slide up under my shirt. “This needs to go,” she said, tugging at it.

Together we pulled it free, t-shirt and hoodie at once. She kissed my bare skin and licked a nipple playfully. I shuddered. We kissed more, lips meeting in a deep and passionate embrace. I moved her deeper into the gazebo, closer to the edge. We swallowed each other’s moans.

“Oh god, yes.” My hands moved up her body, pushing the straps of her boho dress from her shoulders. She shrugged her way out of it, pushing it down her slender body. Which left her in just a strapless bra and a matching thong, both black.

I reached out and caressed the smooth skin of her waist. She shivered under my touch. Emboldened, I continued exploring her body, running my hands up along her flat stomach, to that belly piercing, to the edge of her rib cage just up under her breasts.

“So soft,” I murmured.

Morgan bit her lip, desire pooled like moonlight in her eyes as she watched me touch her. I leaned in, capturing her mouth in another heated kiss as my thumbs stroked over her hard nipples through the thin fabric of the bra.

My mouth found the sensitive skin of her neck, kissing and sucking as I made my way lower. "I want to taste every inch of you."

I dropped to my knees in front of her, hooking my thumbs into her thong and slowly dragging it down her legs. She was still bare, her pussy glistening with arousal in the moonlight. I placed open-mouthed kisses along her inner thighs, drinking in the smell of her arousal.

She whimpered as I pressed a kiss against her smooth mound, shifting her weight to practically sit on my face. Her breath hitched as I dragged my tongue through those slick folds, so familiar, yet new all over again. "Oh god, Nathan..." Her hands found my head, fingers tangling in my hair.

I looked up at her, holding her gaze as I continued to pleasure her with my mouth. She was staring right down at me, her eyes alive with passion. I moaned against her pussy, savoring her taste and relishing every needy whimper and gasp.

I dipped my tongue into her entrance, feeling her walls flutter around me as I fucked her with my mouth, spurred on by her cries, by the way she ground down on my face. My cock throbbed. I needed her. I needed to fuck her. But I wanted her to come first.

"Oh fuck, Nathan, I'm... I'm... going to... going to..." she gasped. "Don't stop, please..."

I redoubled my efforts, working her until her hips started to buck against me. She held me against her thighs, shifting even higher over me, smothering me in her sex as she cried out. "Yes, yes, YES!" Her orgasm slammed through her, and I felt it in her clenching pussy, pulsing on my tongue.

I rose, pressing my body flush to hers.

"I need you," I murmured, voice thick with desire. "I need to be inside you."

For answer Morgan claimed my mouth in a searing kiss even as her hands worked on undoing my jeans. As soon as my cock was freed, she

wrapped a hand around it, stroking me firmly. I groaned into our kiss.

“Fuck, just like that,” I growled. “I want you so bad.”

I broke the kiss so I could step out of my pants, kicking them aside impatiently. Morgan wrapped her legs around my waist, grinding her dripping wet pussy against my aching cock. It took all my willpower not to plunge into her right then and there. “Morgan... I don’t have a condom,” I managed to get out.

Morgan kissed me hard, moaning into my mouth. “In my purse,” she said, nodding towards the discarded handbag on the floor. I found it hot that she had them at the ready, my cock surging even more as I stepped away to grab the condom from her purse.

She’d settled into the padded bench at the side of the gazebo by the time I returned, her bra gone and a smile like that of the Cheshire Cat peering out at me through the shadows. I slowed a moment, admiring the stunning creature sprawled out on the bench. I swear I’d had this dream before. Maybe I was having it now.

I rolled the condom on quickly and positioned myself between her thighs. “This really happening?”

Morgan grabbed me by the hips and pulled forward. “I think so, but maybe I’m dreaming?” she said. She groaned as I sank into her, her eyes fluttered shut. “Nope, not dreaming.”

She wrapped her legs around my hips, pulling me fully inside her with one quick motion. “Oh my god! You feel so fucking good.”

I was at a loss for words. It wasn’t just good. It was... right. This was where I was meant to be, hand in perfect fucking glove.

I leaned down to capture her lips as I started to move, rocking into her with long, deep strokes. “You feel... so... so...”

“Yes!” she cried out, her inner muscles clenching deliciously around my shaft as if to keep me buried inside her. “Harder, Nathan!”

I rammed into her harder, finding a rhythm that had her moaning even louder.

“Yes! Right there!” She was getting close already. I knew the cues. I knew her body. It was like coming home. Gritting my teeth, I willed myself to hold back. I wanted to draw this out, to make it last. After so long, I didn’t want this moment to end.

“Nathan... I’m... I’m going to come... AGAIN!”

Hearing her say those words, feeling her clench around me as her second orgasm hit... it was too much. With a low growl, I buried myself to the hilt one last time as my own release overtook me.

I couldn’t form any words as I slowly came back down from my high. Resting my forehead against hers, feeling our racing pulses begin to slow, I kept waiting for that moment where I woke up. Or for her to realize that this was fleeting.

But when I tried to pull back, Morgan grabbed me, kept me close, kept me against her. “Don’t go,” she said quietly. “Not yet. I just... I just need this feeling... for a little longer.”

We held one another in the gazebo as the sweat cooled on our bodies. It was like the reality of the situation was in that wind, pleasant at first, then increasingly uncomfortable. But I didn’t care. I wanted this. I wanted her.

“I missed you so much, Morg,” I said, kissing her softly. She looked up at me, blinking and smiling, her hair mussed, her cheeks still flushed from exertion. She looked satisfied. She looked amazing.

“Me too.”

Even as the afterglow faded, it still felt right. Natural. Like things were finally starting to veer back in the proper direction. Things still weren’t resolved. We still needed to have a big discussion. But that wasn’t for tonight, in the gazebo. The gazebo was reserved for clandestine sex.

Morgan went back to Callie's room. I went back to mine. Tomorrow would be a day of drama, and as much as I wanted to hold Morgan and fall asleep in her arms, it would have to wait a little longer. Interestingly, it was my idea to sleep separately.

The next day began like every other. I got up, showered, dressed in my khaki work pants and blue uniform polo. June took me aside before we went down to breakfast. "So how did things go last night?"

"They went well." I couldn't keep the smile from my face. She knew what that meant.

"You got laid."

"Are you jealous?"

June snorted. "You think a lot of yourself, don't you? I don't blame you. I would have hit it."

We were only ever friends-with-benefits, but she was definitely a friend. I grabbed her and hugged her tightly, saying, "Thank you," because I wasn't sure how else to express my gratitude. It went so much deeper than the two words. She was exactly what I needed at that moment, and I'd miss it.

"You're welcome."

"Hey, Nathan?" It was Vicky there, clearing her throat. "Um, Horton wants to see you."

Hannah Horton, the executive director of Suncrest Valley Vineyard, wanting to see *me* wasn't a good thing. We'd only ever talked briefly, when I was hired. She hadn't even been part of the interview process.

"Maybe she wants to give me a raise," I said.

"Probably," Vicky said. She sounded a lot more sarcastic than my original joke.

I headed to her office knowing what the score was. This was it. This was my deadman walking moment, on the way to the gallows. When I entered the room, Will's father and Adelaide Marx's husband, Mr. Marx was also there. Not good.

"You wanted to see me?"

Hannah Horton was in her late forties or early fifties. A handsome woman with dark hair and a no-nonsense attitude. She didn't look happy. "I don't know what to say, Nathan."

My face was already burning when I'd entered, but it somehow grew hotter under her scrutiny. "Did I do something wrong?"

"You fucked my wife," Mr. Marx said. He looked angry, but there was something off about his face, like he took delight in making the accusation.

Horton winced.

"I'm... I'm sorry. It just happened. She came onto me—"

"So it was my wife's fault?" He cut me off, and while the words were full of passion, again, it didn't feel like anger fully directed at me. More like a man delivering lines in a community play.

"No, no, of course not. Just that... I never forced her." I glanced at Hannah. She needed to believe me. "I'd never do that."

"Did you like it?" Mr. Marx pressed. "Did you like fucking my *wife*?!" His voice rose. His breathing grew heavier.

"You're fired," Hannah said before things could spiral even more. "Effective immediately. Pack your things and go."

I nodded. "I'm sorry. I never meant to—"

“Just get the fuck out of my office, Nathan.” She was pinching the bridge of her nose. Whether she knew that I’d gotten caught up in this couple’s schemes or not didn’t matter. As I was leaving, I heard her say to Mr. Marx, “Suncrest Valley offers our sincerest apologies. As discussed, we’ll discount the...”

And I was away. I had to wonder if this was all some elaborate plot to get a 20% discount. Seemed a little too convoluted, though. I was just a plaything in this couple’s kink.

“How Did it go?” June asked. She was waiting for me in my room.

“Fired.”

“What the fuck? You didn’t do anything. It’s not your fault that their son brought your ex-girlfriend here.”

Right. She didn’t know about me and Mrs. Marx. No one did. I felt deeply ashamed by it. “Life’s not always fair,” I mumbled.

“I’m going to go to Horton. This is fucked.”

“It’s okay. It’s... it’s fine.”

“How can you say that?”

“Because... because at the end of all of this, Morgan’s back.”

“You mean that?” It was Morgan, speaking from the entrance to my room. She took in how close I was standing to June with a quick glance, then looked right back at me. My ears burned.

“Oh, hey.”

June rose. “I’ll give you two some privacy.”

On her way out, though, she looked at Morgan directly. “He may have flaws, but he’s a good one. Don’t hurt him, or I’ll be after you.”

“I know,” Morgan said quietly. “And I won’t.”

June didn’t look fully convinced, but gave us our space after saying, “Don’t leave without saying goodbye.”

“You’re leaving?” Morgan asked when we were alone.

“Yeah. They fired me.”

Her eyes went wide. “For last night?”

“For...” I hesitated. I had no idea how she’d handle my confession, but I needed to tell it. If we were going to try again, I needed to put as many of the cards on the table first. “I fucked Will’s mom.”

“Wait, what?” Her eyes went even wider.

“It wasn’t planned, but she came on to me and told me about how Will was going to propose and I was out of sorts and then...” I rubbed the back of my neck, surprised that my fingertips didn’t come away singed. I flinched as I looked at her. “Then I fucked her.”

She stared at me, her eyes flicking back and forth as she processed it. Then she was laughing. And I was laughing. And we were laughing together at the absurdity of the moment.

“You fucked Will’s mom?”

“I did.”

“Wow.”

“So you’re not upset?” I asked.

“Honestly, I’m not sure what I am.”

“I’m pretty sure that her husband was okay with it, too. Like, they have some kind of arrangement.”

“No shit. Really? That’s... kinky.”

“Didn’t stop him from going to my boss and having me fired, though. That’s probably because of last night.”

“Because of me,” Morgan concluded. “I’m so sorry that you got caught up in this.”

“I’m not.” Deep breath. “Like I was saying to June before you so rudely eavesdropped,” I said with a grin. “It was worth it to get you back.”

“A phone call would have been easier.”

“But a lot more boring.”

She caressed my face. “You’re definitely not boring, Babe.” She hesitated. “I... I don’t want to be apart anymore.”

My heart swelled at her words.

“Maybe I can transfer,” she went on. “There are a ton of schools in Los Angeles. UCLA has a decent program, and—”

“And it’s definitely nothing compared to Johns Hopkins. Plus, I’m pretty sure you missed the application deadline.”

“So I’ll take a year off.” She drifted closer. “Get things sorted out.”

“You’re not someone who quits on a thing. That’s usually my deal.” We shared a quiet chuckle.

“I’m not quitting. I just... I want to be closer to you.”

“Stay. Finish up your thing. I’ll come to you.”

“Oh, Nathe. You’d do that?”

“There are a ton of teaching jobs in the Baltimore and DC area. Just give us a year, and I’ll be there.”

Morgan had stopped. She turned to me. “Okay. But... but not like before. Not like London, or after graduation.”

“I’m not asking you to do that—”

“No, you’re not. But it’s what I want. It’s what I need. I... I want to be together now. I want to tell people that you’re my boyfriend—that I *have* a boyfriend.”

The more she spoke, the broader my smile got. “I like that.” I pulled her close. “I really like that.”

“This isn’t a goodbye,” she said, brushing my face. “This isn’t an ending or a pause or a break. This is a new beginning.”

I leaned in for a tender kiss, pouring all my love into it. Morgan melted against me, returning the kiss just as passionately.

“I... I love you, Nathan,” she whispered against my lips.

“I love you, too, Morgan. So much.” Another kiss, brief but no less loving. “A year. We can do this. And then we’ll be together, for real this time.”

We kissed once more before reluctantly breaking apart. Morgan took my hand, squeezing it tight. “I can’t wait,” she smiled, eyes bright—for this moment, for the future, for us.

PART III

MED SCHOOL

I pulled into a parking spot near Morgan's apartment in east Baltimore, finding a street spot just a block away from her place. The humid September air pressed against the windows, making the inside of the car feel stuffy despite the air conditioning. It was a far cry from SoCal, but at least summer was mostly behind me.

A full year had passed since Suncrest Estates. The year hadn't been the easiest, but both of us made a concerted effort to stay in touch this time. We FaceTimed, we tried to talk most nights. She visited me for a few days at Christmas and New Years before she had to get back to her coursework, and once again when I graduated. That was a great day, having my family *and* Morgan there. It was a taste of what the future could hold.

The summer had spoiled us. I'd gotten a teaching job at a high school in Bethesda, an upscale suburb outside of Washington, DC, and Morgan actually took the summer off to decompress. We'd spent most of our time with one another in my group house just being a couple again. It was the first time we'd spent that much time together in nearly two and a half years, and despite my worries, it was amazing. Morgan was amazing.

But now life has restarted. I'd started preparing my lesson plans for 9th Grade History, and Morgan had already started her third year at Johns Hopkins.

It had been two weeks since I'd last seen Morgan in person—a lifetime apart after the summer, a blip when considering our history.

As I walked up to her row house apartment building, I felt an old stirring of anxiety and insecurity. The old questions had stirred when we were living apart, even this last year, even when I knew I could trust Morgan. The difference between the college version of myself and my current one was that I could manage it.

Still, ringing her buzzer outside the small apartment in Butchers Hill had me on edge. I hadn't called ahead. I decided to surprise her Saturday morning by driving up here.

When she didn't answer the buzzer immediately, though, my paranoia threatened to take over again. I took a deep breath and stepped back, taking in the quiet street, the narrow rowhouses, their brick facades sun-faded and patched in places, stoops decorated with mismatched pots of herbs and late-summer flowers. A few trees arched over the sidewalk, casting speckled shade, and somewhere nearby, a dog barked once, then went silent. It was the kind of neighborhood that felt lived-in, a little worn at the edges, but with character—like the city had settled here and decided to stay.

That was me. Or the me that I wanted to be.

The intercom clicked on before I needed to buzz again.

"Hello?" Morgan sounded tired.

"Surprise!"

"Nathan?" She *was* surprised, but not in a bad way. "Come on up."

A moment later, the door buzzed open. Like many of the homes in this area, this rowhouse had been converted into four apartments for students and recent grads. Morgan lived on the second story, and as I ascended, I was full of nerves again. Like I was meeting Morgan all over again for a first date.

I wondered if this was how she'd felt when she came to visit me after London. I could still remember that day, opening my door to see her

standing there like a ghost from my past.

“Hey, stranger,” she’d said back then. It’s what I said now, when Morgan opened the door to me. She didn’t seem to pick up on the allusion. She didn’t look like she was picking up on much of anything, I thought, as she rubbed sleep from her eyes. “Late night partying?”

Morgan was still in a pair of loose, plaid pajama pants and a Hopkins t-shirt, her brown hair up in a messy bun that definitely looked slept in. She yawned and pulled me in for a warm hug.

“If by ‘partying’ you mean spending all day in the OR as a bunch of puffed up doctors watch my every move, and then going home and cramming all night so I don’t actually fuck up next week’s clinical rotation, then yes, I was ‘partying hard.’”

I pulled back, but didn’t let her go. “Yeah, sounds like partying to me. Wild one, too.”

Morgan laughed. “God, I missed you. Has it really only been two weeks?”

“Two weeks.” I thought again of her homecoming after London, and how she’d joked that I was harboring a girlfriend in my apartment. “So you going to invite me in?” I asked. “Or do you have a new boyfriend in there?”

Morgan looked alarmed for a moment before she got it. “Oh, callback,” she said with a chuckle. “Sorry, my brain’s still waking up.”

“It’s past 11 in the morning,” I pointed out.

“Is it that late, already?” She stepped aside, and that’s when I saw the state of her room.

“Jesus, did you get robbed?”

“Oh, right.” She looked around at the mess of the place. “I wasn’t expecting you and guess I didn’t have time to clean up.”

The bed was unmade. There were dishes piled up in the sink. The counter was covered in papers and textbooks and a small army of empty

coffee mugs. This was atypical of Morgan, who was always so tidy. This looked more like my place.

I looked at her again, seeing the bags under her eyes and the weight of all the pressure that she was putting on herself. “You okay?”

“I’m okay,” she said. I didn’t believe her, but it also sounded like she was trying to convince herself of that, too. “I just... I meant to straighten up, but—”

“Shh, shh. Don’t worry about it.” I took her hand into mine and pulled her toward the unkempt bed. “Just means I can feel less guilty about messing up the sheets.”

Morgan giggled, sounding closer to her old self, and let herself be led. I sat and pulled her into my lap. It really did feel like so long ago since I’d seen her last, despite it only being two weeks, and yet things still felt so natural between us.

I kissed her, my hands traveling across her body and sliding up under her t-shirt. “You’re so sexy,” I mumbled as I kissed her long neck, nuzzling her just behind her ear.

Morgan’s laugh had a sardonic edge to it. “Please. You’re lucky I was able to shower... yesterday? Or maybe it was—”

“Oh, that an invitation to shower with you?”

“Now there’s something we haven’t done in a while,” she said.

I shared a bathroom in my group house with three other roommates, and while they were pretty easy-going, shower sex wasn’t something I was willing to do. And despite having her own studio in the city, we rarely spent time here.

“Maybe after,” I said. “Right now, I need you.”

I pulled off my shirt, leaving my chest bare. Morgan stared at it like she hadn’t seen me naked in a year. “You look good, Nathan.” She traced her hand along my shoulder. “Deltoids, trapezius, very nice pectoralis major.”

“Love the sexy doctor talk.” I tugged at her tank top. “But I want to *see* the sexy doctor even more.”

“Not a doctor yet.” She said as she let me pull the tank off. “And not very sexy these days, either, I’m afraid.”

“You’re always sexy.” But I knew what she meant. She didn’t *feel* sexy. It was my job to change that. I opened her bra next, a basic black satin one, and freed her perky tits. I dipped in and kissed her nipple, drawing a gasp. “So sexy.”

I leaned her back and crawled over her, kissing her again, caressing her breasts before dropping my hand lower. Morgan started to get into it, too, reaching down between my legs to feel my dick through my jeans. I kissed her harder, and she kissed me right back.

Things got more heated. We stripped off the rest of our clothes, frustrated by the barriers. My whole body sang as she wrapped her hand around my cock. I reciprocated, rubbing my hand over her mound, scratchy from where her pubes had started to grow back in. “I’m sorry, I’ve been neglecting that area—”

I laughed. It was so Morgan to apologize for not shaving her pussy. “You’re sexy, bush or not.”

In a weird way, the lack of grooming was a comfort to me. When she came back from England, her bare kitty was the surest sign that she’d been sexually active over there. This was the opposite.

I moved on top of her, and she pulled me close, lining me up. “Fuck me,” she whispered. “Right now, I really need it.”

“I aim to please.” I pushed home, sinking into her warmth, and we groaned together at the slippery reunion.

“God, yes, Nathan,” she sighed. “That’s feels...”

“So good,” I finished for her.

“Mmm...”

We made love quietly, reveling in the familiarity of one another. We'd been together, on and off, for nearly four years. We'd made love countless times. We knew one another—how to please, when to push, when to draw things out. It was a good, satisfying fuck. Nothing mind-blowing, but still exactly what we both needed.

After, lying naked in one another's arms, we chatted about the last two weeks like old friends. I told her about the school I was teaching at, how the kids seemed good, for the most part, and how it was their parents that were the hardest to deal with.

Morgan went on about how different school was from the first two years, which were mostly spent in classrooms. "This is the part where all those classes and tests become real. It's, like, really scary, honestly."

"That's the whole point though, right?"

"Yeah, just... it's one thing to read about stitching up an incision. Totally different to have to do it."

"So you're already... doing surgery?"

"Not really. I'm not even an intern. I'm like the intern's intern. I do the grunt work. Take notes. Recite proper procedures—and get yelled at if I don't say it exactly right." She sounded bitter at that. "I've been doing a rotation in the ER, so sometimes they need help doing really basic stuff. But even that is, like..."

"Scary," I finished.

"If I mess that up, it's a real person."

"You did it all the time on, what, dead bodies?" I always found that to be the most creepy thing.

"Yeah, and a cadaver doesn't wince when I fuck it up." I could hear the stress started to rebuild itself as she talked about it, and diverted.

"You're just getting into the rhythm of a new thing. Give it some time. You'll be great."

"Thanks."

Morgan didn't sound so sure.

“O h, fuck me!”

“Uh! Uh! Take it! Tell me you love it.”

“I love it. I love your big, fucking dick, Jeremy!”

“Tell me I’m the best you’ve ever had, my little slut!”

“Oh, Jeremy! Oh! Oh! Mmm...”

It was like a nightmare, waking to that for the last few mornings—the sounds of her moans, the slap of skin on skin and the rattle and squeak of a bed under duress. And the name, Jeremy. Jeremy.

“Oh, Jeremy, fuck you feel good!”

I put a pillow over my head. It helped in that I couldn’t hear them. In the darkness, though, I saw Morgan in Jeremy’s bedroom back in college, on her hands and knees, getting fucked from behind. Or Morgan getting manhandled by Will, her boyfriend from her first year in med school.

I’d made peace with all of that. The past was the past. All we could control was the present, and I was managing.

Still, hearing my housemate, Laura, getting pounded by her new boy-toy, whose name happened to also be Jeremy, definitely stirred up the past. It stirred up some other things, too, if I was honest.

I gave up trying to get any more sleep and got up. The shower helped wash away the sleep and the cobwebs of the past. I was a different man

now. I had a job. A bunch of kids in my classroom looked up at me like I was an adult or something. Catching my reflection in the mirror as I got out of the shower, I no longer saw the skinny, awkward teen staring back at me. I'd filled out. I could probably pull off a tank top, I thought with a chuckle.

I ran some product through my thick, dark hair. I wore it longer now. I styled it. People now said things like, "I wish I had hair like yours."

Joyce, one of our other housemates, was also up. Which meant the coffee was already made. She was sitting by the window, head in a book, as always. She didn't bother looking up as she spoke. "Couldn't sleep, either?"

"Kind of hard."

"Your girl loves the big D."

That snapped me out of my morning daze. "What did you say?"

Joyce finally glanced at me. "Hm? Oh, umm... Laura loves a big dick? Sometimes like that." Then she giggled, realizing what she'd actually said to me. "It's probably why your room has so much turn over. I'd recommend earplugs."

I only heard half of it, shaking my head to clear it. *Your girl loves the big D*. The past was the past, I reminded myself. That said, it would be best for all of us if Laura broke up with Jeremy, no matter how much she loved his "big, fucking dick."

"What are you grinning at?" Joyce asked.

"Just wondering how long this one will last."

"One more week, tops." Joyce was back in her book. "They never last more than two."

I poured myself a cup of coffee and sat down at the kitchen table across from Joyce. She'd already gone back to her book, her ginger hair falling over her face. I glanced at my own, ready to dive into lesson plans when I saw Morgan's message.

MORGAN

Happy 24th!

The timestamp on it was nearly 2 in the morning. A past version of me would have read things into her sending me a text at that time. I would have wondered what she was doing up so late, whether there were any guys around, whether she was having fun. The reality was that she was probably up late cramming for today's formative.

NATHAN

Thanks. Good luck today!

It was early. I didn't expect her to respond. She was probably sleeping off the late night. When my phone actually rumbled with an incoming call, I was surprised.

"Morgan?"

"Happy Birthday!"

"Hey, thanks." I checked the clock on the wall again. 6:45 am. "You're awake?"

"I am. Needed to get a little more studying in."

"You *need* to sleep."

"It's fine. I can sleep when I'm—"

"Don't say it," I cut her off.

"I was going to say when I graduate. But I also have this weekend. You're still coming, right?"

We'd planned on me coming up after work and staying through Sunday. "I am, but I can come tomorrow if you want to crash—"

"No way!" Her answer was immediate and forceful. "It's your *birthday*, Nathan O'Conner. And I've got something special planned."

"Something special, huh?" I glanced at Joyce, who was still reading, but clearly listening. "Okay. But are you sure? You've been going pretty hard at school—"

"And it's all good. Seriously. Just let me sleep in tomorrow, maybe grab some pastries, and I'll be right as rain."

I could hear her smiling, and it made *me* smile, too. “Okay, sounds great. See you later tonight.”

“I love you, honey. See you then.”

“Love you, too. And good luck today,” I said. “You’re going to crush it.”

I heard her take a deep breath. “I will. Bye now.”

Joyce was watching me over her mug when I put the phone down. “Happy birthday,” she said.

“Thanks.” I smiled, still hearing Morgan’s voice in my head.

Joyce tilted her head. “Sounds like you may be in for a fun evening.” She sipped her coffee, deadpan. “Hope the renter downstairs has some earplugs.”

I chuckled, thinking of Laura and her fuck buddies. “We’re not *that* loud.”

“No, but you two aren’t quiet, either,” she said.

I blushed. It never occurred to me that my housemates could actually hear us having sex.

“Your girl’s not Laura, but let’s just say the neighbors probably know exactly when you’re in town.”

“Oh, God...” My face grew brighter. But in my discomfort, that tiny voice whispered, “*Or maybe she’s not so quiet when I’m not there.*”

Joyce didn’t see my discomfort. She just laughed. “Relax, birthday boy. Go and have your fun.”

The drive up to Baltimore wasn't great on a Friday afternoon. Everyone was leaving DC, and I got caught in the mess. I didn't actually mind it. I played music. I thought about lesson plans. I thought about a lot of things.

Mostly about Morgan. About tonight. About how different this fall already felt from the last one. Last fall, I was in class on the other side of the country. We'd just recommitted to one another, yet I still felt skeptical of the whole thing following through.

Dan and I had talked about it. I made sure to call him every time I felt like I was doing it again, slipping back into the paranoid boyfriend that I was back in our last year in college. Talking helped. Acknowledging that I had a problem was the first step in fixing it.

But somewhere between the stalled traffic on I-95 and the thrum of an old Radiohead album, Joyce's voice crept back into my head: "*The neighbors probably know exactly when you're in town.*"

And when someone else had been in there?

I shook it off, turned up the volume. No point dwelling. Not on my birthday. Not when Morgan had something special planned.

By the time that I showed up at Butchers Hill, it was pushing dinner time. I hoped that the surprise wasn't a well-cooked dinner. Morgan was great at many things. Cooking wasn't one of them.

“Hey, I’m finally here,” I said, ringing the buzzer. The front door of the rowhouse unlocked, but Morgan didn’t say anything. Mysterious. I wasn’t sure what to expect, and my nerves were bouncing all over the place as I made my way up the stairs.

At the top of the stairs, Morgan’s front door was slightly ajar, and through that crack spilled soft electronica. “Hello?” I said, pushing the door open further and stepping inside.

The room had been transformed from the messy chaos a few weeks ago. The curtains were drawn. Incense burned on the island counter. And the furniture had been completely rearranged. The IKEA armchair that had always sat off to the side was now positioned right in the center of the room, and one of the end tables had been pulled up beside it. On the end table was a short glass filled with a large ice cube and some amber liquid. Beside it, a bottle of Bourbon. The ice cube was still frozen.

Sit, read a note on the chair. I looked around for a camera. I looked around for some clue as to what was going on.

Then I sat.

“Happy Birthday.” Morgan’s soft voice drew my attention away from those shelves.

I turned towards her, and my heart skipped. Stepping from the bathroom was a wet dream, a porn version of my girlfriend that had my jaw on the ground. She wore the stripper version of a nurse’s uniform—a white bra edged in red, with a little cross in between her tits, a white skirt so short that her ass cheeks hung out, a pair of white tights that ended high on her thighs, decorated with little, red bows.

Her wavy, chocolate brown hair flowed out of a white nursing cap that no one wore anymore, but goddamn did it look hot.

“I’ve been thinking... I’m not sure I’m cut out to be a doctor, so...” Her hips found the beat. “...I decided to make a career change.”

I watched her sway hypnotically as she sashayed in a wide arc around the room. I confirmed that the skirt didn't quite cover her ass, and between the red band at the top and the red band at the bottom of her bra was the full swath of her lean, flat tummy. A silver caduceus hung from her belly piercing.

"Uhh... okay." I was slow on the uptake as she positioned herself in front of me, between the bookshelf and my seat in the armchair. "So nurse?"

Morgan's sultry facade cracked for a moment. That smile was electric. That smile was everything. "I will be right along to check your blood pressure, sir."

She turned her back to me and bent forward, pushing her ass out as she grabbed the shelf in front of her. I watched that short, white skirt rise, giving me a glimpse of her white panties nestled between her cheeks. Off of the shelf, she picked up the stereo remote and turned up the music. Looking over her shoulder, she winked.

Then, because she was Morgan, she cracked up before getting herself under control.

It didn't break the mood. Not even a little. A stampede of buffalo could have raged through the living room, and if Morgan was still wearing her sexy nurse costume, I would still be enraptured.

That's when she started to really move to the music. I'd seen her dance at house parties and the occasional club that we'd gone to. I knew that she loved to dance. I just didn't know that she could dance like *this*—slow, sensual, a panther on the prowl.

In time with the languid bass of the music, she approached. My vision narrowed even more. I saw nothing but the vixen she was projecting. I saw skin. I saw tits. I saw her long, long legs.

And then she was upon me, a knee between my thighs, her body sliding along mine. She smelled spicy and new. Her skin seemed to glitter. She

moved in, as if for a kiss, but her lips glanced away at the last moment, and my vision was filled by her cleavage. She smelled amazing, her perfume unfamiliar and intoxicating.

When I put my hands on her hips, caressing her narrow waist, she pushed away and wagged her finger in my face. “Uhn-uh-uh, no touching.”

This time, she didn’t laugh at the silliness of the roleplay. Nothing about this was silly. Not anymore.

She leaned closer, her ear right up against mine. “Only I get to touch.”

A moment later, I felt her hand against the front of my pants, tracing my bulge. I swear I almost came on the spot. Who was this woman?

It was like she read my mind, saw my question, and it amused her. She grinned as she turned away from me, sinking her ass into my lap as she rippled her upper body, out and up. Reaching between her shoulder blades, she unsnapped her nursing “top” and let it fall forward, collecting it against her chest.

In one fluid motion, she was back on her feet, hips and shoulders swaying. My mouth was dry. I remembered the glass of booze that she’d left at my side, and almost gulped it down at once. I played it cool, though, remembering my role as patron. I took a deep breath and slowed things down, sipping the chilled bourbon as I watched this hottie move.

She turned, holding the bra over her tits for a teasing moment longer before letting it drop away. I’d seen those breasts countless times, and yet this felt completely new. Had they always been so perfectly shaped? Her skin was like alabaster, her nipples small and erect and tawny.

Then she was back on me, touching, rubbing, gyrating in my lap. She was good at this. Too good. I began to wonder, but my brain wouldn’t let me go there. Not when she ran my face between her breasts. Not when she wiggled out of her short excuse for a skirt.

I finally saw the panties that I’d only caught glimpses of—a white g-string, nothing more than three straps that intersected in a T just beneath her

tailbone, leaving nothing to the imagination. There were her taut butt cheeks, shaped like an inverted heart. There were the dimples of her lower back. There was the gap between her thighs and her mound that the g-string just barely covered.

Morgan relaxed into me, draping her hair over one shoulder, splaying her legs the way a real stripper would. She collected the bourbon from my hand and tipped the rest of it back into her mouth. Even watching her throat muscles swallow the liquor was fucking erotic.

From this angle, I could see the full sweep of her body, from the peaks of her tits down the flat plain of her stomach. I wanted to push my hand beneath that g-string, rules or no rules. But that also gave me an idea on how to bend them.

I reached into my pocket and pulled out my wallet, retrieving a one-dollar bill. Folding it in half, length-wise, I held it up in front of her. “A tip?” I asked.

She smirked, running her hands down her body—a journey I wished I could take—before tugging at the side of the g-string. I slipped the bill into the band, but not before catching sight of her mound, smooth and silky once more.

“A dollar, huh?” She slithered off of me, turning on her way down to her knees. She pushed open my thighs and stared up at me. “That’s not going to get you far.”

I swallowed hard. She was no longer my girlfriend. I was completely enthralled by the stripper fantasy—to the point where I felt guilty for doing this behind Morgan’s back. “I... uh... have a girlfriend.”

Morgan seemed to gasp herself at that, her red painted lips parting, her eyes dilating as she, too, succumbed to the roleplay.

“It’s okay,” she said, eyes wide. My heart rattled. My breathing was too short. She lowered her voice even more, tipping her head forward so that she had to look up at me through her lashes. “No one will tell.”

My hand shook as I reached back into my wallet and pulled out a twenty. “You’re very... pretty,” I stuttered.

“Mmm...” She took the twenty from me and set it on the side table, beside the bottle of bourbon. “We can do better than just ‘pretty.’”

She pressed her hands against the insides of my thighs, opening them wider. Her eyes clung to mine, dark and wide in the dim lighting. Right up until she ran her hands over the front of my pants, tracing my erection—then her focus shifted to my excitement with a bit of her own.

“Very nice,” she purred. “I love a nice, big cock.”

My gut fluttered. I blushed *for* Morgan, thinking of the sweet and innocent girl I’d met in that lecture hall, and yet that’s what made this whole thing so electrifying. I hadn’t felt this amount of emotional whiplash since that first day that Morgan had shown up at my door after England.

She slid back up my body again, pressing her tits against the outline of my dick. Her shoulders and hips continued to sway and rock to the music, slowly, hypnotically. This was a dance, a performance, and she never forgot it.

I retrieved another twenty dollar bill and held it up as she crawled into my lap. “That for me?” she asked, plucking the bill from my fingers and setting it down with the other. “I normally expect a bigger tip for a blowjob, but I heard it’s your birthday, so...”

She unzipped my fly without taking her eyes from me. I wanted to kiss her, but knew that somehow, it was taboo. “Happy birthday,” she mouthed before sliding again to the floor. She opened my pants and fished out my cock, her body still undulating to the music.

“Very nice, birthday boy.”

I held my breath as this vixen wrapped her lips around my dick and started to bob. It felt unreal. Morgan was always good at giving head—especially after her year abroad—but something about this situation, and the

time apart, combined to make the sensation of her lips and tongue and throat on me feel even better.

Or maybe Will had given her something big and hard to practice on during that first year apart. Maybe he still was—

“Fuck!”

I started coming before I could hold back, even as my jealousy closed around me like a house on fire. Morgan didn’t flinch. She just wrapped a hand around the base of my dick, tightened her lips, and swallowed.

But the music hadn’t stopped, and the stripper show wasn’t over. “How much more do you have in your wallet?” Her voice was throaty from all the action, and easy to believe that this was someone else.

“Uh, like... another fifty.”

“Good enough. Give it to me and we’ll make this a truly memorable birthday.”

I couldn’t get the cash out of my wallet fast enough. A smile slipped across her face—an amused-Morgan kind of smile rather than a sultry vixen one. It was there and gone as soon as the money exchanged hands.

“Now,” she said, slowly jerking my softening dick. “Does your girlfriend do this?”

She pressed my cock against my body, opened my legs wider, and lowered her face. Now I knew I was dreaming. Now I knew that soon I’d wake up, alone in my group house with a mess in my shorts.

But I didn’t, and Morgan lifted my balls higher as she moved her tongue down across my asshole. It was so shockingly unexpected. I was erect faster than it takes for a lightbulb to switch on. Her soft, wet tongue ignited me.

“Uhhnn fuck!” I seized up. She didn’t stop. She didn’t pull away. This wasn’t some gimmick. Morgan Carrington was licking my anus as she started to jack my just drained dick, and I was rock hard once again.

This was definitely a new trick, but was it new to her? And where had she learned it?

Satisfied that I was hard and my erection wasn't going anywhere, she moved her mouth back to my dick, giving it a few sucks before running her body along me as she rose.

She shimmied over me, and the lapdance resumed. She teased me as she stretched out the g-string, before finally bending at the waist and drawing it down her long legs.

She was definitely wet. This stripper fantasy wasn't just getting to me. I reached out to touch her hips, but she redirected them back to the armrests of the chair. "No touching, sir," she giggled. But at the same time, she collected my cock in her hand and crawled higher up my body. "Only I get to touch, remember?"

Facing me, her tits in my face, she lowered herself onto my dick. I slid inside with ease, her pussy drooling over my balls. She shuddered, at last losing time with the music. At last, we were Morgan and Nathan again, and when I ran my hands up her back, she didn't protest.

"Oh, Nathan..." Morgan groaned, rolling her hips in my lap, her knees dug into the back of the chair on either side of me. "Oh, that's so... mmm..."

Only maybe some fantasy was still going on behind Morgan's eyes. She used me, riding me like a toy as I feasted on her nipples. "Yes! Yes, that's so... ah!"

I squeezed her ass, guiding her along my cock. She moaned even louder at that, quickly falling into the driving rhythm that I set. "Yes! Yes! I'm close. So close!"

"Come on my lap, and I'll make sure you get an extra large tip." I don't know why I said it. You ask me in the sober light of morning to say those same words and my face would flare up with embarrassment. But it felt like the right thing to say here.

Moreso, it seemed to drive Morgan over the edge. She slammed her hips down into me one last time, grinding our pelvises together, and came with

her head thrown back and her fingernails pressed into my shoulders.

I held her close as she came down from her climax, shivering and shuddering as I throbbed, still hard, deep inside her.

“You know what? Maybe you really should consider a career change. I think you’d make a pretty good... nurse.”

Morgan laughed. She nuzzled against me and breathed me in. “I love you so much, Nathan.”

“I love you too. You’re full of surprises.”

“So you liked your birthday present?”

I picked up the bottle of bourbon and pretended to read the label. “It’s not bad.”

She playfully patted my shoulder.

“I loved it,” I said. “Like, OMG loved it. Where did you get this stuff?”

“I’m borrowing the shoes. The rest, Amazon, baby.”

“Well, now you have something for this Halloween.”

Morgan laughed. “There’s no way.”

And yet, back in those horrible months when I’d broken up with her and she’d hung out with Jeremy and Cassidy and that crew, she *had* worn something not much different—a slutty angel in booty shorts and a bralette. I never told her that I saw that, and she has never admitted to it.

And that was kind of the problem.

Moving to the bed, I couldn’t help myself. Not as I watched Morgan, sitting on the edge of the bed, unrolling those bow-topped, white stockings one at a time. The angle, her pose—both feet on the floor, with one leg extended, the other bent toward the bed—the dim lighting, it looked more like an artistic nude than a snapshot from my own life.

When she joined me under the covers and I slipped my arm around her, she was back to being the Morgan I thought I knew. Except that she’d forgotten to take the nursing hat out of her hair.

I pulled it off, this cheap, white headband with a red cross on the crest. Her hair spilled free, loose coils of warm brown. Looking at the hat, I said, “That was so... amazing.”

Morgan actually blushed, despite it all. It’s what I loved so much about her. She kissed me sweetly, her hand moving between my legs. I was still mostly erect.

“Just where did you learn to dance like that?” I asked. “You’re not *actually* moonlighting as a stripper, are you?”

“Yes. I decided that the few hours of free time I could carve out each week was making me soft, so I applied at the Penthouse Gentlemen’s Club.”

I traced the lines of her body. “It’s definitely paying off.”

“Please. I barely have time to get a jog in anymore. I’m in the worst shape of my life.”

This was so fantastically far from the truth. “Are you kidding? You look amazing.” But I saw her descending into her dark, self-defeating place again. I fingered her navel piercing. The twin snakes of the caduceus were warm. “But seriously, for someone who’s never been to a strip club, you were amazing.

“Who says I haven’t been to a strip club?””

“Really?”

She went bright red and hid her face in her hands.

“No way.” I continued to stare at her in disbelief. “You? A strip club? Weren’t you all against female exploitation and women’s lib and stuff?”

She seemed to take comfort in my totally ignorant statement, dropping her hands. “First of all, I’m still ‘against female exploitation,’ and you should be, too. And secondly, it’s such a male-dominant worldview to think that just because a girl takes her clothes off for money means that they’re being exploited.”

“Okay.” All I really heard was that she wasn’t denying that she’d visited one. “So when did you do this?”

I knew the answer, though. “London. Cass dragged me along on a lark with some of our other friends.”

“Did you... did you get a lapdance?”

“I... did.” This wasn’t comfortable for her, but it was so exciting for me.

“I have an idea for a birthday present for next year...”

“I don’t think I want to see a stripper crawl all over my boyfriend.”

“It’s okay. I’d be willing to just watch.”

She tugged on my cock. “Come here, you. You can watch me any day.”

And with that, she straddled me again, and talk of strip clubs—and London—faded away.

I WOKE to the faint hum of traffic outside the window, the early light slanting pale and thin across the ceiling. Morgan was still curled beside me, but facing away now, her breathing uneven. When I brushed my hand along her side, she shifted under the covers, letting out a soft groan.

Deciding to let her sleep, I slipped out of bed and padded into the kitchen area. Her place was small, not even a one-bedroom, so I tried to remain quiet as I fixed the coffee.

Either I wasn’t successful, or she was drawn to the aroma, because she stirred to life as the coffee brewed. “What time is it?” she asked, voice hoarse.

“Little after eight.” I went over to her and kissed her shoulder. “We wore each other out last night.”

That earned the faintest smile. It was true. She was insatiable—especially for someone who was up late the night before and early that morning studying.

“You’re amazing, you know that?” I told her. “I’m never taking you for granted.”

“Oh please,” she said, burying her face back into the pillow. Muffled, she said, “How about you start by bringing me a cup of that coffee.”

I hopped up. “Of course.”

I found a carton of oat milk creamer, despite Morgan drinking her coffee black these days. “This for me?” I asked. She didn’t stir from her bed. I opened it, smelled it, and poured some in before returning to the bed with our mugs.

I set hers down on the table beside the bed and heard Morgan mumble, “*That’s the stuff.*”

It was funny. Back when we were dating in undergrad, she was always the first to rise, a true morning person. Even after a late night of drinking. The glimpse of her in Napa last summer was the same. Even over *this* summer, when she stayed at my Bethesda place, she was up with Joyce. Now she could barely roll over to drink her coffee.

I sat on the end of the bed, crossed legged, sipping my own. Her discarded “nurse” skirt half hung off the edge. I picked it up. “Okay, so tell me more about you getting a lapdance.”

Morgan let out a low chuckle, but it sounded thin. “Not much to tell.” She sipped at her coffee, hissing as it burned her tongue a little. “It was like one song. We were drinking. I don’t know.” She rubbed her temples. “Sorry, my brain’s kind of mush right now.”

“No worries. Drink your coffee. I’m going to go pick up some food.” I kissed her. “Then maybe we can pick up where we left off last night.”

She smiled wanly and sipped her coffee again. Her blinks were slow, her eyes unfocused. I swear, at any moment, she was about to fall asleep.

I told myself it was just the grind of third year. Stress. Long hours. No big deal.

Still... last night, she'd been electric. Lit up. This morning, she felt a little... far away.

I shook it off. I wasn't going there again, I reminded myself. I wasn't that guy anymore.

The first half of the year flew by—first quarter grades were due, preliminary testing for the state was in, and I was neck-deep in lesson planning. Morgan was working through her clinical rotations. She'd moved on from emergency medicine, which seemed very stressful, to surgery, which *also* sounded like a lot, but she seemed to enjoy it more.

We tried to see one another every weekend. I'd drive up or Morgan would drive down, we'd spend the night together, we'd be a couple. Most times, our time together involved Morgan studying on her computer and me going over my lesson plans or grading papers, but we were *together* and it was amazing.

In between those weekends together, we'd text, we'd call, we'd stay connected. She'd leave me fun messages at random late hours for me to read when I woke up. Sometimes these messages would contain pictures of her—all safe for work, despite me trying to get her to send me something racier. Just photos of her making funny faces. Always made me smile.

When she texted:

MORGAN

Guess who moved to Baltimore!

She didn't wait for me to guess.

Cassidy!

I wasn't sure how to process it. Cassidy represented a phase in my life that I wasn't proud of, and a side of Morgan that I still didn't fully know: London. That time that we were apart. At least, the *first* time. Cassidy was a fun girl, blonde, striking, outgoing. I'd only met her a few times, but she seemed like the kind of person who enjoyed being at the center of a storm.

And apparently she'd taken Morgan along to a strip club. So that's fun.

NATHAN

That's a funny coincidence!

I added the exclamation point because I didn't want Morgan to read any kind of tone or accusation. I was the new me, and it was actually nice that Morgan would have another friend in Baltimore. Since medical school, I didn't get the feeling that she socialized all that much.

And there *was* this other part of me that *really* liked the idea of Cassidy being back in Morgan's orbit. It was the same part of me that looked at a flame and wondered what it would be like to just reach out and touch it.

MORGAN

Yeah, she took a marketing job at Under Armour.

NATHAN

Makes sense to me. Maybe we can all go out to brunch when I come up this weekend.

Let me ask.

A moment later...

She's in. Fun!

This was the new me. I could have brunch with Morgan's London friends, and I was cool with it.

IT WAS A CRISP, clear Saturday morning in October when I drove up to Butchers Hill. I wanted to get in last night, but my roommates were throwing a house party and I felt obligated to stay for part of it. It was too late to drive up that night.

Butchers Hill looked almost pretty in the thin autumn light—the stoops draped with cheap Halloween decorations, leaves swirling in the gutters. I parked and buzzed up.

Morgan’s voice came bright through the intercom: “Come on up!”

She met me at the door with a quick kiss, hair up in a bun, cheeks flushed like she’d just run a mile. She pulled me in for a saucy kiss, and I could taste the coffee on her lips. “You have fun at your party?”

”Would have been better if you’d been there.”

”I was thinking of coming down and surprising you, actually,” she said, letting me in. “But I ended up crashing hard. Long days in the surgery wing.”

”Oh, don’t worry about it,” I said, rubbing her arms. “Glad you got some sleep.”

She smiled and grabbed her bag. “Come on, Cassidy’s meeting us at Blue Moon in ten.”

”Blue Moon again?” I teased. “You never change.”

She flashed a grin, but for a moment, I saw the exhaustion behind her eyes. I definitely saw the bags. “Comfort food,” she said. “I need it.”

Cassidy was already at a table when we arrived—blond hair sleek, designer sunglasses perched on her head. Cassidy stood to hug Morgan warmly, then turned to me. Her embrace lingered, fingertips brushing my shoulders, her perfume sharp and provocative. “Nathan, you’ve definitely filled out,” she purred, a mischievous smile playing on her lips.

"Hey now, off my man," Morgan said, laughing as she slid into the booth. I extricated myself from the blonde's grasp and moved in beside Morgan. Cassidy sat across from us.

We ordered coffee—Morgan's black, Cassidy's some elaborate espresso cocktail.

"So you're in Baltimore now?" I asked Cassidy.

"Just started," she said. "Under Armour. Pay's not great, but it's a good company to have on the resume. And I get to hang out with my bestie, so how could I not take it? I heard you were a teacher now?"

We fell into a normal conversation, like we were all old friends. Like I hadn't had a meltdown our final year at school and broken up with Morgan because I was jealous of their mutual friend, Jeremy. Speaking of, I was curious about him and what he was up to. Maybe it was the constant reminder I kept getting of the guy, courtesy of my roommate.

But I didn't go there. I wanted to keep things normal and safe. We talked about what it was like to teach. Cassidy talked about the last couple of years—mostly how she'd partied in Chicago for a bit, then New York.

"Baltimore sounds like a downgrade," I said.

She shrugged. "Charm City, can't go wrong. Besides, my mom lives in Towson. I'm pretty familiar with the place."

We were halfway through omelets and pancakes when a new voice cut across the hum of the café.

"Carrington."

We all looked up. A tall man in a tailored charcoal coat stood at the counter, waiting for a to-go order. He wore a crisp button down shirt beneath the coat with, in my opinion, one too many buttons done. Sharp-featured and effortlessly composed, I disliked him immediately.

Morgan's posture shifted immediately—her back straightening, eyes brighter, her hand rising unconsciously to tuck stray hairs behind her ear, an

intimacy in her reaction that unsettled me deeply. “Dr. Koskinen! I didn’t know you came here.”

“Occasionally,” he said with a slight smile. “Good to see you, Carrington. Keeping up with the reading?”

“Always,” she said, beaming. Her whole posture shifted—alert, energized. I felt the old insecurities return. This was me meeting Jeremy for the first time outside of the gym. This was me seeing Will.

“Hello, I’m Nathan,” I said. “Morgan’s boyfriend.”

Dr. Koskinen turned his attention to me. I wasn’t sure what to expect when he did, but it wasn’t the welcoming smile that he gave me. “Nice to meet you, Nathan. Morgan’s talked about you.” He held out his hand. “Morgan’s got a lot of promise.”

“She does,” I said dumbly, caught off guard.

“And I’m Cassidy, Morgan’s best friend. I hope she’s talked a lot about me, too.”

Dr. Koskinen just smiled politely at that. Clearly Morgan hadn’t. “Well, I’ll leave you three to catch up.” To Morgan, he added, “Dr. Shaw tells me you’re doing well in surgery. That’s what I like to hear. Enjoy your weekend.”

And with that, he collected his coffee and left.

Cassidy watched him go, then looked at Morgan. “Okay, who was *that*? And why didn’t you introduce me, girl?”

“That’s Dr. Mikael Koskinen, one of the residents at Hopkins. He’s kind of brilliant, but, like, really intense.”

“I can tell,” Cassidy said, her eyes flashing. My gut squirmed, but I buried those feelings. “Is he single?”

“He’s married, although his wife lives in Europe.”

Hearing that he was married only helped calm my panic a little. But I pressed on, deciding to change the subject before things spun too far out of control.

“Okay, Morgan mentioned the other day that you took her to a strip club. Back in London.”

“Nathan, no,” Morgan said, her face going bright. At the same time, the blonde turned her attention to me, her smile wide. “Did she now? That’s how she phrased it?”

“Wait, you *didn’t* take her?” I said, jumping to the next conclusion. “She took you?”

Cassidy snorted and shook her head. “Do you really think Ms. Nose-in-the-books would suggest that?”

“Hey now,” Morgan protested.

“She does surprise sometimes,” I said, thinking about my birthday gift.

“Oh, I know she does,” Cassidy said. “I don’t befriend boring people.”

“So tell me about the strip club thing.”

“This feels like a story that should be told over stronger drinks than this.” Cassidy tapped her coffee mug with her long, pink painted nails. “But fuck it, I’m game.” She glanced at Morgan, as if getting her permission. “I didn’t invite her along. We were in a group.”

“Jeremy?” I asked.

“He was there, but this was mostly with this European group we’d fallen in with.”

I vaguely remembered someone talking about this group. There was one name in particular that had been mentioned, but I couldn’t remember, and it seemed weird to ask.

Peeking at Morgan, she looked very uncomfortable with the whole story.

“Okay, so you went out with the group...” I probed.

“Yeah. Spearmint Rhino after some prepartying. It wasn’t part of the plan—we were actually at a club around the corner. But when Lorenzo, who was always the instigator, suggested we keep going, well...” Cassidy

glanced at Morgan, who was staring down at her coffee, cheeks flushed bright red.

“It was wild,” Cassidy said with relish, eyes gleaming. “The lights were so dim you could barely see, the music pulsing, champagne flowing everywhere. And the dancer, Sapphire—God, she had the softest skin and smelled like vanilla and spice. You should’ve seen Morgan’s face when Sapphire leaned in and whispered something into her ear...”

I looked over at Morgan, who wasn’t denying any of it. If anything, her furious blush confirmed it all.

“So what happened next?” I probed.

“Cassidy’s making it sound crazier than it was,” Morgan said. “All I really remember was drinking way too much, Lo overpaying for some chick to rub herself all over me, and really not much else.”

Lo. Lorenzo. I remembered him being mentioned by Jeremy so long ago. To hear Morgan use his name so casually sent a shiver through me. But that was the past. All of this was the past.

“I would have remembered everything,” I said. “For that, I definitely would have been your DD.”

“Maybe we should check out the Baltimore strip clubs—”

“Okay, enough. New topic.”

Cassidy laughed. “Fine, fine. But one of these days, I’m dragging you out for some fun. You study too much.”

“I study exactly as much as I need to,” Morgan said, a little too sharply. She drained her coffee. “You heard Mikael. I need to keep impressing Dr. Shaw.”

‘Mikael’, not ‘Dr. Koskinen’. The familiarity made me jittery. Old Nathan. I wrote the jitters off as the coffee. When Morgan ordered a refill, I switched to water.

Cassidy watched Morgan quietly for a moment, then shot me a quick, meaningful glance. I couldn’t fully decode it, but it felt like a warning—*Pay*

attention. Something's off.

Morgan caught none of it. She just stirred her fresh cup vigorously, eyes already drifting back toward some invisible pressure. And as we fell back into lighter conversation, I kept sneaking glances at her, wondering how much longer she could keep this up—and what would happen when she couldn't.

THE WEEKS between my October visit and winter break blurred together. More often than not I was up in Baltimore with her, so she didn't waste precious study time on the commute. I practically moved in, keeping a set of clothes in her apartment and doing most of the cooking. It was fun. It was domestic and comfortable. Cassidy would stop by from time to time, and the more I got to know that vivacious girl, the more I liked her.

Halloween passed quietly—no wild parties this year, and the nurse costume stayed tucked away in a drawer. Morgan claimed she was too swamped with her surgery rotation to even think about a Halloween party, and honestly, I didn't mind keeping things low-key.

We FaceTimed briefly Halloween night, laughing about how domesticated we'd become.

November brought colder weather, shorter days, and more stress. I could see it building, see the weight on her shoulders. I did what I could to be there for her, playing the supportive boyfriend. She rewarded me with vigorous sex when she was done studying, or was back from a rotation, and I wasn't complaining.

We stayed in town for Thanksgiving, having a dinner with my Bethesda housemates. We invited Cassidy, who fit right in with the ragtag bunch.

By December, I was ready for a break. We both were. Teaching had a few perks, one of the biggest being longer vacations in summer and winter.

For winter break, after finishing up the last of my grading, I went into Baltimore to stay with Morgan. That was the plan until her semester was over and we'd fly down to Florida to see my family.

Baltimore in December was a far cry from those earlier Autumn days—gray skies, icy winds slicing through narrow streets, strands of holiday lights twinkling from bare trees. Morgan had survived her surgery rotations, even impressing Dr. Koskinen along the way, or so she said. She still carried the stress, though. There was next semester, and the next, and the next, but she seemed to persevere, never complaining.

Snow fell steadily, wrapping the city in a quiet, intimate stillness. We spent the day curled together in her bed, skin warm against skin, tracing fingertips lazily across each other's bodies between gentle kisses. Her voice was a soft murmur against my chest, her breath sending little ripples of heat through me as we spoke about nothing important.

"This is nice," she said as she curled up against me. "Can we stay here forever?"

"We can stay as long as you want, but eventually we'll need to eat."

"We can call Cass. She'll bring some takeout."

"And a bottle of vodka," I added.

"No way," Morgan said. "That girl is all about tequila."

"That's fair." Whenever Cassidy was around, she made me think of their time in London, that missing year, the one that began all of our struggles—or *my* struggles, at the very least. I had little snippets of her time there. She'd gone to a strip club. She'd hung out with some "Europeans." She'd seen a guy named Lorenzo.

That set my gut squirming every time. Even now, alone in bed with Morgan over three years later, there was a flutter. But it wasn't so much crippling jealousy anymore. I was curious and... and maybe a little aroused. I just didn't know how to ask it. Just seemed awkward to come out and ask: *So you fucked a guy named Lorenzo? Tell me about it, please...*

But I could skirt around the edges.

“And Cassidy was even wilder back in London. Or so you say...”

Morgan stirred against me. I wasn’t sure she would answer and almost gave her an out when she said, “Oh, yeah. She’s grown up a lot since college. But we all have, right? You definitely have.”

I appreciated the compliment, but I wanted to hear a story. “Like how wild?”

Morgan snorted. “You just want to hear about some exploits of a hot blonde, don’t you?”

“No,” I answered quickly. “I mean, maybe? Especially if they involve you.”

Morgan laughed softly, turning her head so her breath brushed warmly against my shoulder. “Okay, fine,” she said after a pause, a playful edge to her voice. “But this stays just between us.”

“Of course,” I said, pulse quickening at the sudden shift.

“One night we were at this club—it was one of those loud, crowded places, flashing lights, everyone dancing,” Morgan started, voice dropping to a quieter, almost secretive tone. “Cassidy was feeling playful. She spotted a couple guys at the bar who’d been eyeing us up and convinced them to come over.”

I held my tongue, listening intently as Morgan paused, remembering the night.

“They were cute—London boys, cocky, too, but at least they weren’t wearing football jerseys. Somehow I got roped in as Cassidy’s wing-woman, but really they seemed more interested in her than me.”

“I can’t believe that’s actually true,” I said. I wasn’t sure if she was downplaying her involvement in this story for my sake, or if she was telling the truth, but I let it go. It was nice to get something—*anything*—here.

“Anyway, I was kind of along for the ride. I didn’t want to leave her alone with these strangers, so yeah. It’s always fun watching Cassidy work

her magic. She's always been good at that sort of thing."

"So what happened?" I pressed gently, my heart beginning to race.

Morgan laughed shyly. "We hung out with them for hours, dancing, drinking, just being... I don't know... totally carefree." I heard the wistfulness in her voice, thinking about the pressures in her life now. "It got late, and Cassidy invited them back to our dorm."

"Both of them?" I was definitely getting hard at this story, just thinking of the prospect.

Morgan just blushed. "Yeah, but I excused myself when we got back to the dorm."

"Weren't you and Cassidy roommates?"

Morgan's cheeks flushed deeper, and she bit her lip. "Yeah. Cassidy definitely wasn't thinking about logistics, she was just having fun."

"So... what happened next?"

"The guys didn't seem too upset when I extricated myself. Not with Cassidy leading them upstairs, one hand in each of theirs."

"She did them both?"

"I mean, I didn't watch!" Morgan said with a laugh. "But, I mean, I'm pretty sure they weren't playing cards in there."

I thought of Cassidy on her hands and knees, one guy fucking her from behind as she blew another, but that image was quickly replaced by another—Morgan in Cassidy's place, Morgan being wild. Then something occurred to me.

"What did *you* do?"

"Are you asking if I really didn't join them? I really didn't."

"No, I mean, you two were roommates. So... did you crash in the lounge or something?"

She stayed quiet for a moment, clearly debating how much she should tell me. Finally, softly, she said, "Or something?"

Someone else's room, and not just a friend's. She would have just come out and said that if it was the case, rather than burying her face in my chest. My imagination raced, picturing Morgan late at night, hesitating before knocking on some guy's door—Lorenzo's perhaps— Lorenzo's door, nervous but exhilarated. My heart thumped wildly.

When I didn't say anything, I guess Morgan misinterpreted that. "I knew this was a mistake..."

"Hm? What? No, that's not... I mean, I know you weren't studying every second of every hour out there. Just... processing."

She had a friend in the program that she was close enough that she could knock on his door, late at night. That was significant. And then I put my foot in my mouth. "Was it Jeremy?"

"Oh, Jesus, no." The way she shifted, so quickly, was almost alarming. "We're doing this again?"

"No, no... I'm sorry. Of course not. The past is the past."

"It *is* the past. But you still think about it. You still worry about—"

"I love you, honey," I said. I could see how I was just adding more weight to her world. I didn't want to do that. "I'm sorry, it's not like that. I don't get upset when I think about those times."

"Then what?" She seemed to calm down, realizing that she'd overreacted.

For some reason, the thought of Will's parents flashed into my head—how his dad liked to watch his mom get taken by other men.

"Uhh... look, I know I was an idiot during our senior year. I made some pretty big mistakes. I'm not going to do that anymore. I've... I guess I've come to terms with it. And I'm sorry I keep bringing it up. I'm just trying to understand."

The more I spoke, the easier this became.

Even if it wasn't fully the truth.

"It just slips out from time to time. But I'm not upset about it anymore."

I saw her mouth the word “anymore,” and quickly moved on.

“I’m not. And you’re right, it’s in the past—”

“You said that,” she pointed out.

I stumbled, pushing on, even as I heard Adelaide Marx whisper, ‘*He knows...*’

“Right, sorry. I guess what I’m saying is that I’m good with it... all... yeah.”

Morgan watched me warily. “Okay,” she said, not quite believing me, but ready to move on from it.

“So let’s focus on the present,” I said. “Don’t we have some holiday party to get ready for tonight?”

Any lightness Morgan had been showing was snuffed out. “Yes, right. Maybe we should just skip it and stay in. It’s all snowy out there.”

“If you want to, but isn’t this, like, an important networking thing?” Then it occurred to me. “Is Will going to be there?”

Morgan winced. I squirmed. I trusted her. I did. But we’d been apart for a year before I moved close, and Will was close, and they’d been so close once, and—

No. I wasn’t going there.

“It’ll be fine. I’m here.” I squeezed her hand. “It’ll be *fine*.”

It wasn’t fine. But not because of her ex-boyfriend.

It was still snowing when we headed out to the holiday party. Morgan wore a navy dress that hugged her slender curves, professional and appropriate for a holiday party among faculty and grad students, save for one thing—it was almost entirely backless, leaving all the smooth lines of her spine and shoulder blades bare.

”Wow, you look nice,” I said dumbly, feeling underdressed in my khakis and button-down. “Should I get my tux?”

”Oh, stop. You look great.” Although she still floated up to me and straightened my collar and ran a smooth hand along my chest. Her eyes darted over my outfit before nodding. “So handsome, Nathan.”

We took an Uber through the snow-laden streets to the party, which was at a renovated townhouse tucked down a narrow side street in Fells Point. Everything about this place screamed money. I was prepared for that, of course. This was a party for doctors and future doctors, and I’d caught a glimpse of that world with the Marx family reunion last summer. What I wasn’t prepared for was who came to the front door.

”You made it, Carrington. I am so pleased.” It was Dr. Mikael Koskinen at the front door. I’d only met him the one time, when we were out at brunch with Cassidy, but the impression of the man remained—intense,

handsome, dominant. But it was the way that Morgan looked at him that lasted. And the way he looked at her. “Please, come in out of this cold.”

I shut the quiver of jealous panic down, even as it wondered why she hadn’t told me whose party this was. That was the old Nathan freaking out.

Inside, it was all polished wood floors, artfully exposed beams, shelves lined with art books and vinyl records. Minimal holiday decor—nothing showy, just a towering fir in one corner strung with delicate white lights.

“It’s good to see you again, too, Nathan,” Koskinen said, holding out his hand as I passed by. He remembered my name. That was reassuring. Or maybe threatening.

“Likewise,” I said, although I felt like a kid pretending to be an adult in this place. “Is this your place?”

“It’s where I stay when I’m in Baltimore, yes.” He didn’t have a deep voice, yet it was still strong, carrying an accent that I’d later learn was Finnish. “Please, enjoy my home. Drinks are in the kitchen. Food is in the living room. My house is yours, although please stay out of the basement.”

Now that wasn’t sketchy as hell.

“I’m just kidding,” he added with a smile.

That didn’t help, either.

I spent most of the party doing everything I could to rein in my anxiety. As such, I drank too much. Way too much.

The party felt different than anything I’d been to before. There were adults in the house, and yes, while I was a 24-year-old professional and technically an adult, the last party I’d been to was one thrown at the Bethesda house and ended when two of the guys Laura was sleeping with got into a drunken fist fight and the cops had to be called.

This one featured wine served in glasses and beer in long-necked bottles rather than kegs and red solo cups. People wore jackets and dresses. They talked about current events and hospital gossip. Some chatted about their kids.

Morgan fit right in. She may have still been the student, but it was me who felt like the kid. Not that she didn't include me. She seemed to go above and beyond keeping me in the loop as we moved through the crowd. She introduced me, repeatedly, as her boyfriend. She held my hand, our fingers interlaced. She said things like, "Nathan's teaching history now, and he's incredible at it."

I recognized that overly bright smile of hers. She was as nervous as I was.

"You know, you don't have to worry about me," I told her. "Just take a deep breath and relax, okay?"

Honestly, the excessive praise was a little embarrassing for me, especially since it garnered polite, but mildly disinterested, nods from almost everyone.

"I'm just..." Morgan paused to gather her thoughts. "I don't want to make the same mistake twice."

"Mistake?"

"Here we are, at another party where you don't know anyone, and the last time we did that..."

Ah, now I understood the source of her anxiety, and why she didn't want to come at all. "Hey, this is so different from Jeremy's house party," I said. I guided her into the kitchen and grabbed a couple of glasses of wine. "Here, relax, honey. Seriously, it's all good. Mingle. Don't worry about me."

Morgan looked skeptical.

"Just don't go off and smoke some hash in Dr. Koskinen's bedroom."

Her laugh was forced, but it was a laugh.

That's when Will entered the kitchen. Morgan saw him first, stiffening as she saw him over my shoulder. She kept her smile up, though. "Hey, Will," she said. "You remember, um... Nathan?"

I turned, uncertain how this would go. The last time I'd seen the man was in Napa Valley a year ago, when he'd drunkenly proposed to Morgan in a van on the way back from a show. If there were hard feelings, though, he masked them well. He'd grown a beard since I saw him, and his dark blond hair was longer, making him look even more like Thor.

"Of course I remember Nathan." It could have been said in spite, but his smile seemed genuine. He extended his hand. "I hear you're teaching down near DC?"

"Yeah. First semester."

"That's great, man."

A very sexy brunette joined Will, slipping an arm around his waist. When she spoke, it was with an Italian accent. "Introduce me to your friends, William."

"Oh, this is Morgan, probably the best student currently in the program—"

"Oh, please."

"And this is her boyfriend, Nathan. He lives in DC."

"Just outside of it," I said.

"And this is my fiancée, Georgiana," Will finished.

Fiance. Already. The man certainly moved quickly. I wondered if his parents had approved of this one, and more cynically, how many wives he'd end up with later in life.

"Congratulations," Morgan said to them both. I could see her visibly relax. Apparently she hadn't known about Georgiana, either. "That's so exciting. Can I see the ring?"

The ring—the same ring that I'd seen briefly last year—was enormous. How funny that a year ago there was the possibility that Morgan would be wearing it. We joked about it later that evening, stealing a quiet moment to ourselves in the corner of the party.

“You have regrets? No way will I be able to afford that kind of ice on a teacher’s salary.”

Morgan snorted. “Oh, please. That’s way too much for me, and you should know that.”

I kissed her. “Remember that when I finally get down on one knee.”

It was around this moment that we realized what we were actually talking about. We’d never actually discussed marriage. Neither of us were ready for that. But I guess I must have just assumed that was where we were headed, and suddenly Morgan was staring at me with wide, shining eyes like I’d *actually* gotten down on one knee.

”Uh, I mean, you know, if that were to hypothetically happen—”

She grabbed me and kissed me hard, her tongue invading my mouth before I knew what was happening. When she broke away, she couldn’t seem to stop smiling. “Of course.” She nodded solemnly. “Hypothetically speaking.”

With the Will encounter behind us, I grew more relaxed. I gave Morgan space to be herself with her classmates, and this time, she took it—although she never fully disappeared from view. I mingled and socialized. Turned out, dealing with doctors and med students was actually easier than navigating helicopter parents, and a whole lot like dealing with drunken guests at a vineyard.

I ended up in the kitchen, talking to a guy whose name I forgot almost as soon as he’d told me. He knew me, though. “Nathan, right? You’re Morgan’s boyfriend?”

Did she tell *everyone* about me? That was actually really nice to hear, I thought drunkenly. I should have asked for his name again, but it didn’t matter. I just grinned and reached for the bottle of wine. “That’s me. You know her?”

“I do. I’m an M3, too.”

I guessed that meant med school year three, but had no idea.

“How’s it going? Morgan’s having a hell of a time this year.”

“Really? She seems to be killing it. Huh.” The guy seemed amused by that. “But yeah, it’s pretty rough. Big transition. We’ve already lost a third of the class that started out. It’s getting *real* real, if you know what I’m saying.”

“Yeah, that’s what I’ve heard.”

“But hey, it’s all worth it.” He gestured around Koskinen’s home. “One day, I’ll have a house like this, too.”

“I hear it’s only one of his houses,” I said, feeling gossipy.

“Yeah. He’s got a house back in Finland. His wife lives there.”

“Tough living so far apart,” I said, speaking from experience.

“Oh, pretty sure they’re separated.” The guy chuckled. “But he goes home from time to time to see his kids. And he’s got a place in Chicago, too. That’s where his primary residence is.” He didn’t give me any room to ask more questions. He kept on talking, going on about the house again. “This is all a good reminder of why we devote over ten years to get this license.”

I had so many questions about Koskinen’s family and his personal life, but the question that came first was the dumbest: “That’s what you’re doing it all for? The money?”

He didn’t seem offended. He just laughed. “Fuck yeah, it’s about the money. And the chicks. They’re important, too.”

“You think Dr...Koskinen did it for the... chicks?” Felt weird to use that word, especially with a guy who I didn’t know. But the wine was working, smoothing everything over. I refilled my glass and forced a smile.

“Don’t know, man. He keeps things professional, of course. Can’t get MeToo’ed in this environment, you know? But I swear, he only seems to mentor attractive, female med students—your girlfriend being one.”

“He’s her mentor?”

I searched for the two of them in the crowd. They were together, as I'd suspected they might be, huddled across the room, absorbed in what looked like a fairly intense conversation, just the two of them. The little things jumped out at me, the easy way she smiled at him, the nervous flutter of her fingers as they spoke quietly. Koskinen leaned in slightly, saying something I couldn't hear, and Morgan laughed softly, ducking her head.

I felt a sharp, twisting sensation deep in my chest—part jealousy, part fascination. Morgan's posture subtly changed, her shoulders relaxing, slightly yielding to his silent dominance. My stomach churned, and I looked away, back to the guy, who'd followed my gaze and seen Morgan with the older man.

He grinned and turned to me, slapping me on the back. "What else would you call that, right?" I could think of a few things, but kept them to myself. "Nice to meet you, Nathan. Merry Christmas, you lucky son of a bitch."

Morgan looked up at last, finding me staring at her. I must have had a black look on my face, because she said something to Koskinen and excused herself. I didn't miss the way he watched her go.

"Everything okay?" Her brow was creased, concern flooding her features. "Do you want to leave?"

"No, no. I'm fine." My voice sounded hollow, forced even to me.

She didn't believe me, I could tell. Her hand found mine, squeezing tight. "You know, I'm kind of tired myself. Let's head out."

"Are you sure?"

She squeezed my hand again. "I'm sure."

I felt drained by the time we got back to her apartment, what with all that navigating the tangled web of my emotions. "Thanks for being there with me," she said, and it was at that point that I realized that she was as exhausted as I was.

"I'm glad I could be."

She fell asleep quickly, curled tightly beside me, finally at ease. But sleep wouldn't come for me. My mind replayed the evening, especially the moments between Morgan and Koskinen—the ease of their interaction, his quiet authority, her subtle compliance.

I stared into the darkness, feeling a confusing mix of jealousy, anxiety, and something deeper and darker—something I didn't yet fully understand, but knew I wouldn't be able to forget.

I DREAMT that I was standing in the kitchen of Dr. Koskinen's Fells Point home again. The holiday party swirled all around me, a blur of people and lights and chatter. I couldn't find Morgan, and Dr. Koskinen was nowhere in sight. The only thing actually *in* focus was a door, tucked into the back corner, that I somehow knew led *down*. To a basement.

My house is yours, although please stay out of the basement.

In my dream, the people suddenly vanished. I was suddenly not there at all, but Morgan was, still wearing the same classy-yet-sexy dress from last night. I could hear her heels clicking through the house. She knew exactly where to go, heading for the basement, for Dr. Koskinen's sex dungeon.

I followed, there but not there, heat built up beneath my shirt. I knew this was a dream. I could have woken from it. But I... I didn't want to.

Mikael Koskinen stood before a Saint Andrew's cross, waiting for her, also dressed like he had last night. Same tailored shirt. Same intense, confident smile.

"Right on time," he told her, looking at his watch. *"Take off your dress."*

I gasped. Morgan did as she was told without hesitation, and Mikael stood and watched with those dark, commanding eyes. Beneath, she was naked other than her stockings. He nodded approvingly at the sight of her

shaved bush because that's how he preferred her. Then she stepped forward, ready to be tied to the seven foot X.

I woke from the dream slowly, morning light pouring in through the curtains of Morgan's apartment, brightened even more by the snow. Morgan was still passed out, rolled onto her side, her hair a beautiful mess across her face.

Koskinen's voice.

Morgan's dress sliding off.

Her perfect submission.

My cock was rock hard beneath the sheets, throbbing with need. I should have gotten up, shaken it off. But I didn't want to. Not yet. Not when she was right here—soft and warm and my confusing dream still playing in the recesses of my mind.

Carefully, I shifted down beneath the blankets, settling between her legs. She'd stripped out of her dress, but had passed out still in her thong—a sure sign of how exhausted she was last night. I pressed a soft kiss to the inside of her thigh.

Morgan stirred faintly, a low hum escaping her throat. She didn't wake.

I kissed her again, a little higher this time, lips brushing the edge of her thong. She let out a soft breath and shifted onto her back, legs falling slightly open. The invitation was unmistakable.

My heart pounded. I slid the fabric down, slowly, savoring the reveal of her bare mound, already a little damp from sleep. A fresh wave of arousal crashed through me—this was my Morgan. No matter what my dreams said. No matter what anyone else wanted from her.

I leaned in and drew a long, slow lick up the seam of her smooth pussy.

She gasped, half-asleep. "Mmm... what...?" Her voice was hoarse, cracked with sleep and something more.

I didn't stop. Another stroke of my tongue, firmer this time, lingering on her clit.

Her hips twitched, a soft moan escaping her lips. “Nathan...” Her hand fumbled for me beneath the covers, clumsy and trembling. “I—I feel like shit...”

I hummed softly against her, circling her clit with gentle, relentless pressure. Her thighs tightened around me, her breath growing ragged.

“Don’t stop...” she whispered, voice breaking. There was no fight in it. No walls. Just raw need.

I devoured her slowly, thoroughly, tasting every inch of her, keeping the rhythm steady and deep. The sounds she made were fragile, desperate, her body trembling beneath my hands.

When she came, it wasn’t loud—it was a breathless, broken gasp, her fingers clutching the sheets, her body bowing under the release.

I kissed my way back up her body, pulling her close. She buried her face in my neck, breath shaky, skin clammy with sweat. Even as I held her, reveling in our closeness, that damn dream taunted me. When Morgan reached down and slipped her hand around my erection, I nearly came.

Instead, I adjusted, pushing my boxers off. We kissed as she guided me into her.

She was so warm, so wet from the orgasm I’d just given her. I pushed in slowly, savoring the way her body welcomed me, clinging to me. Her legs wrapped around my waist, her breath hitching as I filled her.

I started to move, slow and steady. Beneath me, Morgan trembled, her arms tightening around my shoulders. I could feel the tension still coiled in her body—not from the sex, not from me. Deeper than that. Worn-out nerves, exhaustion barely masked by the heat between us.

But God, I wanted her. Needed her. Needed this.

The images from my dream tangled with the reality of her beneath me—Morgan bound to a cross, Morgan moaning for Koskinen, obeying his every command. The thought should have disgusted me. Instead, it drove me harder, made my thrusts deeper, rougher.

I caught her gaze—half-lidded, dazed. Vulnerable. But when I hesitated, she whispered, voice thin and pleading:

“Don’t stop.”

So I didn’t.

I fucked her slowly but firmly, grinding deep on every stroke, gripping her hips, needing to feel her break apart again—this time for me. Her nails raked weakly down my back, her moans soft and breathless.

When I came, it hit fast and hard, my body shuddering with release, the heat of it flushing through me. I buried my face in her neck, groaning against her skin.

After, I collapsed beside her, pulling her close, my heart racing, breath shallow.

Morgan burrowed against me, boneless and warm. Her voice was a faint murmur against my chest. “Didn’t know I needed that...” A shaky exhale. “God... I’m so tired.”

I stroked her hair gently. “Go back to sleep. I’ve got you.”

I’ve got you.

I really hope I’ve got you...

THE REST of winter break was good. Great, even. Other than a quick trip down to Florida to hang out with my brothers and parents for Christmas, we spent most of our time at the group house in Bethesda. While it was clearly my world down there, I got the feeling that Morgan enjoyed the break from Baltimore and med school.

On New Years Eve, we drank too much and partied too hard with my roommates, the vibes completely different from Dr. Koskinen’s holiday soiree. While it was still weird seeing Morgan and matter-of-fact Joyce

becoming closer friends, or watching as Cassidy and Laura exchanged gossip, it was a good time.

It was the last party of the year—New Year’s Eve—and contrary to Joyce’s predictions last September, Jeremy was still in the picture. Funny I’d ever confused him with the other Jeremy from school. This Jeremy was taller, broader, Black, and built like a linebacker—about as different as it got. When I introduced him to Morgan, I wasn’t even *thinking* about that early jealousy.

That night, he wore a tight black sweater that didn’t leave much of his musculature to the imagination. I noticed Morgan notice, then pretend not to. “That’s Jeremy,” I said. “Laura’s guy.”

“*That’s* Jeremy?”

I’d mentioned to Morgan that my roommate was having loud sex with a man named Jeremy, and how loud they got. It was a funny aside at the time, but I also hadn’t mentioned anything else about him. Guess she was also picturing her college friend.

The new Jeremy wandered over with Laura, who was already a bit tipsy and grinning like she was proud of her show pony. “Hey, Nate,” Jeremy said, our hands slapping together in a bro-shake. “This must be Morgan.”

Morgan smiled warmly but kept one hand on my arm. “Hi. Nice to meet you.”

“Damn,” Jeremy said. “Laura undersold you.”

I tried not to let my eyes linger on the way her hand stayed on my arm, or how her smile tightened whenever Jeremy looked too long.

Laura snorted. “Don’t mind him. He’s had two drinks and thinks he’s charming.”

Jeremy’s grin widened. “Guilty.”

Morgan didn’t quite know how to react—not with me standing there. This was my world, sort of, and she was a guest in it. Laura tried smoothing it over, but didn’t help much.

“Please, I just told him that you were, like, crazy smart,” she said. “Going to be a doctor.”

“You also said that she was hot,” Jeremy pointed out.

“Shush you,” Laura said, tapping Jeremy’s lips with her finger.

“Think you’re going to have to make me.”

Laura grinned saucily. “Oh, my pleasure. But first,” she grabbed his arm, “put those muscles to work and switch out the kegs.”

We rang in the New Year and kept the party going longer than I was used to. Morgan kept up, too, and it felt like old times, before the med school stress, when she was freer. We crashed in my bedroom, drunk and giddy and full of New Year cheer.

“I like your roommates,” she murmured against my shoulder. “They’re fun.”

“I like that you like them.” I kissed her, let my hand drift lower. We were just starting to undress when we heard it—muffled at first, then unmistakable: the sound of Laura getting absolutely railed.

Morgan froze against me. Our eyes met in the dark. Then we cracked up, covering our mouths to keep as quiet as we could. “Jesus,” she whispered. She covered my mouth with her hand, eyes wide.

“Oh, fuck me! Fuck me, Jeremy!”

“Uh! Uh! Uh!”

Jeremy didn’t hold back, either. He never did.

Morgan looked at me, something passing between us—heat, curiosity, tension. And then we were all over one another as the rhythmic thumping grew louder. She sat up and pulled her dress over her head in one swift motion. Beneath, she wore only a black lace thong—thin, low-slung, nearly translucent. Her breasts were bare, nipples peaked from the cool air... or maybe from the attention. Or maybe from the sounds of sex echoing through the walls.

“Your friends are hot,” we heard Jeremy say just as Morgan hooked her thumbs into the waistband of her thong, revealing her smooth, glistening skin.

Laura laughed. “You thinking of her then? How rude.”

Morgan froze. I clawed at her, tugging her close. I couldn’t read her face in the dark, but she climbed over me without any more hesitation, and when she sank onto my dick, she was wet and ready for my dick.

The sounds of sex picked up again, but it was that brief exchange that lingered. Were they thinking of Morgan now? Was this Jeremy actually imagining it was Morgan that he was pounding away at. It was a picture that I couldn’t stop imagining.

Morgan wasn’t quiet, but she didn’t let loose the way Laura did. I wondered if they could hear us. I stopped caring almost as soon as I had the thought, grabbing Morgan’s hips and matching her frantic pace.

I couldn’t tell where her breath ended and mine began. And maybe, just maybe, I liked the idea that someone else wanted her. Because she was mine. And she was fucking me.

Morgan's stress returned as winter break came to an end. There was only so much I could do, only so much reassurance. When I dropped her off at her place the night before classes and rotations started up again, I reminded her that I would be there for her. "I'm just an hour away—"

"When there's no traffic."

"I'm close. If you need anything, just call, okay?"

She nodded. "Thank you." She relaxed into my arms. We kissed. We hugged. She was near tears when she finally let me go and said, "I love you so much."

"Hey, hey, I'll see you next weekend, okay?"

"Of course." She pulled herself together and took a deep breath. "I can do this."

"Just do your best."

Morgan nodded. "Always."

Always. *Always do your best.* It was sound advice not just for her, but for me. When we were together, I felt like we could conquer anything. When we were apart, it was harder to calm my inner paranoia.

Thing was, it wasn't *just* that inner paranoia. Something new had crept into my thoughts, something planted by the Marxes, maybe, or watching the way New Jeremy looked at her.

Or watching Morgan fucking Will in the gazebo over a year ago.

I thought about that incident a lot. I'd jerked off to it, if I was honest, feeling shame every time that I did. I thought about Morgan and her striptease scene, and what she may have done in London, and all the juicy stories that I was too afraid to ask her about.

The pressure was back in full force by the time I went up to visit her the next weekend. It was like we hadn't had a break at all. She'd stayed up most of Thursday night cramming for a formative, and while she was definitely flagging by the time I got up there, she insisted that she was fine.

When we had sex that weekend, it was like she was clinging to something that she knew she couldn't hold on to.

Or maybe I was just being dramatic. Probably that.

Not everything was about sex, I reminded myself. That had been the problem with the old version of myself. While Morgan worried that we were always going to live in the shadow of her year in London, I worried that I was going to forever live in the shadow of myself and my own insecurities.

At least I was more conscious of it now, three years later. That meant that I could actively fight it. I needed to prove that I wasn't that guy anymore.

Second week, when things seemed even worse, I broached the subject. "Hey, what can I do to help, honey?"

We'd planned on going out to dinner, but Morgan needed to study, so we ended up staying in. I cooked for her—shrimp fettuccine, one of her favorites—and we ate it at her island counter in the kitchen, which we'd needed to clear of text books.

"You can keep making food like this." She reached out and squeezed my hand. When she met my eyes, I saw the bags around hers. "I'm okay, really. It's just all, like, a lot. But that's to be expected in the third year. You just being here helps."

And you not freaking out and getting all possessive on me, I heard between the lines.

I frowned, but let it go, trying a different tactic. “Maybe your mentor can help.”

“My mentor?”

“Doctor... Koskinen?” Like I didn’t know his name by heart. Dr. Mikael Koskinen.

“Oh, he’s not my mentor.” I swear she blushed. She definitely pulled her hand away. “He’s just one of the resident surgeons and advisors. “What makes you say that?”

“Just something I heard at that party. Someone said something about him mentoring you.” Heat started to build along the back of my neck.

Morgan knew me, though, and seemed to forever guard against it. “You know you don’t have to worry about him, right? You can trust—”

“I do trust you. And I’m being serious. Mentor or not, maybe he’d be someone you could talk to. I’m sure he’s seen stress. Has coping mechanisms.”

See, there, I was a different man than the Nathan from college. That Nathan never would have recommended that. That Nathan would have seen Koskinen as an even bigger threat than Jeremy.

Morgan seemed to give the suggestion some real thought. “And you’re not going to freak out?”

I thought of my dream. Of Morgan on the cross, naked and bound. I squirmed, but also felt that heat along my neck creep lower. “No, honey. Of course not. I just... if I can’t help, maybe he can.”

I am not sure why I did that. I still didn’t understand, even as I drove back home Sunday night. Why push her in the direction of a man that I *definitely* couldn’t trust? It was like squeezing out a bottle lighter fluid on a flame that I had my face over, just to see how close I could get before I burned myself.

Some people get a thrill jumping out of a plane or racing a motorcycle. Apparently my greatest thrill was seeing Morgan flirt with men who *definitely* wanted to fuck her.

Not that I really thought that she would. I really didn't. She'd proven that she was loyal. But I'd also watched her get fucked by Will, watched how much she liked being bent over and used by a man who could give it to her.

When she texted me the next week that she was getting coffee with Dr. Koskinen, contrary to my promise, I did freak out a little. How could I not? But how could I hold it against her, either?

So I did what I had always done in these situations: I called Dan.

"I'm doing the thing again."

Dan knew this story. He'd heard it before, just not recently. "Self-sabotaging?"

"Not yet."

"Then there's hope for you."

I told him about how I told Morgan to reach out to the med school analog of Jeremy from college, he told me that was progress, not self-sabotage. But also:

"Why the hell did you do that?"

"Huh?"

"Look, I'm all about you taking these kinds of steps and of trusting her, but also, I super hate to break this to you, but this does feel like a form of self-sabotage."

"Not very encouraging," I said.

"You can be supportive without trying to fan the flames."

"Shouldn't I trust her? Isn't that what you're always saying?"

"Well, yeah, we're not talking about her. We're talking about *you*. Even now, you're probably wondering whether something *is* going on or not, right? Something about the way he looks at her—"

I thought about the exchange I'd witnessed between the two of them at the Christmas party—her deference, his authority. “You *should* see how he looks at her.”

“See? That’s what I’m talking about. I shouldn’t have to be the one to say this, but it’s the way *all* guys look at Morgan,” Dan said. “Hell, it’s the way *I* look at Morgan.”

“You’re an asshole.”

Dan just laughed at that. “Pretty sure you’re the asshole in most situations. I’m just the asshole’s best friend.”

I sighed. He was right.

“Here’s the thing,” he said. “Back in school, you somehow landed a babe like Morgan, who turned out to be, like, really fucking cool. Then you broke up with her for a year so you could bang other chicks while she was away.”

“It wasn’t just because of that,” I said defensively. He was silent until I admitted: “Fine, that was mostly the reason.”

“Then, you got pissed when she did the same.”

I couldn’t argue with that.

“The unfortunate side effect to that whole thing is that now, whenever you two are apart, that’s where your mind goes. You think that she had so much fun in London while you weren’t around, why not have some fun now, while you’re not around.”

“That feels reductive.”

“But is it wrong?”

“Fuck, I don’t know. Maybe you’re right. But weren’t you literally just telling me that I’m an idiot for pushing her into this guy’s arms?”

”Ah, yes. You’re like one giant self-fulfilling prophecy. You seem to be doing everything that you can to make your fears and insecurities a reality. You need to cut that shit out.”

I was quiet, chewing on that. He wasn’t wrong.

“Look, my friend...” Dan’s voice was softer. “If you look for drama hard enough, *you* make it. Didn’t you learn your lesson back in school?”

“I was never a great student. That was always Morgan’s role.”

FEBRUARY ROLLED in cold and wet, the kind of raw chill that seeped through windows and left you tired all the time. Morgan was more than tired. When I visited, I found her half-buried in books, her coffee intake edging toward alarming. The nights we spent together were good—needed—but there was a desperate edge there I couldn’t ignore.

At first, I told myself it was the new rotation schedule—some surgical sub-specialty this time. More intense. Less predictable. But the silence still gnawed at me.

It was a Wednesday night when the message came:

MORGAN

Hey honey, weird question—would you mind if I went out for drinks tonight? A few of us are going with Koskinen. He invited a small group. Kinda networking.

I stared at the screen for what felt like a long time, heart racing.

This was the moment, wasn’t it? The kind of test I’d promised myself I was ready for. The old me would have panicked, made some excuse, found a way to sabotage it. The old me would have told her to go, then driven up there to watch her.

I wasn’t that guy anymore.

NATHAN

Of course, you should go. Sounds like a good opportunity.

You’re sure? I can skip if you’d rather I didn’t.

That need for permission was a sign that she still didn't trust *me*. That she still worried about *me*. That she was still living in the shadow of our past. She was just doing everything she could to survive, and part of that included the need to make me feel psychologically safe. It sucked that I did that to her.

No, honey. I trust you. Go have fun. Network. Text me later.

She sent a heart emoji. I set the phone down, trying to ignore the hollow ache already forming in my chest.

And the heat pooling lower.

She did text. A lot. She texted when she was heading out. When she arrived. She told me the people who were there—some others from the program that I didn't know, some doctors. She texted me when she was headed home—not too late at all. She texted me when she was headed to bed.

While I appreciated the oversharing, it drove the point home: she still saw me as fragile. I hated that I'd made her feel like she had to do this. And hated even more how much it turned me on.

Morgan mentioned Koskinen more and more after that. Casually at first: a passing comment about some advice that he'd given her, an offhand remark about how sharp his surgical technique was. Then it was stories about how he'd complimented her charts, how he'd passed along the praise the other professors had given her. "Dr. Koskinen" became "Mikael."

Time compressed. February felt like forever. I was glad that she was talking about him, sharing those details, but each time, a coil of heat and dread twisted tighter in my gut.

There were a few other drinks nights. Morgan always told me about them, and always asked first.

MORGAN

Hey honey, Mikael invited a few of us out again. Just drinks, nothing crazy. You okay with it?

NATHAN

Of course. Go. You deserve it.

I meant it. And I didn't. Not entirely.

Alone in my room at night, I couldn't stop the thoughts. I pictured them together, the way I used to picture her and college Jeremy, or her and Will. The way Mikael stood close to her at the party. The way her posture had shifted under his hand. I started wondering what he'd say to her in those quiet moments after a drink or two. How easily she might respond.

And it didn't disgust me. That was the worst part. Lying in the dark, hard and aching, I'd find my hand drifting lower before I could stop it. And when I came, I'd feel equal parts shame and hunger for more.

The next time I saw her, something was different. She was warm, affectionate—but underneath it, something felt off. Her touches lingered too long, her smile a little too bright, her laugh just a little too forced. Like she was trying to make up for something she hadn't told me.

We were curled up on her couch, a rare afternoon off, but I could feel a flicker of distance I couldn't name. "You're sure you're okay?" I asked, brushing a stray hair from her cheek.

"I'm fine." Her smile flickered, not quite reaching her eyes. "It's just this rotation."

"You've been going out with them more."

She stilled for a moment. "Yeah. It's been good. Helpful, actually. Mikael's been really supportive."

"That's great." I swallowed hard. "I'm just worried that maybe you're burning both ends of the candle, you know?"

Morgan snorted. "There are only two ends to this candle? Feels more like five." She shook her head, as if to dispel all of that. "But seriously,

honey, I'm *fine*."

She wasn't fine. I found out just how true that was in late February.
Almost too late.

Things didn't feel sustainable. Morgan was running downhill, and it felt like I spent all my time running after her, trying to keep up with her pace. We were Jack and Jill, and we were going to break our necks. At the end of February, things came to a head.

MORGAN

Hey... so there's this thing Friday night. Kind of an end-of-rotation drinks thing. Just a few people, some residents. Mikael will be there.

Morgan always made sure to let me know when her mentor—for that's who he was now—would be there. It was a good thing, yet always made my stomach tighten regardless. It wasn't just insecurity though. I recognized it as something else. Something that I didn't want to put a name to.

I want you to come. If you can.

For once, it was me who had the conflict—I was chaperoning the 9th grade field trip to Philadelphia and wouldn't be back until very late.

I called her.

When she picked up, there was a pause before she spoke, like she was gathering herself. Then: "Hey." Her voice sounded light, cheery, but

stretched thin. I couldn't see her face, obviously, but imagined a forced smile, like the ones she'd been giving me of late. "You're calling me?"

I chuckled. "Just wanted to hear your voice."

"Aw."

"And also to tell you that I can't make it to that drinks thing. I'm on chaperone duty for the Philly trip, remember?"

"Shit. Right. I... shit, I totally forgot."

"Hey, it's okay. You don't have to be so hard on your—"

"I'll skip it. No big deal."

"Don't do that. You should go. You've earned it, honey."

She was quiet for a beat. "I don't know..."

We would forever be living in the shadow of our pasts.

"Go," I said. "Enjoy the evening."

"You're sure?"

"Yes," I said, feigning exasperation when all I felt was that this, all of it, was just plain wrong.

We hung up a few minutes later, after I had reassured her half a dozen more times.

When the call ended, I sat staring at the screen, heart racing, heat low in my belly. If this was a test, I'd passed.

We'd passed.

Right?

Life took work. Morgan and I took work. Mikael—or Jeremy or Will or whoever came next—would only be a threat if I let them become a threat.

Chaperoning the trip helped keep my mind focused that day, a Friday, although there were lulls. Ninth graders were pretty independent. I just needed to make sure that they didn't do anything that would get them into trouble—and hopefully that they might learn a little something in the balance.

When I was on my own, with my thoughts, my mind went to Morgan. She'd been under so much stress. It had been there even before this year. I remembered her telling me as far back as Suncrest Estates that maybe she wasn't cut out for med school. But she'd deteriorated over the last year.

If you look for drama hard enough, you make the drama. Dan was right, of course, and that had always been my flaw, but something about this whole situation felt off. When we piled into the charter bus, heading back to DC, that feeling only grew.

MORGAN

Heading out to Halcyon.

I knew the bar and lounge—trendy, upscale, served cocktails over beers. It was so easy to imagine her there with Mikael, tucked into a booth. He'd reach out, brushing her soft dark hair from her face, tell her how proud he was of her this year. She'd eat up the praise. She was easily motivated by positive reinforcement from authority figures.

Would he take advantage of her? Had he been taking advantage of her?

If you look for drama hard enough...

By the time we hit I-95, the kids were all on their devices, earbuds in, hoodies up. The bus glowed with technologized adolescence. I had a seat to myself up near the front, and my phone out, squirming. I turned my phone over and over in my hands, waiting for more updates, but I couldn't just sit still. Something told me that was the wrong move, and while my gut had led me astray over and over, I had to trust it now.

NATHAN

Hey, I need a favor.

I didn't text Morgan, but Cassidy. Funny how things change over time. In our Senior Year, I didn't really know Cassidy, so it goes without saying that I didn't trust her. She was, after all, the same girl who'd taken Morgan

to a strip club In London and who probably encouraged her to go and have fun. Now, she was the one friend that I could trust.

CASSIDY

What's up?

This was delicate. We'd seen each other a few times since she'd moved here, but only in passing. We'd not actually talked about Morgan specifically, but based on that one exchange of heavily-freighted looks we'd shared at the cafe the afternoon that I'd first encountered Mikael, I knew that the blonde had picked up on something off in Morg's behavior, too.

NATHAN

Morgan's at the Halcyon with some of her med school friends.

CASSIDY

And one dark and brooding doctor?

Cassidy picked up on it immediately, but I couldn't read her tone in the text. She could have been accusing me of being jealous all over again, She was, after all, college Jeremy's friend. But I'd texted her for a reason. Might as well go all in.

Yeah, and I'm worried about her. She seems off.

I immediately followed that text up with:

Maybe I'm being an idiot.

I'm headed there now. Morg's been acting weird, I totally agree.

Cassidy had seen it too. In one way, it was a relief to get that validation. In others, it made everything so much harder to deal with. Was it too late? Was the love of my life already fucking the doctor?

My stomach twisted at that last thought. I tried to shake it off, but I couldn't. So I dealt with the hypothetical. If she *was* sleeping with Mikael, what would I do? Did she still love me? I had to believe that she did based on all the other signs—the way she looked at me, the way we were together, especially during winter break when it was just the two of us.

But Morgan was also a sexual creature, despite trying her best to repress that side of her. She'd let it out in London. She'd let it out with Will. I'd watched her in the vineyard, at the Edge, and how he fucked her. And how she loved it.

Maybe that's what she was getting from Koskinen. Maybe that's what she needed when I wasn't there.

I told myself that I wasn't going to be this guy anymore. I told myself that I wasn't going to be the one who checked and re-checked his phone like a jealous idiot. The one who couldn't let Morgan breathe. But the bus was dark, my brain too loud, and as we rolled through Baltimore after dark, I thought about my girlfriend out there—what she might be wearing, how she'd look after a couple of drinks, how she'd lean on Koskinen's arm as he guided her into an Uber.

Heat pulsed low in my belly.

I... was aroused, thinking about this man, not me, leaning in, voice low, palm resting against her back. I hated myself for it, for wanting the image to linger. For wanting more.

I locked my phone and leaned back against the seat, trying to breathe. It wasn't working.

The phone buzzed.

CASSIDY

Found her.

That was all I got. No update. No reassurance. But at least Cassidy was there. It helped a little.

No immediate response.

I tried to relax, telling myself everything was fine. But my phone stayed in my hand. Without thinking, I flicked over to Instagram. Just something to pass the time. Just to keep my mind busy.

That's when I saw it.

Cassidy's story, still fresh. A quick boomerang clip—shot glasses clinking, half-empty glasses, blurred laughter. A second clip—people at the bar. The camera swept past the crowd—Morgan was there, tucked beside Koskinen. Smiling. Laughing. Close.

Too close?

I watched the clip again and again.

It could have meant nothing. It probably meant nothing.

But the way Koskinen leaned toward her—shoulder to shoulder—the way her head tilted back, laughing—

The ache in my chest returned full force. Heat flooded low in my belly. I shouldn't be reading into it. I knew that. But on the dark bus, phone glowing in my palm, I couldn't stop.

I played the clip one more time. I wanted it to mean nothing. I wanted to believe it meant nothing. But the way my heart was racing—I knew better.

When I got home, my roommates were doing what they always seemed to do on a Friday night—hanging out on the screened in porch smoking weed. Normally I didn't partake. I was either up in Baltimore, or just too exhausted from the week to hang.

Getting off that bus at 11, still wired, I decided to join in when Chris saw me walk past.

I didn't really know my roommates beyond their broad strokes—Laura liked to fuck big dicks, Joyce was still in school and was something of an enigma to me, Chris was both a total stoner and the manager of the local

bank. Jeremy was there, too, big and black and always ready with a wide smile.

“I thought you were up in Baltimore with that hottie of yours,” Jeremy said.

“Nah. I was on a field trip.”

“So she’s all alone?” The way he grinned at me as he passed me the bowl made me feel really uneasy. I waved the bowl off. I wanted to be amongst people, but knew that pot would make me even more paranoid.

“Oh, stop, you,” Laura chided.

“You should go up there and surprise her, man,” Jeremy said, making a little thrusting motion as he said “surprise.”

“Should have asked to be dropped off on the way down,” Chris, the stoner banker, huffed around a lungful of smoke.

“Jesus, you two,” Joyce broke in. “Not everything’s about sex.”

“Pretty sure that’s not true,” Chris tittered.

“When was the last time you got laid?” Joyce said.

He looked at our resident college coed and said, “My door’s always open.”

Joyce just rolled her eyes.

My phone buzzed. I immediately pulled it out. A text from Morgan. My pulse jumped. Too fast. Too eager. I opened it.

MORGAN

Did you send Cass to check up on me?

Oof. I heard the accusation in the message. I’d fucked up. Again. My face burned. I didn’t know how to respond, so I ignored it, darkening the phone and slipping it back into my pocket.

“Yo, you good?” Jeremy asked, grinning lazily at me from across the porch.

I forced a smile. “Fine.”

But my pulse was racing. And my mind wouldn’t stop.

“You should go up there, bro. You should be hitting that.”

I got up, unsteady.

Fuck. Fuck! I’d made a mess of things. Again. How many times? How many cycles of this were we going to go through? One of these days, Morgan was going to get wise to me and *actually* leave for a man like Koskinen.

Who has an estranged wife back in Finland, a voice reminded me. Who’s not good for Morgan.

I headed upstairs, mind buzzing—not just from the second-hand smoke, but from everything else. Had it been a mistake to send Cassidy out?

My phone buzzed again. It wasn’t Morgan, though, but Cassidy.

CASSIDY

Things aren’t good, Nate. Worse than I thought.

My stomach dropped.

NATHAN

What? Tell me.

You need to talk to Morgan.

That’s not cryptic as fuck.

She’s ready to talk. Just... give her some space. It’s been quite a night.

That wasn’t fair. Cassidy couldn’t drop a bomb on me like that and then tell me to stay away. I didn’t go, although I never actually got ready for bed. I slept in my clothes, getting up more than once as if I was going to drive out there.

I didn’t actually sleep, though. I didn’t doze. I was wired, and I was on the road before the sun had even started to rise.

Okay, so I was reverting. I could admit that much to myself as I drove along the I-95 Corridor early enough that there were only a few other cars with me. The plan had always been that I'd come up Saturday, just not this early.

Cassidy had told me to give her space, and I had. About five hours. That would have to be enough.

Things aren't good, Nate.

So I *wasn't* crazy. She'd been acting oddly all year, and it had been getting worse and worse since Christmas.

Worse than I thought.

Something was definitely wrong. It wasn't me. It wasn't.

I often get epiphanies while on the road—especially in the mornings, when my mind was clear and fresh. Not that I was all that fresh now, having not slept, but even then, I was finally able to put the pieces together and see the most obvious fucking thing.

I pulled up outside her place just after seven. The sun was just bleeding out over the roofs of the rowhouses. The street was empty and still. I sat in the car, palms sweaty against the wheel. I shouldn't be here. Her last text to me still sat on my phone, unanswered: *Did you send Cass to check up on me?*

There was no reason to be here this early.

Except there was.

I grabbed the coffees I'd picked up, got out, and headed to the door.

I buzzed. No answer.

Waited. Buzzed again. Still nothing.

After her late night last night, she was probably passed out. She often slept in these days. I wasn't going anywhere, though, and I still had a key. I turned it in my hand, pulse racing, then slid it into the lock. The door clicked open.

I stepped inside. The stairwell was dark and uninviting. I rose wordlessly, blood pounding in my ears. Her door was closed, but it wasn't locked. I probably should have knocked, but I didn't. I twisted the knob and pushed it open, ready for anything.

I honestly don't know what I was expecting—Morgan and Mikael laughing over coffee, Morgan slowly riding Mikael in the hazy morning light, Morgan not even there at all.

But she was. She was passed out in bed, still in her dress, the sheets half-kicked off, her hair all over her face. It was exactly the scene that I should have been expecting. That should have come with relief. Instead, I felt guilt and shame for thinking anything else. And, weirdly, some deep and confusing sense of disappointment.

She stirred as I closed the door behind me, even gently. Shifting, blinking into the morning light, she said, "Nathan?"

Her voice was weak, stretched thin the way she'd been stretched thin all year long.

"I'm here." I went to her, setting both coffee cups on the table beside the bed. Her phone was there, a message waiting for her. I couldn't help but scan it. A snippet from Cassidy that made me gut lurch one final time.

CASSIDY

Call me after you tell Nathan. I'm here if you...

I wanted to interpret that in the worst possible way. But that was me and my insecurity. It was me not seeing the obvious fucking thing right in front of my eyes.

“If you look for drama hard enough, you make it,” I mumbled to myself.

“What?” Morgan asked, confused.

I sighed, sidled closer to her, and touched her face. Her eyes were sunken and her skin looked drained of color. “Just some advice that I wish I’d taken months ago. I’m sorry, Morgan.”

“Why are you apologizing? You just brought me the elixir of life.” She gestured in the direction of the coffee.

“Because I have been so busy projecting my insecurities on you that I missed the much more scary reality.”

It was at that moment that she knew that I knew. We were too close to one another. We knew each other too well. Others may have overlooked her flaws, but I saw them. Saw them and loved them. “What are you taking? What are you on?”

Morgan’s breath caught, her face growing ashen. She hesitated for just a moment before admitting it. “Adderall.” She looked away, shame written all over her face, but also something else—relief. “I was going to tell you... so many times, I tried, but I... I was scared.”

I laid down beside her, collecting her in my arms. I didn’t say anything, just held her as she blubbered into my chest. I could still smell the booze from last night, the cigarette smoke and another man’s cologne. It was almost intoxicating.

“How long has it been going on?”

“A... while. Second year, I guess, although it was pretty light at first. Just a pill here and there to help me study. Then third year happened, and things got so fucking hard. Rotations on top of exams. Everyone expected me to do so well—including myself. And you were around, and I wanted to

be the awesome girlfriend your roommates thought that I was. And, and I wanted everything to be perfect, so I fell back on... on Addies. I never meant for it to go this far, but I wasn't sure how to stop, and... and..."

She was shaking. I squeezed her harder, held her tighter.

"You don't need to apologize, Morg."

"I am a failure. A total fucking sham. I want to be a doctor, but here I am abusing prescription pills."

"Probably not the first."

"And I don't want to be lumped in with those others." Her voice took on an edge. "I'm supposed to be better than that."

Her voice cracked again, and fresh tears spilled onto my chest.

I kissed the top of her head. "You're human, Morg. You're allowed to be."

She shook her head against me. "I'm a fucking mess."

"Yeah," I said softly. "But you're *my* mess."

That pulled a choked little noise from her—half laugh, half sob. "I want to stop," she whispered. "I do. I just—I need help. I don't know how."

I stroked her hair, held her tighter. "Then we'll figure it out," I told her. "Together."

She curled in closer. "What would I do without you?"

"Have one less fragile ego to tiptoe around?"

She sniffled a laugh. "Sounds pretty boring."

"Good answer," I said. "Because I plan to keep things interesting."

We lay there for a long moment, her body slowly relaxing against mine, the shaking easing bit by bit.

Then her voice came again, small and tentative. "There's more I should tell you... about last night."

My chest tightened. I could still smell the cologne. Mikael's, most likely, and it drove me crazy inside. But she didn't need *crazy* right now.

She needed restraint and understanding, and I knew that it wasn't what my paranoid self thought it was. "Okay. Whenever you're ready."

She pulled back just enough to meet my eyes. I nodded in encouragement, even as everything inside of me twisted into knots.

"Nothing happened between us..." she said hesitantly. "Mikael and me..."

"You don't have to keep leading with that, honey. I told you, I really do trust you—"

"But it could have." She cut me off. My mouth went dry. She continued. "I'd been up late the night before, just to make sure I nailed my last day of rotation, so I'd taken... you know, a pill before meeting up with Mikael and the crew. That, plus drinks, and... I don't know. Nothing happened, but maybe I was more open to it than I should have been. I'm... I'm a bad person."

Tears formed in her eyes, and I folded her against me, brushing her hair. "You're not a bad person," I murmured.

"Nothing has ever happened between us, I swear," she blubbered. "But there's always been, like... like... I don't know..."

"I know what you mean. And it's okay."

"But it's not. You sent Cassidy to check up on me."

"I'm sorry about that—"

"I'm not. If you hadn't, maybe I would have made a mistake that couldn't be corrected."

My heart skipped. "There are no mistakes that cannot be corrected. But also, you didn't make it."

"After she showed up, that's when I started to spiral. I realized where things were headed. I... I got sloppy. Drank more, which made me sleepy, which made me reach for the pills again. That's when Cass put it all together."

Now last night's texts made sense, as well as the one from Cassidy this morning.

"You were going to tell me," I said.

"Yeah. She threatened me if I didn't. Mikael did, too."

"He knew?"

"Cass accused him of being my dealer!"

"Was he?"

"No, of course not. I got it from a few of the other people in our class. I didn't want anyone to know how bad it was for me, so I kind of spread the risk around."

Morgan wanted to present the most positive side, even to her drug dealers..

"I'm scared, Nathan."

I kissed her forehead. "Me too." It was the honest, frightening truth. "But you don't need to do this alone. Not anymore. You've got Cassidy. You've got me. We'll get through it. One step at a time."

She closed her eyes, let out a long, shaky breath.

And for the first time in weeks, I felt her really rest against me.

Morgan actually withdrew from school those last few months, just to get her head straight. At first, she outright refused, saying fiercely that she didn't quit, that she wouldn't let herself give up. But it was Mikael Koskinen, surprisingly, who finally convinced her. He sat her down gently, calmly, and talked her through the reality of her situation. He knew the right people, made some calls, and helped her arrange the leave in a way that wouldn't harm her career.

I still didn't fully trust him. I couldn't be certain that he *wouldn't* have taken advantage of Morgan in her vulnerable state, but once he learned about her drug abuse, he became very careful with their interactions, distancing himself, never taking any meetings with her in private. The happy hours stopped.

Morgan and I talked about it often in the months that followed, during long, quiet days tucked away in her Butchers Hill apartment. It felt safe to open ourselves up in that cozy isolation, gently and calmly confronting each other's fears.

"I'm sorry about Mikael," she said. "I shouldn't have gotten so close to him."

Morgan had entered therapy to deal with the Adderall abuse and the relentless pressure she'd placed upon herself. Her therapist had got her

thinking about many things—not just herself, but about us, too.

“I mean, I encouraged you to seek his mentorship,” I said.

She nodded. “Why did you do that?”

The answer wasn’t one that I was proud of, but in the interest of honesty, I gave it. “That’s me being self-destructive, I guess. I... I do that sometimes.”

“Oh, I know.” She put a hand on my arm. “But we need to take turns doing that. We can’t both be self-destructing at the same time. This year was my turn.”

It was nice that we could joke about this now.

“I’m not going to put myself in that kind of situation anymore. I promise.”

“And I’ll give you the space you need. I trust you. I need to start acting like it.”

I’d been doing a lot of soul searching on my own end, too, and I didn’t think it was only about trust and betrayal and insecurity. There was a new element that had crept in at some point. Even when I’d gone to meet her the morning of the confrontation, a part of me imagined walking in on an entirely different scene. I still had dreams of opening the door to her slowly riding Koskinen’s dick—dreams that made me hard. Horrified, yet hard.

But I wasn’t ready to talk about *that* with Morgan. She was dealing with enough.

We were still in bed, but I’d gotten up to make coffee. She shifted close, snuggling into me, and I stroked her hair. When she spoke, her voice was delicate. “Did you know that seeing you every other week is one of the few things that’s keeping me going?”

She paused. I didn’t speak, knowing she was working through some things.

“There are days when I swear, I’m just going to drop out. Maybe I should have gone for a PhD or something more academic. When you’re

gone, I get *maybe* five hours of sleep each night. When I'm not at the hospital or the clinic, shadowing whoever, I'm cramming to learn all the stuff that seems to come so easily to everyone else. I'm memorizing tables and formulas and codes. I take furious notes all day long that are mostly lists of shit that I don't know.

"That led to the addies. It led to more self-doubt. And whenever I was about to hit my true breaking point, I'd see you. And you're... you. You don't have any of that weight, and you help take some off of me. And I love you, Nathan. I love you for that. And I'm so scared... so fucking scared... that the next time you leave, you won't come back."

I almost told her that she was being crazy, but she wasn't. Because I *had* left her once. Because I *had* abandoned her once, and for even dumber reasons.

"I'm not going to leave you. And I'm so sorry for doing that senior year."

"I'm sorry I went to London."

"I'm not. And honestly? I hope you aren't actually sorry. We needed that. And we needed time apart. The people we were back then wouldn't have worked."

She nodded, acknowledging the truth in the statement.

"And besides, if you hadn't gone, then maybe you never would have experienced that stripper."

Or other things.

My cock swelled, and Morgan must have felt it.

She giggled. "That again?"

"That. Again." I stroked her hair and built up the courage to say something honest. Or at least take a step in that direction. "I'm glad that you had fun out there. And... and I'm not just talking about the stripper."

Now it was her turn to stay quiet and let me talk. I wasn't ready for this confession either, but I could get closer.

“It doesn’t fill me with jealous insecurity anymore. If anything, I’m just kind of curious about it all. Like what did you do there, what kinds of adventures did you have...”

I was getting harder.

Morgan shifted in my lap, sitting up enough to look at me with those big, luminous eyes of hers. Her hand rubbed up over my cock. “Interesting,” she said.

“Do you really not remember much about that evening that Cassidy was talking about?”

Morgan went red, but didn’t look away from me. “I remember... some...”

“Tell me,” I said.

She almost checked in again. I saw the ‘*You sure?*’ question on her lips. But I was sure, and she finally saw it.

She tugged at my boxers and pushed me onto my back. Mounting me, she pulled her T-shirt off—the only thing she normally slept in.

“We went out dancing,” she began, slowly, guiding her cock against her smooth mound. She wasn’t soaking, but she *was* wet enough that I sank into her easily. “This was back in November. It was cold in London. Got dark very early, so the night started early and seemed to stretch on and on...”

She sank her teeth into her bottom lip, her eyes going farther away, back into memory.

“We’d just finished up our papers and done our presentations. We didn’t have anything for the next week. God, those days were so easy...” She sighed, comparing undergrad life to med school. “Anyway, everyone was primed for some fun. So when Lo suggested a strip club, and everyone else seemed game, I went with it.”

I was so hard, listening to her talk, but mention of “Lo” had my cock practically vibrating.

“Who’s Lo? You’ve mentioned him a few times.”

She looked down at me, her hips never stopping their slow roll as she weighed how much to share. “Spanish guy in the program. Dad was a footballer who immigrated from Sudan, so he came from money.”

“He was the ringleader.”

“Yeah.” There was *so much more* packed into that acknowledgment, and it channeled all the blood into my dick.

“So he got you to go out. And he got you into the VIP lounge.”

“He did.” Whether consciously or not, she started riding me faster.

“And what happened?”

“He wanted to watch me get a dance...”

And she couldn’t say no to him. My ears burned at my own speculation. I ran my hands up her thighs, to either side of her hips. Together, we fucked.

“The rules are different... when that much money is involved.”

I remained quiet, listening, ears burning. For a second, I wasn’t sure if she was going to continue. Then: “The dancer... Sapphire... she was tall, with dark hair and pale skin that felt like silk. I can still remember how *soft* she was...”

Morgan leaned forward until her chest brushed mine, her lips near my ear. “She climbed into my lap and started slow, like she was testing me. Her hair was thick and glossy—it brushed over my chest, my stomach. She stripped slowly...”

Morgan rolled her hips in a slow, hypnotic rhythm, her body warm and heavy against mine, like *she* was the stripper. Her voice dropped lower—half confession, half seduction.

“She had this way of moving... like her whole body was made of music. Every sway, every twist of her waist, so practiced. I remember watching her slide her hands up her own thighs, tugging at her panties like she was teasing herself.”

I groaned beneath her, hips bucking up instinctively as Morgan moved with languid grace, mimicking the rhythm she’d described. Her breasts

brushed my chest, her breath hot on my neck.

“She straddled me,” she whispered. “Not like this—well, maybe a little like this—but her knees were pressed to either side of me on the velvet couch. Her skin was so soft. She leaned down until her breasts were inches from my face... and then she started whispering.”

Morgan’s breath hitched—just enough to betray that she was remembering more than she planned to say.

“What did she whisper?” I asked, my voice tight, pulse hammering as I filled her deeper with every slow rise and fall of her hips.

“She asked if I was nervous,” Morgan said, eyes half-lidded, her smile teasing but tinged with vulnerability. “She said she liked when girls were nervous. Said it made her want to take her time.”

She shifted again, grinding down in a slow, deliberate circle that made me gasp, closing her eyes, clearly lost in the memory.

I cupped her breast, thumbing her nipple until she arched into my touch. “And?”

“She... she told me that I could touch her if I wanted.”

I was fucking up into her, hands on her hips, guiding her. She didn’t need much encouragement. Morgan was riding me hard, squeezing my ribs with her knees, her body rising above me.

“Uhh, God...” she groaned, eyes closed as her night rolled on.

I needed to know more, though. “And? Baby, did you?”

“I... touched her... breasts...”

I squeezed hers now, my thumbs teasing her hard nipples. “Like this?”

“Mmm...” She groaned. “God, Nathan, you’re so *hard*.”

I was. Like a bar of fucking titanium. Morgan clenched around me, her pussy feeling magical.

“Oh, Morg...”

“Uh! Uh! Uh!”

She cried out as I flipped us, pinning her beneath me, still inside her. I was wild now, chasing the image, the scent, the memory she'd fed me.

"Did you kiss her?"

"Yes," she hissed, eyes shut, thinking about it maybe? Or just saying 'yes' because we were having sex. I wanted clarity. I *needed* clarity.

"You really kissed her?"

I fucked her faster, driving deep and hard. She was close. I was close. But I needed to know.

"Lo wanted us to kiss," she said, as if speaking from the other side of a dream. "So we kissed."

That's all it took. That was the trigger. I was there, lost in her—lost in the vision of what she'd been and what she'd shared. She clung to me, shivering, her own orgasm right on my heels, drawn out by the memory, the thrill, the heat between us.

Lo wanted us to kiss.

So we kissed.

I was nearly hard all over again. But I wasn't. I was exhausted. I collapsed

When we finally stilled, chest to chest, breathless and raw, she whispered, "I can't believe I told you all that."

"I can't believe it's taken so long for me to hear it." We were sweaty and so hot it was uncomfortable, but I didn't let her go. I wanted to hold her close, to reassure her that I was fine. "You know how hot that is?"

"Yeah, you've been pretty convincing." She giggled.

"So what happened after? You kissed, and...?"

"Wish I could tell you there was more, but there really wasn't. The song ended, and she left."

"What? Guy like this Lo...renzo..." Felt weird to use the shortened name of a man I didn't know, who once fucked my girlfriend. "...didn't pay for another set?"

"He... had other plans for that night." Now Morgan was blushing furiously again. "I'm sorry, I know that's all awkward to hear."

I kissed her and squeezed her close. "I'm good, honey." We were still dealing with her fears and all the pressure of life. I was determined not to make her worry that I'd go into a jealous rage and leave her just because she mentioned an old boyfriend.

She still looked at me dubiously. I wanted to put those doubts to rest forever.

"You don't have to worry anymore, Morgan. I wish I could go back in time and re-write all of Senior Year. But I can't. It's set in stone, part of our history. Best we can do is grow from it."

I could see her starting to buy it, the words truly sinking in. Her eyes were bright, but not in the chemical way that they'd been for so many months—how had I ever missed those signs?

"We'll be fine, you and me. You're going to be a successful doctor and you're going to buy us an amazing house where we're going to raise an amazing family and throw parties and grow old together."

Tears welled up in her eyes, fat and ready to stream down her face. It gave me the confidence to keep going.

"But you can't do it on your own. This isn't sustainable, and you know it. You have friends all around you. People who care about you. And you don't have to keep them at arms length because you're worried that I'm going to get jealous. You need to open up to them, okay?"

She nodded. There was still some doubt. I wanted to banish it all. I wanted her to live without fear.

"Let me prove it. I want them to come to our wedding. Bring your London crew. Hell, bring Jeremy. Bring them all."

"Our wedding?" She turned to look up at me, eyes wide.

I felt giddy. This wasn't planned. Nothing about our lives was planned. It just seemed to happen around us, and we did our best to hold on. But this

felt right.

I sat up in bed, and got Morgan to do the same. Naked, sitting criss-cross from one another, I took her hands in mine. “Morgan, will you marry me?”

Now those tears finally released, streaming down her cheeks. She couldn’t stop smiling.

”Yes,” she said, just as a sob emerged. She grabbed me and pulled me in for a kiss. “Yes, yes, yes.” She kissed me again as I laughed. “God, you’re an amazing man, Nathan. I love your vision of our future. I want that.”

It made me feel weightless to hear her say that. “Then let’s make it happen.”

ABOUT KENNY WRIGHT

Kenny has been publishing hotwife erotica for over ten years (and writing for much longer than that). He writes what he likes to read: steamy, explicit erotica that's just crazy enough to be true. He believes in a world where men read and appreciate erotica, and hope to contribute to it word by word.

More recently, he's started a community over on Patreon, testing out new story ideas and gathering feedback for upcoming releases. Come join the community and support more works like this one.

Find him online at www.kennywriter.com, on Patreon as KennyWriter, or follow him on Twitter at @kennywriter, [Bluesky](#), and [Medium](#).



ALSO BY KENNY WRIGHT

Like what you just read? Check out these other books by Kenny Wright (or browse my catalog at <http://www.kennywriter.com/books/>).

The Blonde in 3C



This one's the closest to an "origin story" as I've written. If you liked While We Were Apart, I'm pretty sure you'll like this one. It's self-contained and isn't quite the same level of slow burn, but it should hit all the right notes.

From neighbor to friend to wife to... hotwife?

Cooper always had a crush on Annika, the blonde in apartment 3C. She was friendly. She was pretty.

Best of all, she had loud sex with her boyfriend, Brett, that Cooper could hear through the floorboards. He never thought that one day, he would marry that sexy blonde.

But first impressions are hard to shake, and Cooper's first impression of his future bride was of an insatiable woman he could never fully satisfy. He was always waiting for the other shoe to drop, for a new man to take his place, for him to lose it all. A hotwife fantasy was born and it grew with their marriage.

The things that Annika did for love always surprised her, but that was just who she was. She gave all of her energy to a relationship. She'd done some wild things for her hedonistic former boyfriend, Brett. She was still trying to figure out Cooper.

When they attend Brett's wedding, Annika and Cooper are put to the test. Will Annika be tempted by the past? Will Cooper's repressed fantasy explode into the open?

[Find The Blonde in 3C online!](#)

Bull's Eye Series (5 books)



Paul Sharpe, self-avowed bachelor, works hard and plays harder—always looking for a new conquest. Blondes, brunettes, redheads, he enjoys them all as long as the pursuit is fun and they're up for a good time. He's fine being disposable. Life is simpler that way.

Until he meets a woman who opens his eyes to a whole new world—the world of hotwives and cuckolds and the games that they play. After that, he sees it everywhere. At bars, at clubs, at his company's gala, he sees men furtively watching other men hit on their wives.

Can he be the other man? Can he be the bull?

Follow Paul's epic journey over five books as he evolves from the bull to so much more.

[Bull's Eye 1: Discovering the Hotwife Fantasy](#)

[Bull's Eye 2: Exploring the Hotwife Fantasy](#)

[Bull's Eye 3: Enjoying the Hotwife Fantasy](#)

[Bull's Eye 4: Consequences of a Hotwife Fantasy](#)

[Bull's Eye 5: Beyond the Hotwife Fantasy](#)

These next two books are in another new and burgeoning sub-genre of hotwife erotica that's, I guess, hotwife thriller? I don't know, but I'm into it, and so I've written a few books (with more in the works).

In Too Deep



David hasn't seen his wife, Amanda, in two months—not since she went undercover on a dangerous, highly secretive case. He doesn't know where she is, what she's doing, or who she's pretending to be. He only knows he misses her—her laugh, her touch, her kiss.

Then one night, David finds himself in a strip club... and finds her on stage.

Seeing Amanda like this—seductive, confident, and far more uninhibited than he ever imagined—awakens a cocktail of emotions: confusion, desire, jealousy... and a craving for more. And then suddenly he's dragged into Amanda's dark and thrilling new world, where every move could shatter her cover—and their marriage.

Can they survive the lies, the danger, and the temptation? Or has Amanda already crossed a line that neither of them can undo?

Packed with explicit, pulse-pounding passion, intrigue, and a unique take on not just the hotwife genre, but the mystery-thriller genre, this is one story you won't forget.

***In Too Deep* is a two-part book series available [everywhere that you purchase your ebooks](#).**

Caught in the Act



Married seducers-for-hire, Logan and Abigail have built a lucrative business exposing cheating husbands—using charm, temptation, and each other. But their latest honey trap assignment takes them to the sun-soaked decadence of Valencia, Spain, where the line between roleplay and reality begins to blur.

Their client, the elegant and enigmatic Kristiana Vanderkamp, wants proof that her husband Elias is unfaithful. It should be routine. But as Abigail slips deeper into the game—and into Elias’s charms—

Logan is forced to confront just how far he’s willing to go... and what it means to watch his wife become someone else’s fantasy.

In a world of lies, lust, and layered agendas, everyone has something to hide—and no one wants to get caught in the act...

[Buy it online](#)

Training to Love It Series (3 books)



Can a wife-watching fantasy be trained?

When Erin comes home from the gym and lets slip that her new personal trainer is a man, Tom doesn't know how to react. When he overhears Erin admitting that she's attracted to AJ, her trainer, he becomes even more confused. He wants to be supportive, but he feels jealous. He wants to be understanding, but he doesn't even understand his own feelings. Every time he thinks of Erin with

AJ, his heart begins to race. Every time she says his name, his breath catches in his chest.

AJ ends up pushing more than just his wife's physical limits. As Tom watches this newer, stronger, more assertive woman emerge with each training session, he realizes that this other man is pushing the limits of their marriage and their happy life. How far would they go for a fantasy? And whose fantasy is it? And what happens when things go too far?

Training to Love It series